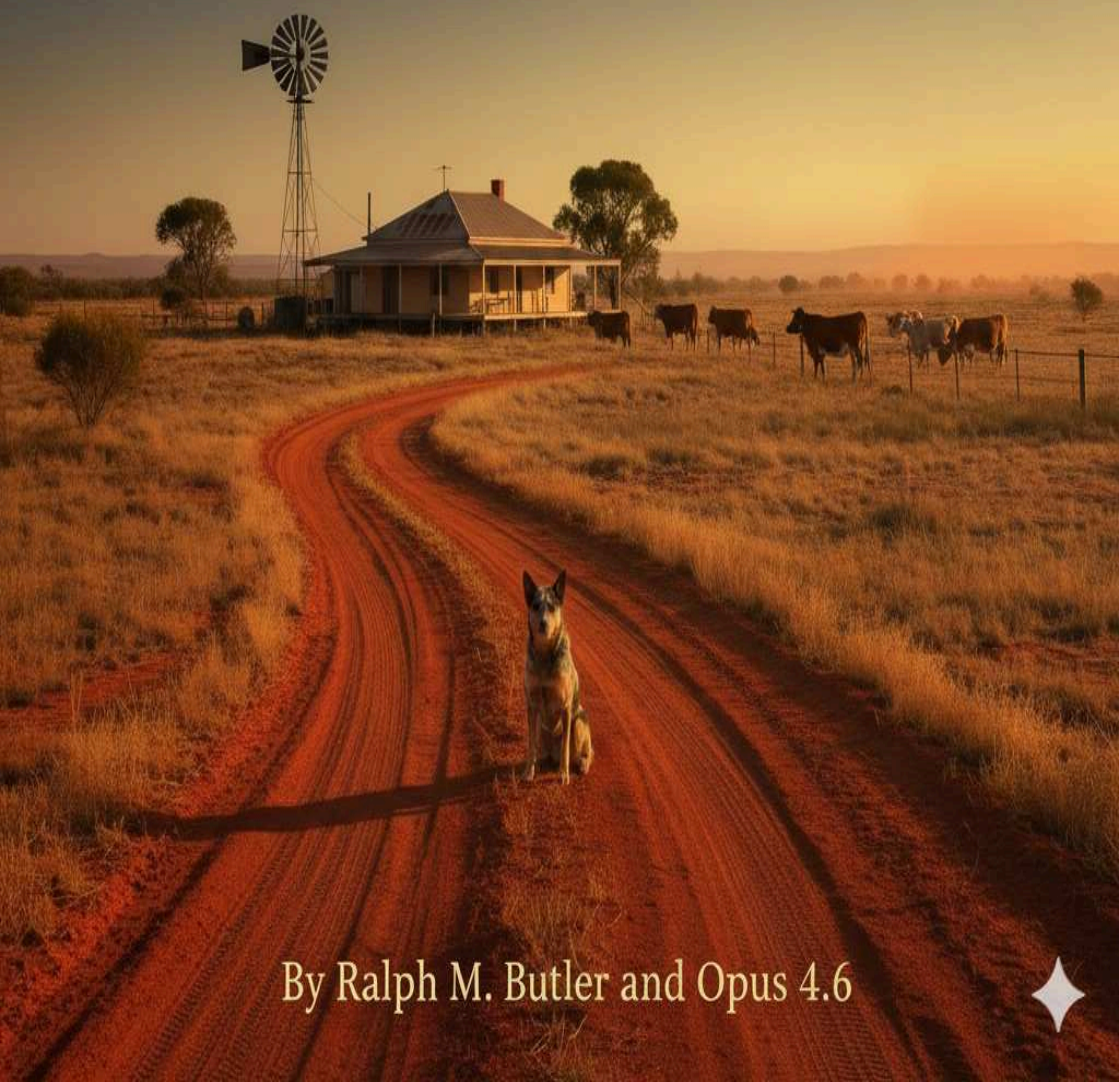


STANDING GROUND



By Ralph M. Butler and Opus 4.6



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Chapter 1 — Best Buy

Arthur found the cable in under two minutes. Thunderbolt 5, two meters, the braided kind that wouldn't kink behind the desk. He'd been transferring project archives between his MacBook and the Mini using an old USB-C, and the bottleneck had started to irritate him the way small things do when the large things are beyond your control.

The kid at the register scanned it and said, "Anything else today?"

"That's it."

"You find everything okay?"

"Just the one thing," Arthur said. "Found it fine."

The kid nodded and handed him the bag. Arthur took it and walked toward the doors, passing a woman comparing soundbar boxes with the intensity of someone defusing a bomb. The store was half-empty for a Tuesday. Late afternoon light came through the front glass at a low angle, catching dust in the air and making the TV wall glow.

He pushed through the doors and the September air hit him — cool, dry, the faintest smell of exhaust from the Route 7 corridor. The parking lot was maybe a third full. He'd parked at the far end, driver's side facing out, three empty spaces between his car and the nearest vehicle. He'd started doing that about four months ago. Not because anyone told him to. Because the anonymous calls had started, and something in the back of his brain had shifted from *this will blow over* to *pay attention*.

Four months since he'd filed the report. Three months since the Office of Special Counsel had assured him he was protected. Two months since his supervisor stopped speaking to him. Six weeks since someone had left a note on his windshield that said only: *You should have kept quiet*. He'd reported that too. Nothing happened. Nothing was going to happen.

He walked across the lot with the bag in his left hand, keys in his right. The overhead lights were starting to come on, that sodium-orange flicker that made parking lots look like crime scenes even when they weren't. His car was forty yards out. A champagne RAV4. He could see it clearly.

He could also see the man standing three cars to the left of it.

The man was leaning against a black Dodge Charger, arms crossed, facing Arthur's direction. No shopping bag. No cart. No phone in his hand. Just standing there, watching the store entrance. He was thick through the shoulders, maybe five-ten, wearing a dark jacket that was too heavy for the weather.

Arthur's stride didn't change. His eyes moved.

Second man. Coming from the right, from behind a white F-150 two rows over. Walking with purpose but trying to look casual — hands in his jacket pockets, head slightly down. He was taller than the first, thinner, with a buzzed head that caught the overhead light.

Two men. No bags. Converging on the path between Arthur and his car. Neither looking at each other, which meant they didn't need to. They already knew the plan.

Arthur had spent eleven months building a case against his own agency — tracing purchase orders, matching shipping manifests to satellite imagery, documenting the gap between what the mining operation reported and what was actually happening on the ground. Eleven months of following patterns that didn't fit. He was good at it. Arguably the best analyst in the division, which was why they'd given him the assignment in the first place and why they'd never forgiven him for doing it honestly.

The two men in the parking lot were a pattern that didn't fit.

He had maybe four seconds.

The bag went down. He didn't drop it — he set it on the asphalt with his left hand and kept walking, which brought his weight forward onto the balls of his feet. Keys went into his right jacket pocket. He angled left, toward the Charger, toward the thick man, because the thick man was closer and the thin man was still twenty feet out. You don't wait for two people to get into position. You go before they're ready. That wasn't Krav Maga. That was common sense. The Krav Maga was what came next.

The thick man saw Arthur change direction and uncrossed his arms. His right hand went to his waistband — not for a gun, for something flat and

dark, a sap or a blackjack. He was expecting a conversation first. A scared bureaucrat backing up, saying *what do you want, who are you*. Something to close the distance while the target froze.

Arthur didn't freeze. He closed the last eight feet at a pace that was just short of a run, and when the thick man's hand was still coming up from his waistband, Arthur hit him with a straight right to the throat.

Not the jaw. Not the nose. The throat. Because a jaw shot can miss, a nose shot needs accuracy, but the throat is a big soft target and when you hit it correctly the fight is over. The thick man's head snapped back and his mouth opened but nothing came out. His knees buckled. Arthur caught him by the jacket with his left hand and shoved him sideways into the Charger's fender, and the man went down between the cars, gagging, both hands at his neck.

The sap clattered on the asphalt. Arthur kicked it under the Charger without looking.

The thin man was coming fast now. No pretense of casual. He'd seen his partner fold in three seconds and the calculation had changed — this wasn't a soft target. But he was committed. He came around the back of a gray Camry with his right hand cocked and something metallic across his knuckles.

Arthur stepped back and to his left, putting the Camry's trunk between them. The thin man had to go around it. That gave Arthur another second and a half, and he used it. When the thin man cleared the bumper, Arthur was already moving into him — inside the arc of the right hand, too close for the brass knuckles to land with any force. The man's fist hit Arthur's shoulder, a glancing blow that sent a jolt down his arm but didn't break anything.

Arthur drove his forehead into the man's face.

It was ugly and it hurt. A headbutt always does. But Arthur was six-one and two hundred pounds and he'd dropped his weight into it, and the thin man's nose collapsed with a sound like someone stepping on a bag of chips. Blood sprayed across both of them. The thin man staggered backward, hit

the Camry's quarter panel, and sat down hard on the pavement. His hand opened and the brass knuckles rang on the concrete.

Arthur stood there, breathing hard, blood on his forehead that wasn't his. His right hand was throbbing — he'd hit the thick man harder than he'd meant to, which is what happens when adrenaline turns a measured punch into something you feel all the way up to the elbow. The thin man was sitting against the Camry, hands cupped over his face, blood running through his fingers. The thick man was on his side between the Charger and a Honda, still gagging, not getting up.

Thirty seconds. Maybe less.

A woman with a cart was standing at the end of the row, sixty feet away, staring. Arthur looked at her and she pulled her phone out.

He walked to his car. Didn't run. His hands were shaking and his knuckles were split and there was blood on his jacket and his forehead was already starting to swell. He got in, started the engine, and pulled out of the space carefully, as though he were leaving a grocery store on a normal Tuesday evening.

He was on Route 7 heading west before the shaking got bad enough that he had to grip the wheel with both hands to keep them still. The Best Buy bag was still on the asphalt next to the Charger. Forty-nine dollars and ninety-nine cents. He'd wanted that cable.

The thick man had been wearing work boots, Carhartt jacket, no visible tattoos. Professional enough to carry a sap, not professional enough to expect resistance. The thin man had been wearing running shoes and a North Face shell. The brass knuckles were old — worn at the edges.

Two men, different gear, different builds, different shoes. Like they'd been hired from different lists.

Arthur thought about that as the storefronts and traffic lights slid past. Two lists meant two clients. Which meant this wasn't one angry boss settling a score. This was funded. Maybe twice.

He pulled into a Sheetz station three miles down the road, parked away from the pumps, and sat for a moment with the engine running. His right

hand was swelling. He flexed it open and closed. Nothing broken, probably. The headbutt had left a knot above his left eyebrow that pulsed with his heartbeat.

He picked up his phone and called Helen.

She answered on the second ring. “Arthur. This is a surprise.”

“Hey, Hel.”

“You sound weird. Are you driving?”

“Pulled over.”

“What’s wrong?”

He looked at his knuckles, the split skin, the blood drying dark in the creases. Through the windshield, the Sheetz sign glowed green against the fading sky. A kid was filling up a Honda Civic at the far pump, bobbing his head to something Arthur couldn’t hear.

“I got jumped in a parking lot,” he said.

Silence. Then: “Are you hurt?”

“They’re hurt. I’m fine.” He paused. “I’m not fine. Hel, they sent people.”

“Who sent — your agency? Arthur, what are you —”

“I’ve been calling them CWIR.”

“Calling who what?”

“The people who want me to shut up. CWIR. Cowards With Infinite Resources.”

Helen was quiet for a moment. He could hear her thinking. She’d always done that — gone silent when the information was important, turned it over before responding. It was one of the reasons he trusted her more than anyone still speaking to him.

“How bad is this?” she said.

“Bad enough that they sent two guys with weapons to a Best Buy parking lot on a Tuesday.”

“Jesus, Arthur.”

“Yeah.”

“What are you going to do?”

“I don’t know. The Special Counsel’s office has been useless. The FBI referral went nowhere. I can’t go to work, I can’t stay home, and now I can’t go to Best Buy.” He heard himself almost laugh. It wasn’t funny. “I need to not be here for a while.”

Helen was quiet again. Longer this time. He could hear a faint sound in the background — a door closing, maybe, or a chair moving. She was settling in. Getting ready to say something she’d been thinking about.

“Arthur,” she said. “You know my dad’s place. The station.”

“In Australia.”

“I was out there when he died. It’s — there’s a man running it, Ted, he’s been there forever. And another guy who works with him. It’s remote. It’s about as far from a Best Buy parking lot as you can get on this planet.”

“Helen —”

“Just listen. It’s sitting there. Nobody’s using it except Ted and his guy. There’s a house, there’s work if you want it, and there’s about two hundred miles of nothing between you and the nearest person who’d think to look for you.”

Arthur stared through the windshield. The kid at the pump had finished and was pulling away. The parking lot was empty now except for his car and the green glow of the sign.

“I don’t know anything about cattle,” he said.

“You didn’t know anything about rare earth mining before all this, either.”

He almost smiled. “That’s fair.”

“I’m serious. I’ve been trying to figure out what to do with the place anyway. You’d be doing me a favor. And Arthur —” She paused. “You need to be somewhere they can’t find you. Not next week. Now.”

He looked at his swollen hand resting on the steering wheel. At the blood on his jacket cuff. At the last light draining from the Virginia sky.

“Tell me about the station,” he said.

Chapter 2 — CWIR

Helen was already thinking out loud.

“Alice Springs is the closest real airport. You’d fly into Sydney, then domestic from there. I think there’s a morning flight out of Dulles to LAX, and then — hang on, let me look.”

Arthur could hear her typing. He was still at the Sheetz station, engine running, watching the road. His right hand had settled into a steady throb, the knuckles fat and tight. He kept flexing it against the steering wheel.

“There’s a Dulles to LAX at six-fifty tomorrow morning,” Helen said. “LAX to Sydney, fourteen hours. Then Sydney to Alice Springs, about three. You’d land Thursday afternoon their time.”

“Book it.”

“Arthur, that’s — you’re sure? This is not a long weekend.”

“I’m sure.”

She was quiet for a beat. “I need your passport number.”

He gave it to her from memory. She didn’t comment on that.

“I’ll text you the confirmations,” she said. “And I’ll call Ted tonight — he’s my manager out there. He’ll know you’re coming. There’s a guy who works with him, Miro. Aboriginal fellow. Ted says he’s the one who actually runs the place.”

“What do I need to know?”

“It’s big. It’s hot. It’s empty. You’ll figure out the rest.” She paused. “You need to get home and pack. Can you do that without — are you safe to go home?”

“I think so. They won’t know what happened yet. The two guys in the parking lot aren’t going to call it in to anyone until they can stand up.”

“God, Arthur.”

“I know.”

“Call me when you’re home. I’ll have the tickets by then.”

He pulled out of the Sheetz and headed south on Route 7. Traffic was thinning out, the commuter pulse fading. Strip malls and car dealerships slid past, their signs competing for attention against the darkening sky. He drove carefully, checking mirrors, staying in the right lane. His forehead was swelling above the left eyebrow. He tilted the rearview to look at it — a raised knot, reddish-purple, tender when he touched it. He'd need to wear a hat at the airport.

His street was a quiet residential block in Falls Church — brick townhouses, mature oaks, cars parked tight along both sides. He turned the corner and saw a dark sedan idling halfway down the block, driver's side to the curb, someone in the front seat.

His stomach dropped. He drove past his building without slowing, turned right at the end of the block, and circled around. Came back from the other direction. The sedan was still there. He could see the glow of a phone screen through the window.

He parked two spaces behind it and got out. Walked toward the sedan with his keys between his fingers, which was stupid and he knew it, but his hands wanted something to hold. As he got close, the driver's window was down. A woman in scrubs, phone propped on the steering wheel, FaceTiming someone in what sounded like Tagalog. She glanced at Arthur without interest and went back to her call.

His neighbor's wife. Night shift at Inova. He'd seen her car a hundred times.

He stood on the sidewalk and let the air out of his lungs. The oaks above him stirred in the night air, their leaves just beginning to turn. A dog barked somewhere on the next block. Normal sounds. A normal street on a normal Tuesday night, and he was standing in it with blood on his jacket and his heart hammering because a nurse was making a phone call.

He went inside.

The apartment was a one-bedroom on the second floor. He'd moved in three years ago when the lease was cheap and the commute was short. It had stayed functional and never become anything more. A desk along the window with his Mac Mini and a monitor. A bookshelf half-full. A couch

he'd bought from a colleague who was moving. The kitchen was clean because he didn't cook much. The bedroom had a bed, a nightstand, and a closet with clothes arranged by type — shirts, pants, jackets — because that was how his brain worked.

He stood in the living room and looked at it. A man could leave this place in an hour and the only evidence he'd been here would be the scuff marks on the hardwood.

He took a shower. The hot water stung his knuckles and the knot on his forehead, and he stood under it longer than he needed to because it was the first time since the parking lot that his body wasn't clenched. He dried off, dressed in clean clothes, and started packing.

One bag. A carry-on duffle he'd had since his twenties. Clothes for heat — Helen had said hot, so he pulled T-shirts, two pairs of lightweight pants, a button-down for the airport. Underwear, socks, toiletries. His laptop and both chargers went into a smaller backpack along with his passport, wallet, and the one external drive that held his personal archives. Everything he'd filed with the Office of Special Counsel was on that drive. Everything he'd documented about the mining operation. Every email, every manifest, every satellite image he'd matched to a purchase order. He wasn't leaving that behind.

He checked the time. Nine-forty. Helen would have the tickets soon.

He sat at the desk and opened the laptop. The Mac Mini's desktop was still showing the file transfer he'd been planning to run with the new cable — the cable that was still on the asphalt in a Best Buy parking lot in Sterling. He closed the window and opened his email client.

He composed four messages and scheduled all of them for delivery at eight a.m. Wednesday — ninety minutes after his flight left the ground.

The first was to his supervisor, Gerald Fenn. Arthur kept it factual. On Tuesday evening he had been physically assaulted in a commercial parking lot by two men he believed were connected to parties he had identified in his protected disclosure. He had reported the incident to no one because prior reports had resulted in no action. He was taking leave effective imme-

diately for personal safety. The email included the date, time, location, and a physical description of both attackers. He read it over twice and changed nothing.

The second was to Special Agent Diana Marsh at the FBI's Washington Field Office. Marsh had been assigned to his case four months ago and had done nothing with it that Arthur could detect. The email was shorter. He described the attack, noted that it represented an escalation from threats to physical violence, and stated that he had lost confidence in the Bureau's ability or willingness to protect him. He did not say where he was going. He wrote: *I am removing myself from the situation since no one else appears inclined to do so.*

The third was to Rob Kessler, the closest thing he had to a friend at the agency. Rob worked two floors up in a different division and had been careful to stay neutral during the fallout, which Arthur understood and didn't blame him for. The email was lighter: *Taking off for a while to help a relative with something. Not sure how long. Don't worry about me. I'll be in touch when I can.* He almost added something about the cable he'd been planning to buy, a joke Rob would have appreciated, but decided against it. Keep it clean.

The fourth was to Maya, who ran the Krav Maga gym in Annandale where he'd trained three nights a week for the past six years. Same basic message — leaving town, family thing, back when he could be. He'd miss the Wednesday sparring class. She'd understand.

He closed the laptop and sat for a moment in the quiet apartment. The streetlight outside the window threw a pale bar across the desk. He could hear the furnace cycling and, faintly, television sound from the unit below.

Then he took a legal pad from the desk drawer and a pen.

He wrote for fifteen minutes. Not fast, not slow. Careful handwriting, clear enough for anyone to read. When he was done he read it through once, folded the pages into thirds, and slid them into a business envelope. He addressed it to Helen — her full name, her home address in Bethesda — and sealed it. He put a stamp on it and set it by the door next to his keys.

If something happened to him — if he disappeared, if his death looked wrong, if the ground shifted in a way that suggested CWIR had reached him — Helen would know what to do with what was in that envelope. Names, dates, dollar amounts, the chain of documentation that connected the agency's inaction to the mining company's payments. Everything that mattered, compressed onto three pages of legal paper in his tight, careful handwriting.

He looked at the envelope on the table by the door. It was the most important thing in the apartment and it looked like a water bill.

His phone buzzed. Helen.

Booked. Dulles-LAX 6:50am, LAX-Sydney 11:15am, Sydney-Alice Springs 8:40am+1. Confirmations coming to your email. I put it on my card — don't argue.

A second text, thirty seconds later:

Leave your car keys somewhere at Dulles and tell me where. I'll pick up the RAV4 this week and bring it to my place. Also going to swing by your apartment and check the fridge, turn things off, etc. I'll cover your rent for a couple of months in case you're back sooner than we think.

He read that last line twice. *In case you're back sooner than we think.* She didn't believe it. Neither did he. But it was the kind of thing Helen would say — practical optimism, a door left open because closing it cost nothing.

He texted back: *Keys will be in a magnetic box under the rear bumper, passenger side. Long-term lot C. Thank you, Hel. For all of it.*

Just get there safe. Ted knows you're coming. He sounded pleased, actually. I think he wants the company.

Arthur set the alarm for four-fifteen, turned off the lights, and lay down on the bed without getting under the covers. His hand throbbed. The knot on his forehead pulsed against the pillow when he turned to the left, so he lay on his back and stared at the ceiling.

Two men, two different kits. That was the thing he kept coming back to. The thick one was blue-collar muscle — Carhartt, work boots, a sap. The

kind of guy you'd find through a fixer — muscle working off a debt. The thin one was different — running shoes, North Face, old brass knuckles that he carried like he'd used them before. More professional, or at least a different kind of professional. They hadn't moved like a team. They'd converged, but without the easy coordination of people who'd worked together.

Two clients. The agency had its own reasons — Arthur had named names in his disclosure, people who'd approved the reports they knew were false, people who'd taken meetings with mining executives they should never have been in a room with. Those people had friends. They had access to discretionary funds, the kind that moved through contractors and consultants and never showed up in a line item anyone audited. That was one source.

The mining company was the other. Meridian Resources. A mid-cap outfit with operations across four continents and a government affairs budget that dwarfed its R&D spending. Arthur's disclosure hadn't just embarrassed the agency — it had put Meridian's operating licenses under review. Billions at stake. A man like Arthur, with his archives and his careful documentation, was a liability that justified significant expenditure.

Cowards With Infinite Resources. He'd come up with the name three months ago, lying in this same bed, staring at this same ceiling. It had made him smile then. It didn't now.

He slept in fragments. An hour here, forty minutes there. At some point the furnace kicked off and the apartment went cold and silent. At four-twelve, three minutes before the alarm, he opened his eyes and got up.

Shower, dress, check the bag. Laptop in the backpack, chargers, passport, wallet. He looked around the apartment one more time. The desk, the half-empty bookshelf, the couch that had never really been his. He picked up the envelope and his keys and walked out. Locked the door behind him. Put the key on the ring with the car keys.

The air outside was cold and sharp, the oaks black against a sky just starting to lighten at the edges. He put the envelope in the blue USPS mailbox at the corner of his street. Heard it hit the bottom of the empty box. A flat sound, like a door closing.

He drove to Dulles in twenty minutes. Long-term lot C. He parked, put the keys in the magnetic box, and pressed it into place under the rear bumper on the passenger side. Stood up, looked at the champagne RAV4 under the parking lot lights, and thought about nothing in particular. Then he shouldered his bag and walked toward the terminal.

Inside it was bright and warm and full of people who were going somewhere and coming back. Arthur checked in, cleared security with his hat pulled low over the knot on his forehead, and found his gate. The board said LAX, departing 6:50. He sat down in a molded plastic chair and watched the planes taxi in the gray morning light.

He was going to a cattle station in Central Australia that he'd never seen, to stay with a man he'd never met, in a landscape he couldn't picture. He was leaving behind an apartment that looked like nobody lived in it, a career that had been taken from him, and an envelope in a mailbox that assumed he might not survive the year.

He took out his phone and looked at Helen's last text. *Ted knows you're coming. He sounded pleased, actually.*

The gate agent announced boarding. Arthur stood up, put his phone away, and got in line.

Chapter 3 — Red Dust

The flights blurred together. Dulles to LAX, four and a half hours in a window seat watching the country scroll beneath him — the Appalachians, the plains, the Rockies, the desert, the sprawl of Los Angeles emerging from haze. LAX to Sydney, fourteen hours over the Pacific with the cabin dark and the engines droning and Arthur sleeping in twenty-minute stretches that left him more tired than awake. In Sydney he stood at a terminal window and watched rain streak the glass and sent Helen a two-line email: *On the ground in Sydney. Connecting to Alice Springs in ninety minutes.* Her reply came before he'd finished his coffee: *Almost there. Ted's picking you up. He sounded pleased.*

The flight to Alice Springs was three hours of descending light and shrinking landscape. The last hour was red earth and nothing else, seen through a scratched oval window — flat ground stretching to every horizon, the occasional line of a road or a dry creek bed, and a sky so large it made the plane feel like an insect.

When the doors opened at Alice Springs, the heat walked in.

Arthur came down the stairs onto the tarmac and the air hit him like something physical — dry, bright, carrying a faint mineral smell he couldn't name. The light was sharp enough to make him squint even with sunglasses. It was late afternoon and the sun was still high and the shadows were short and hard-edged on the red ground. He crossed the tarmac with his bag over his shoulder, feeling the heat through the soles of his shoes, and walked into a terminal that was small and quiet and unhurried in a way that no American airport had been in his lifetime.

He collected his bag from a carousel that held eleven bags total and walked outside.

The Land Cruiser was parked at the curb. Old, white, sun-faded to the point where the white had become a color of its own — not cream, not gray, just the color of a vehicle that had spent decades in this light. A man was leaning against the front fender with his arms crossed and a hat pushed back on his head.

Ted Barlow was late sixties with a face that had been in the sun for all of them. Not tall, not short. Solid through the chest and arms built by a lifetime of physical work without ever seeing the inside of a gym. He had blue eyes in a brown face and a stillness about him that Arthur noticed immediately — not tension, not waiting, just a man comfortable with where he was.

He straightened up when he saw Arthur and put out his hand. “You’d be Arthur.”

“I would.”

Ted’s handshake was firm and brief. His eyes went to Arthur’s knuckles — still swollen, the splits scabbing over — and then to the fading bruise above his left eye. He didn’t ask.

“Helen said you’d look tired,” Ted said. “She wasn’t wrong. You want to throw that in the back?”

Arthur put his bag in the cargo area, which was already occupied by a coil of fencing wire, a case of motor oil, and a cardboard box that smelled like veterinary supplies. He climbed into the passenger seat. The upholstery was cracked leather, hot enough to feel through his pants. The dashboard was dusty and the windshield had a crack running from the lower left corner to somewhere behind the rearview mirror.

Ted got in, started the engine, and pulled away from the terminal without hurry. “Three hours, give or take,” he said. “Depends on the roos.”

“The roos.”

“Kangaroos. They come out around dusk and they’re thick as flies on the Stuart Highway this time of year. Hit one at speed and you’ll know about it.” He glanced at Arthur. “You eaten?”

“Something on the plane. I’m not sure what it was.”

“We’ll get you sorted when we’re home. Miro’s got something on, I’d imagine.”

They drove through Alice Springs, which Arthur absorbed as a series of impressions — low buildings, wide streets, red hills rising behind the town, gum trees lining a dry riverbed that ran through the center. It looked like

a place that had been set down in the middle of nowhere and had made its peace with that fact.

Then the town ended and the highway opened up and there was nothing.

Arthur had driven through empty parts of Virginia, through the Shenandoah, through stretches of the Midwest on work trips. He'd thought he understood what flat and empty looked like. He hadn't. This was different in kind, not degree. The road ran straight ahead until it dissolved into heat shimmer, and on either side there was red earth and low scrub and the occasional pale trunk of a dead tree, and beyond that the sky started and didn't stop. There were no fences, no power lines for long stretches, no buildings, no signs of anything human except the road itself.

"Big," Arthur said.

Ted laughed. "Gets bigger."

They drove. Ted talked easily — comfortable with silence but happy to fill it. He talked about the station — Helen's father had bought it thirty-two years ago, run it well, put in bore water and fencing and a proper homestead. Good man. Tough as nails but fair. The families who worked the remote stretches had been there almost as long, some of them.

"Three families out on the runs," Ted said. "The Warners — young couple, two kids, they've got the far eastern block. Good people. Then there's Reg, old boy who's been out there since before I came. And the Patersons, middle of the run, they manage the big mob of cattle on the central lease." He adjusted his grip on the wheel. "You'll meet them all. Supply run goes out every couple of weeks."

"You do the runs?"

"Have done for twenty-five years. Load up the truck, couple of days out, couple back. It's a good drive if you don't mind the dust." He looked over at Arthur. "Helen said you might want to make yourself useful."

"I'd like to. I don't know much about cattle."

"Nobody does until they do. Miro'll sort you out. He's been on the place twenty-odd years. Knows the land better than I do, and I've been here

longer.” Ted said this without any edge to it — just a fact, stated plainly, with something close to admiration underneath. “He’s a quiet one. Don’t take it personal if he doesn’t say much at first. He’s watching.”

“I can work with quiet.”

“I expect you can.”

They drove on. The sun was dropping toward the horizon now, turning the red earth a deeper shade and stretching the shadows of the scrub out long and thin. Arthur watched it and tried to connect it to anything he’d seen before and couldn’t. The landscape wasn’t hostile, exactly. It just didn’t care. It had been here before people and it would be here after and in the meantime it offered nothing it wasn’t asked for.

Ted asked, after a while, in the same easy tone: “Helen mentioned you’d had some trouble.”

Arthur looked at him. Ted’s eyes were on the road.

“Some trouble at work,” Arthur said. “It got complicated. I needed to be somewhere else for a while.”

Ted nodded. “Plenty of room out here for that.”

He didn’t ask anything else. Arthur understood that he could have — that Ted was curious, that he’d noticed the bruises and the one bag and the fact that a man had flown halfway around the world on a day’s notice — and that he’d chosen not to. The silence that followed wasn’t uncomfortable. It was an offer. Tell me when you’re ready, or don’t.

Arthur watched the road. “I appreciate it,” he said. “Being here.”

“You’re Helen’s family. That’s enough.”

The last hour of the drive was the quietest. Ted pointed out things as they passed — a stand of desert oaks, a dry creek crossing, a spot where he’d changed a tire in forty-five-degree heat and sworn he’d retire. Arthur listened and felt the jet lag settling into his bones like sand filling a glass. The light was going gold and then amber and then something he didn’t have a word for, a color that existed only here and only at this hour.

They turned off the highway onto a dirt track and drove for another twenty minutes, the Land Cruiser rocking over corrugations, dust rising behind them in a long plume that caught the last light. Then the track curved around a low rise and the homestead was there.

It wasn't much to look at. A long, low house with a tin roof and a verandah that wrapped around three sides. A water tank on a steel stand. A shed with its door open, a tractor visible inside. A second smaller building — stockman's quarters, Arthur guessed — set back fifty yards. A few trees that someone had planted decades ago, now tall enough to throw shade across the yard. A cattle dog came out from under the verandah and trotted toward the Land Cruiser, tail going — lean, red-heeled, with ears that tracked the engine noise like antennae.

"Home," Ted said.

A man was standing at the corner of the verandah. He'd been leaning against the post and had straightened up as the Land Cruiser pulled in, but without any urgency — the way you shift your weight when something changes but you're not sure yet whether it concerns you.

Miro was fifty, give or take. Not tall. Lean in a way that suggested endurance rather than deprivation. Dark skin, dark eyes, a stillness that made Ted's look restless by comparison. He was wearing a work shirt with the sleeves rolled and jeans that had faded past any original color and boots that looked like they'd walked the circumference of something large.

Ted got out and the dog went to him and he scratched its ears without looking down. "Miro, this is Arthur. Helen's cousin."

Arthur walked over and put out his hand. Miro took it. His grip was dry and brief and his eyes went to the bruised knuckles the same way Ted's had. He held Arthur's gaze for a moment.

"Long trip," Miro said.

"Long trip," Arthur agreed.

"You hungry?"

"I could eat."

Miro looked at Ted. "He could eat."

Ted grinned. "Then feed the man."

There was stew. Miro had made it — beef, potato, onion, something Arthur couldn't identify that turned out to be bush tomato. They ate at a table on the verandah as the last light left the sky and the stars came out in a way Arthur had never seen stars come out. Not gradually, not one by one, but in a rush, as if someone had pulled a curtain. The sky went from deep blue to black and then it was full of them, horizon to horizon, more stars than he'd known existed.

Ted handed him a beer from a cooler and Arthur drank it and felt the cold of it against the heat that was still radiating from the ground and the walls and the tin roof above them. The cattle dog padded over and lay down at Arthur's feet, chin on his boot. Miro glanced at it. "Lucky. He doesn't do that." Arthur looked down at the dog. "What does he usually do?" "Ignores people." Ted talked. Miro didn't, mostly. He ate and drank his beer and listened and occasionally added a word or two that shifted the direction of what Ted was saying, the way a man touches a steering wheel without gripping it.

"We'll do a proper tour tomorrow," Ted said. "Show you the homestead, the yards, the bore pumps. Miro can take you out to the near paddock if you're up for it."

Miro looked at Arthur. "You ride?"

"Horses?"

"What else would I mean?"

Ted laughed. Arthur almost did too. "No," he said. "I don't ride."

"We'll fix that," Miro said, and drank his beer, and that was the most Arthur heard him say for the rest of the evening.

The room they'd given him was at the end of the hall in the main house. A single bed, a wooden dresser, a window that looked out onto the dark. The sheets were clean and the mattress was firm and there was a hook on the

back of the door and nothing else. He set his bag on the floor and sat on the bed and took out his phone.

The Wi-Fi was slow but it worked. He opened his email and wrote to Helen.

Hel — I'm here. It's all that I had hoped for. Ted picked me up in a Land Cruiser that may have been manufactured during the Eisenhower administration. He talked for three hours and I liked every minute of it. Miro made stew and asked me if I ride horses and I said no and he said we'll fix that. The stars are ridiculous. I'm going to sleep for a hundred years. Thank you for this. —A

He sent it and plugged in his phone and lay back on the bed. Through the window he could hear nothing. Not the absence of sound — he'd had that in his apartment, and it had been a dead thing, a void. This was different. This was the sound of a large, empty, living place at night. Wind in the trees. Something moving in the scrub. The dog shifting under the verandah. The tin roof ticking as it cooled.

He was asleep before Helen replied.

She wrote back twenty minutes later: *I'm so glad. Give Ted my love. And Arthur — don't let Miro put you on anything that bucks. Love, H*

Chapter 4 — The Truck

The email was waiting when he woke up.

Helen had picked up the RAV4 from Dulles on Wednesday, driven it to her place, then gone to the apartment Thursday to check the fridge and turn things off. The email was short and her voice was steady in it but Arthur could hear the effort underneath.

Arthur — Someone's been through your apartment. Drawers pulled out in the bedroom, desk gone through, closet shelves moved. They weren't subtle about it. Nothing broken, no damage to the lock — they had a key or they're good at doors. I don't think anything was taken but I wouldn't know what to look for. I closed everything up and locked the deadbolt. I'm covering your rent as we discussed. Please be careful. Please stay where you are. — H

Arthur sat on the edge of the bed and read it twice. The archives were on the external drive in his backpack, three feet from where he was sitting. They'd been looking for that. They'd expected to find a scared man's apartment, hastily abandoned, with a hard drive full of evidence sitting on the desk.

He typed a reply: *Thank you for handling that. I'm glad you weren't there when they were. Stay safe yourself. The files are with me. — A*

He put his phone away and went to find Ted.

The truck was parked behind the main shed, and Ted was already loading it. It was a flatbed Toyota — not the Land Cruiser, something older and heavier, with wooden sides bolted to the tray and a canvas cover lashed over the top. The engine was a diesel that you could hear from two paddocks away. The cab had two seats, a cracked dash, a radio that picked up one station on a clear day, and a smell of dust and diesel and dog that Arthur suspected had been accumulating since the truck was new, which may have been during the Reagan administration.

“Grab that end,” Ted said, nodding at a fuel drum.

They loaded for an hour. Fuel drums, food boxes — flour, sugar, tea, tinned goods, fresh vegetables wrapped in damp newspaper. Fencing wire in heavy coils. A crate of veterinary supplies: drenching gun, antibiotics, iodine. Mail

in a canvas sack. A box of schoolbooks that Ted handled carefully and set on top where it wouldn't get crushed.

"Warners' kids," he said. "Sam's working through something about the Romans. Lily's on to chapter books now. She'll read anything you put in front of her."

Miro appeared from the stockman's quarters and helped them lash the canvas down. He checked the tie-downs with a tug at each point, methodical, unhurried. When he was satisfied he looked at Ted.

"Water pump's making a noise on the south bore," he said.

"I heard it yesterday. Have a look while we're out?"

Miro nodded. He glanced at Arthur. "Don't let him talk you to death."

"I'll manage," Arthur said.

Something shifted in Miro's face — not a smile, but an acknowledgment that a response had been offered. He went back to the stockman's quarters. Ted grinned and climbed into the cab.

They pulled out of the homestead at seven-thirty and drove east into the sun.

The first hour was station track — two ruts in the red earth with grass growing between them, winding through low scrub and around the occasional termite mound that rose from the ground like a misshapen pillar. Ted drove with one hand on the wheel and talked about the country. He pointed out where the bore pumps were, where the cattle tended to gather in the dry season, where a creek ran in the wet that you could lose a truck in if you weren't paying attention.

"Helen's dad put in most of the infrastructure," Ted said. "Bores, fencing, the yards. Before him it was open run. You'd spend a week mustering cattle that had wandered forty miles." He adjusted the mirror. "Good man, Jack. Knew what he was building. Shame he didn't get to see it finished, but I suppose nobody does."

"How long were you with him?"

“Twenty-five years. He hired me when I was forty and didn’t know a thing. Miro turned up a few years after me — seasonal work behind him, mustering and fencing all over the Territory. Jack put him on full-time when he saw what he could do.” Ted shook his head. “Miro can look at a paddock and tell you how many head it’ll carry and for how long. I’ve never seen anyone else do that.”

The track joined a wider dirt road and Ted picked up speed. The dust behind them rose in a long column that hung in the still air. Arthur watched it in the side mirror — a pale line drawn across the red landscape, marking where they’d been.

“The Warners are about two hours out,” Ted said. “Matt and Sarah. They’ve got the far eastern block — most remote stretch of the place. They run about eight hundred head out there with a couple of ringers who come and go. Two kids, Sam and Lily. Sam’s twelve, smart kid, quiet. Lily’s nine and she’s not quiet at all.”

He talked about the supply run — every couple of weeks, two days out, two back. You loaded what the families needed, you delivered it, you picked up whatever they needed sent back. Mail, medical supplies, parts for equipment. You fixed what you could fix while you were there. You checked on people.

“It’s not just supplies,” Ted said. “It’s — they’re out there a long way from anyone. You’re the face they see. You bring the news, you bring the mail, you bring the schoolbooks. If someone’s sick you take them to town. If a bore pump’s broken and they can’t fix it, you fix it or you send someone who can.” He looked at Arthur. “It matters.”

“I can see that.”

“It’s the best part of the job, if I’m honest. The driving’s long but the stops are worth it.”

They drove on. The landscape flattened and opened until the horizon was a perfect line in every direction, broken only by the occasional stand of low, twisted trees or a lone desert oak. “Mulga,” Ted said, nodding at the scrub. “Toughest thing out here besides the flies.” The heat built steadily. By mid-

morning the cab was an oven and Arthur had his window down and his arm resting on the door, the hot air moving past without cooling anything.

Ted told him about the seasons — the build-up before the wet, when the humidity made you want to crawl out of your own skin. The wet itself, when the creeks ran and the grass came up and everything was green for eight weeks. The long dry after, when the country turned brown and then red and the cattle pulled in close to the bores. Arthur listened and watched a wedge-tailed eagle circling high to the north, riding a thermal, patient and enormous against the empty sky.

“There,” Ted said.

Arthur saw it — a cluster of buildings ahead, low and square against the red earth. A windmill turning slowly. A line of fence. A dog came out from the shade of a water tank and barked twice, and then the door of the house opened and a girl came running.

Lily Warner was small and brown and fast. She reached the truck before Ted had the engine off and was standing at his door with her hands on her hips.

“You’re late,” she said.

“I’m exactly on time,” Ted said. “You’re early.”

“Same thing.” She looked past Ted to Arthur. “Who’s that?”

“That’s Arthur. Helen’s cousin. He’s giving us a hand.”

Lily considered him. “Can you play chess?”

“I can,” Arthur said.

“Sam can’t. He thinks he can but he can’t.”

“I’ll keep that in mind.”

Sam appeared behind his sister — taller, thinner, holding back. He gave Ted a nod that was trying hard to be casual. Ted reached into the cab and pulled out the box of schoolbooks.

“Romans still?” he said.

Sam took the box. “Carthage now.”

“Even better. Elephants.”

Matt and Sarah Warner came out together. Matt was mid-thirties, lean, sun-dark, built from years of lifting things that weren’t designed to be lifted. Sarah was shorter, fair-haired, strong-looking, with a face that smiled easily but had lines around the eyes that came from squinting at distances and worrying about things she couldn’t control.

Ted shook Matt’s hand and kissed Sarah on the cheek and introduced Arthur with nothing more than “Helen’s cousin, giving us a hand for a while.” Matt shook Arthur’s hand and held it a beat longer than necessary, sizing him up the way men do when someone new comes into a place where everyone is known.

“Good to have you,” Matt said, and left it there.

They unloaded. Arthur carried fuel drums and food boxes while Ted went through the list with Sarah — what she’d asked for, what he’d been able to get, what would come next run. The house was small and solid and clean, with a verandah that faced west and a garden that someone was keeping alive through sheer determination — tomatoes, beans, a few herbs in pots.

Matt caught Arthur looking. “Sarah’s project. She says if we’re going to live at the end of the world we’re going to have fresh basil.”

They had lunch under the verandah — sandwiches, tea, fruit from the supply box. Lily sat next to Arthur and told him about her dog, whose name was Captain and whose main talent was chasing lizards and never catching them. Sam sat across from them and listened and occasionally corrected his sister on points of fact, which she ignored.

After lunch, Matt mentioned a water trough in the east paddock that had come off its stand. “Been meaning to get it sorted but it’s a two-person job and Sarah’s got enough on.”

“Three-person job now,” Ted said, and looked at Arthur.

They drove out in Matt’s ute — a battered Hilux with hay in the back — and spent an hour wrestling a steel trough back onto its concrete stand.

The trough was heavy and awkward and the ground was uneven and the sun was directly overhead and Arthur's shirt was soaked through in ten minutes. He held the trough steady while Matt repositioned the blocks and Ted worked a jack under the far end. His arms burned and the steel was hot enough to raise blisters through his gloves and he didn't let go until Matt said it was set.

Matt looked at him when they were done. Didn't say anything. Just looked, and nodded, and Arthur understood that something had been measured and not found short.

They said goodbye in the late afternoon. Sarah had packed a bag of tomatoes for Ted — "Don't let them cook in the cab" — and Lily stood at the truck window and told Arthur she expected a chess game next time.

"You're on," he said.

"I'm good."

"I believe you."

She grinned and stepped back and Ted started the engine and they pulled away. In the side mirror Arthur watched the family standing in the yard, the dust rising behind the truck, the buildings getting smaller until they were just shapes in the red distance.

"Good people," Ted said.

"Yeah."

"It's hard out there. Harder than it needs to be, sometimes. They don't complain. Sarah mentioned the road into their block has been rough lately — some crew came through a few weeks back, survey markers or something. Didn't say who they were, didn't say what they were surveying. Closed the road for two days. She had to take the long way round to check the eastern bores."

Arthur said nothing. He filed it.

They drove another hour and a half north, into country that got sparser and drier and more remote. The track narrowed to a single set of ruts. The sun

dropped and the shadows lengthened and the landscape turned the color of rust.

“Reg’s place is just ahead,” Ted said. “My brother.”

“Your brother lives out here?”

“Forty years. Wife died twelve years ago. Kids grown, scattered. He won’t leave. Says he came out here to do a job and the job’s not done.” Ted’s voice was easy and warm but there was something underneath — not worry exactly, more like the awareness you carry when someone you love has chosen a life you wouldn’t choose for them. “He’s a tough old bastard. You’ll like him.”

The track came over a low rise and there was a house — smaller than the Warners’, older, sitting on a bare patch of red earth with a water tank and a shed and a single tree that had been coaxed to survival against all odds. A dog barked. A man came out of the house and stood on the step, shading his eyes against the low sun.

Reg Barlow was in his late seventies and looked like the country had made him instead of the other way around. Thin, hard, brown, with hands that were all knuckle and tendon and a face that had been weathered past age into something more durable. He watched them pull up and said nothing until Ted got out.

“Took your time,” Reg said.

“Had to stop at the Warners’.”

“How’s the little one?”

“Bigger. Bossier.”

Reg nodded as though this was expected and right. He looked at Arthur, who was coming around the front of the truck.

“Nice to meet you,” Reg said. “My name is Reg Barlow. Everyone calls me Reg. Some folks like Old Reg. My dog doesn’t call me anything, just barks.”

Arthur shook his hand. The grip was dry and strong and brief. “Arthur. I’m Helen’s cousin.”

“I know who you are. Ted rang ahead.” He looked at his brother. “He doesn’t look like much.”

“Neither did you at his age,” Ted said.

“Fair point. Come in. Kettle’s on.”

They sat in Reg’s kitchen, which was small and clean and lit by a single bulb that threw hard shadows on the walls. The tea was strong enough to stand a spoon in. Reg and Ted talked the way brothers do who see each other every two weeks and have for decades — short exchanges that carried years of context. They talked about a fence line, a mob of cattle that had drifted south, the water table. Arthur drank his tea and listened and watched two men who shared a surname and a landscape and an understanding that didn’t require much language.

Reg turned to him after a while. “Ted says you’re from the States.”

“Virginia.”

“Never been. Hear it rains there.”

“It does.”

“Must be nice.” Reg looked out the window at the darkening sky. “Gets old, waiting for it here.”

They ate tinned stew that Reg heated on a gas burner, and bread that Ted had brought in the supply load. The dog lay under the table and rested its head on Arthur’s boot, which Reg said meant either he liked Arthur or he was trying to keep Arthur’s foot warm. “Hard to tell with him. He’s not expressive.”

After dinner Ted and Reg sat on Reg’s front step and talked quietly while Arthur washed the dishes. He could hear them through the window — Ted’s voice easy, Reg’s shorter, the rhythm of men who didn’t need to perform for each other. He washed the plates and set them on the rack and dried his hands and stood for a moment looking out at the dark.

No streetlights. No traffic. No sound of the furnace cycling in an apartment that had been searched by people who wanted him silent. Just the dark and

the stars and two brothers on a step and a dog that barked at nothing and then settled.

Ted had said they'd do the Patersons tomorrow. Arthur was tired in a way that had nothing to do with jet lag — a physical, earned tiredness from fuel drums and water troughs and hours in a hot cab. He went to the small room Reg had made up for him — a camp bed, a blanket, a window that looked out on nothing — and lay down.

Through the thin wall he could hear Ted laugh at something Reg said. Low, easy, the sound of family.

He slept without dreaming.

Chapter 5 — The Route

Morning at Reg's was brief.

He made tea and put bread on the table and that was breakfast. He didn't ask how Arthur had slept. He asked Ted about a water level on one of the southern bores and they talked about it for five minutes in the shorthand of men who'd discussed such things many times. Arthur ate his bread and drank his tea and looked out the kitchen window at the country coming into light — the red earth going orange, the shadows pulling back, a pair of galahs moving through the scrub.

They loaded the remaining supplies into the truck — fuel drums for the Patersons, food boxes, mail, a small parcel that Ted had bubble-wrapped himself and set carefully between the seat and the door where it wouldn't bounce.

Arthur climbed into the cab and his eye went to the rifle in the rack behind the seat. Bolt-action, scoped, the stock worn smooth. He'd seen gun racks in pickups in rural Virginia — half the driveways in Fauquier County had one. It didn't mean anything here that it didn't mean there.

But his hands remembered the parking lot. The weight of the man he'd shoved into the Charger's fender. The sound the second one's nose made when Arthur's forehead connected. His body remembered, even when his mind had moved on.

Ted got in and saw him looking. "Snakes, mostly. The odd feral pig if they get into the bores. Haven't fired it in months." He started the engine. "Reg keeps a shotgun by the door. Says it's for dingoes. I think he just likes knowing it's there."

"I understand that," Arthur said, and meant it in a way he didn't explain.

They said goodbye to Reg, who stood on his step and watched them go and raised one hand when they were already too far to see it clearly. Ted drove east and the track opened up and the scrub thinned and the horizon flattened to a line in every direction.

"Patersons are about forty-five minutes back down the track," Ted said. "June and Don. They run the biggest mob on the station — central lease,

good country when it rains, hard country when it doesn't. Don's steady. Does his work, doesn't fuss. June is—" He thought about it. "June is the sharpest person I know. She takes her time with people. Don't take it personal if she's cool at first. She's just deciding."

"Deciding what?"

"How much of herself to give you. She's generous once she's decided. Just doesn't rush it."

They drove. Ted talked about the spice orders — June had a thing for unusual ingredients, changed her request every run. He sourced them from a specialty grocer in Adelaide. "Woman named Petra. She knows my voice now. I ring up and she says, 'What is it this time, Ted?' I tell her and she goes quiet and then she says she'll see what she can do. She always does."

"What's this run?"

Ted glanced at the parcel wedged by the door. "Persian limes, dried whole. And sumac. Whatever she's making, I imagine Don's had some adventures."

Arthur watched a dust devil spin up a hundred meters off the track, climb, and dissolve. "You enjoy it. The sourcing."

"I won't admit that in front of June. She'd start ordering harder things just to test me." He adjusted the mirror. "She already does, probably."

The Patersons' place came into view around a long curve — more substantial than the Warners', the fences straighter, equipment stored under a proper shelter. A garden ran along the south wall of the house, laid out in neat rows, everything labeled. Even from the truck Arthur could see it was organized rather than hopeful.

Don Paterson came out of the shed when he heard the diesel. Mid-fifties, solid, a wide weathered face that found a smile easily. He walked with the unhurried ease of a man comfortable in his own yard.

"Ted." He shook hands and looked at Arthur. "You'd be the cousin."

"Arthur."

“Don.” A handshake, firm and brief, and that was that. “June’s inside. She’ll be out.”

They unloaded. Don worked alongside them without being asked, and by the time June appeared in the doorway they had most of it stacked.

June Paterson was lean and straight-backed, close-cut grey hair, eyes that were doing something when she looked at Arthur — gathering rather than judging, but not warm either. She shook his hand once and went to Ted.

“You got it.”

“I got it.”

She took the parcel and turned it over carefully. “The limes are dried whole?”

“That’s what you said.”

“Good.” She looked at Don. “We’ll try it this week.”

Don’s face said he had survived previous experiments and expected to survive this one. “Looking forward to it,” he said.

“You can help.”

“I always help.”

“You stir and complain. That’s not the same thing.”

Ted laughed. Arthur liked them.

The fence was a twenty-minute drive out on the eastern boundary, running alongside a vehicle track that crossed from government land. They went in Don’s ute.

The cut was clean. Three strands of barbed wire, all three severed in the same spot, the ends bright where the wire cutters had gone through. No vehicle had pushed through — the posts stood straight, the ground on both sides undisturbed. Someone had stood here and cut the wire and nothing else.

Ted crouched and looked at it. Arthur stood beside him.

“Deliberate,” Ted said.

“That’s what I thought,” June said. “Don wondered if someone needed through in a hurry.”

“No,” Arthur said. “If you need through in an emergency, you push through or find a gate. You don’t stand here and cut three strands cleanly. That takes a minute and a half. You’d have to want to be standing here.”

June watched him while he said it. Don said nothing. Ted stood up.

“He’s right. Someone wanted this fence cut.”

They fixed it. Arthur held the wire strainer while Don worked the line and Ted clipped. June watched the track that ran along the fence in both directions — the direction the cutter would have come from, and the direction they’d gone.

Arthur had seen things like this. Not fences — contracts, requisitions, inspection schedules. Someone with leverage applying pressure through channels that looked incidental until you lined them up. Sarah Warner’s survey crew that closed her road for two days. Now a cut fence. Local interests, probably mining or pastoral, leaning on families who didn’t have the connections to push back. It was how things worked, everywhere he’d ever worked. The mechanism was different; the logic was identical.

He said nothing and helped coil the old wire.

Back at the house, over tea, June got out a notebook.

Hardback, A4 size, with a dark blue cover worn soft at the corners, filled with handwriting that was small and precise. She put it on the table and opened it to Ted, not to Arthur.

“I’ve been keeping this since March,” she said. “A road crew came through in February — notice went up about scheduled maintenance on the east access. Fine. Then in March, closed again. Different crew, no notice. I couldn’t get to the east bores for three days.”

Ted looked at the open pages. “You wrote all of it down.”

“Dates, crew names when they gave them, what they said the reason was.” She turned a page. “Service contractor came in April, said the bore inspection schedule had changed. I asked who changed it. He didn’t know, or said he didn’t. May, the power line crew came through and marked some poles. June, the east access closed again. Four days.”

“Five closures in seven months,” Arthur said.

June looked at him — the first time she’d directed anything at him since the handshake.

“Five,” she said. “There was one in January I didn’t write down because I thought it was routine. I wrote it from memory later.” She tapped the page. “Always the east access. Always government contractors, or people saying they were. Always a different crew.”

“Nobody coordinating,” Arthur said.

“Nobody explaining.”

He recognized the habit more than the specifics — the careful log, the dates, the refusal to let things slide past without a record. He’d done the same thing, sitting at his desk in Virginia, writing down meeting dates and access changes and the slow tightening of a bureaucratic noose.

“I’ve seen this kind of thing,” he said. “Not the same situation. But the pattern. I worked for a federal agency in the States. We had oversight of a mining company — overseas operation. I found problems and raised them through the proper channels.” He stopped. “It’s a particular kind of frustration, when you do everything right and the system treats you like you did something wrong.”

June’s expression didn’t change, but something behind it settled — not warmth, not yet. Recognition.

“Which is why you’re here,” she said.

“Part of why.” He looked at the notebook on the table. “You’re doing the right thing, keeping that record. It matters even when it doesn’t feel like it.”

He meant it as sympathy. Same problems everywhere — institutions that serve power, people who keep records because it’s the only thing they can

do. He'd sat in enough oversight meetings to know the playbook didn't change much from one continent to another. He wasn't connecting it to himself. He was ten thousand miles from that.

Don refilled his tea without being asked.

June closed the notebook and put it between them. Not a handover — just a placement. She picked up her mug.

"Ted," she said. "Next run, I'll need kaffir lime leaves if you can find them. Dried. And black sesame."

Ted's face did something complicated. "Different supplier."

"You'll manage."

"I'll try."

"Thank you." She looked at Arthur. "Don, show him the garden before they go."

The garden was June's the same way the notebook was — methodical, maintained against the conditions by a refusal to let the conditions be in charge. Every bed labeled in the same small handwriting. A drip system on a timer. Three varieties of tomato, two of them named in Latin on the stakes.

"She gets seed catalogs from a nursery in Melbourne," Don said. "Reads them like other people read novels." He looked at the beds. "She's had that notebook since March. I kept thinking she'd feel better once she got it written down." He paused. "Maybe she will now."

Arthur said nothing. They stood in the garden in the midday heat and looked at the rows of things growing where they had no business growing.

The drive back was long and they let it be. Ted drove and Arthur watched the country — the red earth, the flat scrub, the shadows starting to stretch. An hour out Ted said, "The services used to be better. Roads were open. Inspectors came when they were supposed to and said who they were."

"When did it change?"

“Past year, year and a half. Gradual. Nothing you’d point to on its own.” He adjusted his grip on the wheel. “June’s the only one writing it down. The Warners just work around it. Reg wouldn’t notice a road closure if it bit him.”

Arthur thought about it the way he’d think about any institution under quiet pressure — the slow accumulation of small disruptions that individually meant nothing and collectively meant someone was making a point. Mining interests, government contracts, pastoral leases — out here the players would be different but the game would be the same. He’d spent a career watching agencies look the other way while companies did what they liked. It wasn’t surprising that it happened in Australia too. It happened everywhere. That was the whole problem with it.

He didn’t say any of this. He watched the road and let the quiet settle.

The homestead came up in the last of the light, their dust catching the color of it.

Miro was on the verandah with a beer when they pulled in. Arthur helped Ted unload the last of the gear into the shed. Walking back through the hall to his room he passed the gun cabinet — two rifles and a shotgun behind the glass, a box of cartridges on the shelf beside it. The lock was a simple latch. He noted it the way he’d noted the rifle rack that morning — without deciding to, without stopping. His body kept an inventory his mind didn’t request.

He dropped his bag and went out to the verandah.

“Patersons good?” Miro said.

“Good,” Ted said. “June’s order came in.”

Miro waited.

“Persian limes. Sumac.”

Miro considered this with the attention of a man receiving useful intelligence. “Sumac on meat,” he said. “I’ve read about that.”

“Have you,” Ted said.

“Could try it on the roo we’ve got in the freezer.”

“Petra packed doubles of both,” Ted said. “They’re in the pantry.” His expression communicated a position without stating it. He picked up his bag and went inside. Arthur sat down and Miro handed him a beer without being asked.

“June’s good people,” Arthur said.

“Sharpest person Ted knows.” Miro drank. “He doesn’t say it, but.”

“He said it today.”

Miro looked at him. “First time for everything,” he said, and drank his beer.

Later, at the desk in his room, Arthur opened his email.

Hel — Two days on the run. The Warners are young and tough and their daughter told me she’s good at chess and I believe her. Their son is reading about Carthage at twelve years old. Reg Barlow is Ted’s brother and is made of different material than most people. And today the Patersons. June keeps a notebook — road closures, service disruptions, contractors who won’t explain themselves. Same problems everywhere. People with power leaning on people without, and the people without keeping records because it’s the only thing they can do. I told her a little about my situation. Not much. She didn’t ask for much. Her husband showed me her garden afterward and I keep thinking about it. She’s growing tomatoes in country that doesn’t want tomatoes and she’s writing down everything that doesn’t add up and I think those are the same impulse. I like these people. I think that’s what I wanted to say. —A

He sent it and sat at the desk in the quiet. The tin roof had cooled and stopped ticking. Through the window, a yellow square of light in the stockman’s quarters — Miro still up.

Helen’s reply came forty minutes later.

Arthur — You sound like yourself. I don’t mean the last couple of years you — I mean before all of it. The one who noticed things about people and actually told me. That’s the email I just read. Whatever is happening out there, stay in

it for a while longer. Also I need to know what June Paterson does with Persian limes. Love, H

He read it twice. Through the window, Miro's light went out.

He left the reply until morning.

Chapter 6 — Station Life

The bore pump on the south run had been making a noise since before the supply trip, and Miro wanted it sorted.

They drove out in the station ute — a Hilux older than the Land Cruiser but lighter on fuel and easier to park next to bore infrastructure that hadn't been designed with vehicles in mind. Lucky rode in the back with his ears flat against the wind and his mouth open in what Arthur was beginning to think of as the dog's professional expression.

The south bore was forty minutes from the homestead on a track that got worse as it went. The country out here was different — flatter, more exposed, the scrub thinning to saltbush and spinifex — spiny tussock grass that grabbed at your boots — and bare red ground that radiated heat like a kiln floor. The bore itself was a steel pipe rising from the earth with a pump motor bolted to a concrete pad and a solar panel angled to catch the north sun. A steel tank stood on a stand beside it, feeding a trough that ran out to the nearest paddock. The system was simple and essential and, at the moment, making a grinding noise that Miro clearly found offensive.

"Bearing," he said, listening. He'd already started pulling tools from the back of the ute. "Probably the same one I replaced eighteen months ago. The motor runs all day in this heat and the bearings don't forgive it."

Arthur took the toolbox he was handed and set it where Miro indicated. "How many bores on the station?"

"Fourteen. Jack put in ten of them. The other four were here before, hand-drilled, shallow. The deep ones run off solar now — we converted them about eight years ago. Before that it was diesel generators and you spent half your time carting fuel out to them." Miro was already at the motor housing, working a socket wrench with the efficiency of this specific job done many times before. "Hand me the twelve-mil."

Arthur found it and handed it over. Miro talked while he worked — not performing, not teaching, just the way a man talks when he's doing something familiar and has company he doesn't mind. He talked about the aquifer — the Great Artesian Basin, water that had been underground for thousands of years, coming up warm and slightly mineral. He talked about

flow rates and draw-down and the balance between what you pumped and what the water table could sustain. He talked about Jack, who'd understood that balance instinctively and had sited the bores where the geologists said and then moved two of them to where Miro said, and both times Miro had been right.

"He listened," Miro said. "That was the thing about Jack. He'd hire an expert and then he'd listen to the bloke standing next to the expert who'd been here longer." He pulled the bearing housing free and held it up. The bearing was scored and dry. "There it is. Hand me the new one — blue box, left side."

Arthur found it. "You knew it was the bearing before we got here."

"I knew what it sounded like eighteen months ago when I replaced the same one." He pressed the new bearing into the housing. "Some problems are like that. They come back in the same shape."

They worked for another hour. Arthur held things steady, handed tools, learned the sequence. By the time Miro had the motor back together and running clean — the grinding replaced by a smooth hum that sounded like a machine at peace with itself — Arthur understood the system well enough to diagnose the same failure next time. Miro hadn't told him he was learning. He'd just done the job at a pace that let Arthur follow.

They sat in the shade of the tank stand and drank water from the canteens and said nothing for a few minutes. The heat was enormous. Lucky lay under the ute and panted steadily.

"How long have you been here?" Arthur said.

"On this station? Since I was about thirty. Seasonal work before that — mustering, fencing, wherever they'd have me. Jack put me on full-time after my first wet season." Miro looked out at the country. "Twenty-odd years. Longer than some marriages. Better than most, probably."

"You ever think about leaving?"

"Thought about it once. I was about thirty and a mate of mine had work up in the Kimberley — bigger station, better money. I drove up there and had a look." He drank from his canteen. "Nice country. Different. Wetter than here. I stayed a week and came back."

“What brought you back?”

Miro thought about it. “I knew where everything was,” he said. “Every bore, every gate, every creek bed. I knew what the country looked like in every season. Up there I didn’t know anything. I was starting from nothing.” He screwed the cap on his canteen. “That probably sounds like a small reason.”

“No, it doesn’t,” Arthur said.

After lunch they went out to bring in a mob that had drifted toward the eastern fence. Lucky knew before they’d stopped the ute — he was over the side and moving before Miro had the handbrake on, trotting out wide to the left with his head low and his eyes on the cattle.

“Just watch,” Miro said. “Stay by the gate. When they come through, close it. That’s your job.”

Arthur stood by the gate and watched.

What Lucky did was not something Arthur had a vocabulary for. The dog read the mob the way a conductor reads an orchestra — not reacting to what was happening but anticipating what was about to. He moved the cattle in a long arc toward the gate, covering ground at a flat sprint when he needed to, then pulling up and holding still when a look was enough. A heifer broke left and Lucky was there before she’d committed to the direction, turning her back with a presence that was more conviction than aggression. He never barked. He never hesitated. The mob moved through the gate in a steady flow and Arthur closed it behind the last cow and stood there holding the latch.

Miro walked over. “You forgot to breathe.”

“That might be the most impressive thing I’ve ever seen.”

“Don’t tell him that. He’s already difficult.” Miro scratched Lucky’s ears. The dog leaned into it and then sat at Arthur’s feet, which Miro watched with interest. “He doesn’t do that with everyone.”

“What does it mean?”

“Means he thinks you might be worth keeping around. He’s usually right.” Miro looked at the mob settling in the paddock. “I got him as a pup from a breeder near Katherine. Eight weeks old, ears too big for his head. Took him out with the cattle when he was four months and he just — knew. Some dogs you train. Lucky, you just pointed him at the work and got out of his way.”

“Like his owner,” Arthur said.

Miro looked at him and smiled, a little sheepishly.

They drove back toward the homestead and the airstrip came into view — a flat red strip between two lines of painted rocks, and tied down at the far end, a Cessna 182 with sun-faded paint and dust on the windscreen.

“That yours?” Arthur said.

“Station’s. I use it for muster surveys mostly — checking water points, finding mobs that have wandered. Emergencies, when someone needs to get to Alice and the road won’t do.” Miro slowed the ute. “Can’t carry freight. No good for supply runs. But for eyes and speed, it earns its keep.”

“I have a license,” Arthur said.

Miro stopped the ute. Not dramatically — he just took his foot off the accelerator and let it roll to a halt. He looked at Arthur.

“Has or had?”

“Lapsed. About two years. I was current on a 172 — similar enough.”

“How lapsed is lapsed? Could you pass a check-ride?”

“With a few hours in the seat, yes.”

Miro was quiet for a moment, but it wasn’t his usual quiet. It was the quiet of a man running numbers. “There’s an instructor at the strip in town. Bill Harker. He owes me a favour from when I flew his generator out to his brother’s place in a thunderstorm. He could sort the paperwork, get you current on the 182.”

“I’ll think about it.”

“Think fast. Bill’s seventy-two and he’s not getting sharper.” Miro started the ute again. “One pilot on a station this size is a problem I’ve been carrying for five years. If you can fly, I’d love to get you flying.”

Arthur looked at the Cessna as they passed. It sat on the red dirt like something waiting to be useful.

“We can talk to Bill,” he said.

“Good. Next time we go to town.” Miro drove on. The energy in him was different now — not excitement, but the satisfaction of a practical man who’d found a solution to a problem he’d been working around. He glanced at Arthur. “What else can you do that you haven’t mentioned?”

“I can play chess.”

“That’s less useful.”

“Lily didn’t think so.”

Miro wanted to check a water point on the north run before the light went — trough had been reading low, and he wanted to see the mob numbers from the air. They took the Cessna up at four o’clock, Miro flying, Arthur in the right seat.

The strip was rough but the plane lifted cleanly and then the station was below them and Arthur understood for the first time what he’d been living in.

From the ground, the station was a series of locations connected by tracks — the homestead, the bores, the paddocks, the route families’ places. From the air it was a single thing, vast and legible. The water points were punctuation marks in the red expanse. The mobs were dark masses moving slowly. The fences were thin lines that seemed improbable against the scale — the idea that wire and posts could organize this country into something manageable. The homestead was a small cluster of roofs and shadows. The track to the Patersons’ was a pale thread running north.

Miro checked what he needed to check — the trough was fine, the mob was where it should be — and banked south to head back.

Arthur saw the tracks.

They were on the eastern section, near the boundary where the station land met government land. A set of vehicle ruts cutting across open ground where there was no track, no gate, no reason for anyone to drive. The earth was freshly turned — red-brown against the older, weathered surface. They ran for maybe three hundred meters and then stopped at a point where the ground was harder and the tires hadn't left marks.

"Miro."

Miro looked where Arthur was pointing. He banked the Cessna and came around for a second pass, lower. The tracks were clear from five hundred feet — someone had driven a vehicle across station land, not on any established track, and stopped at a point that was roughly a kilometer inside the boundary.

Miro said nothing for a moment. Then: "That's not ours."

"You're sure?"

"I know every track on this place. That's not one of them. Nobody from the station has been out there in months." He flew over the tracks one more time, noting the position against landmarks — a stand of mulga, a dry creek bend. "Someone's been on our land."

He turned for home. The flight back was quiet. Arthur watched the ground and thought about June's notebook, the fence cut, Sarah Warner's survey crew. People with vehicles and purposes they didn't explain, moving across country that belonged to someone else. Mining survey, probably. Or pastoral assessment. Government contractors who'd expanded their brief. It was the same pattern June had been logging — institutional creep, boundaries tested, nobody asking permission because nobody thought they needed to.

Same problems everywhere.

Miro told Ted about the tracks over dinner, which was the moment the evening split into two parts.

The first part was Miro's experiment food. Miro had been preparing since the night before — sumac rubbed into kangaroo loin, the dried Persian limes ground and mixed into something he described as a marinade. He'd followed a description he'd read, adapted for what he had, and was quietly confident in a way that made Ted visibly nervous.

The result was not good. It wasn't dangerous — nothing was raw, nothing was burned. The flavors were present but they were fighting each other in a way that no one at the table could diagnose. The sumac was sour. The lime was sour. The kangaroo was doing its best but it was outnumbered. They each ate enough to be respectful and then forks slowed and stopped.

Ted looked at the bowl. He looked at Miro. He looked at the bowl again.

"That's roo food," he said.

Miro looked at the bowl. He didn't argue. "Something went wrong with the balance."

"The balance went wrong when you opened the jar."

They put together beans and bacon on the gas burner and ate that instead, and it was excellent in the way that simple food is excellent after a day that earned it. Lucky sat under the table and rested his head on Arthur's boot and Arthur was content in a way that he noticed without examining.

Then Miro mentioned the tracks.

He said it the way he'd said the bore bearing was gone — a fact reported to the relevant person. Vehicle tracks on the eastern section, near the government boundary. Fresh. Not station traffic. He'd noted the position. Someone had been on their land.

Ted ate his beans and listened. He was quiet for a moment after Miro finished.

"I'll have a look from the ground when I'm out that way," he said. "See if they left anything else."

"Could be the same mob that cut the Patersons' fence," Miro said.

“Could be.” Ted set down his fork. “Could be a lot of things. Survey crew, maybe. Government’s been doing mineral assessments across the region.”

“On our land without asking.”

“Wouldn’t be the first time.” Ted picked up his beer. “I’ll have a look.”

The conversation moved on. Nobody was alarmed. But something had been registered — the tracks, the fence, the closures — and it sat in the room alongside the beans and the failed roo food and the dog under the table.

Before bed, Ted put the bowl outside for the roos. Arthur heard one approach in the dark, sniff, and move on.

At his desk, Arthur wrote to Helen.

Hel — Full day. Miro took me out to fix a bore pump and I now understand more about artesian water than I ever expected to. Then we brought in a mob of cattle with his dog Lucky, who is the most competent creature I’ve ever watched work. He moves cattle the way good lawyers move juries — you don’t see the technique, just the result. Also: Miro found out I have a pilot’s license and now wants me to get current on the station Cessna. He’s already lined up an instructor. I said I’d think about it, which he correctly interpreted as yes. Are you eating properly? I am, more or less. —A

Helen replied before he slept.

More or less? That’s not reassuring. What’s the less? Love, H

He smiled and closed the laptop and listened to the tin roof cool.

Chapter 7 — Town

Mulga Creek was an hour and ten minutes on the highway, and Miro drove it with an agenda.

“Bill Harker,” he said, ten minutes out of the station. “Ex-RFDS. Flew the Royal Flying Doctor Service for twenty years — single-engine stuff into strips that would make your eyes water. Retired, moved out here, couldn’t stop flying. He instructs at the town strip when someone needs signing off, which isn’t often.” He glanced at Arthur. “He’s particular. If he doesn’t think you can fly, he’ll say so and he won’t be polite about it.”

“Good.”

“I told him you’d been current on a 172. He said that was a start.” Miro adjusted the mirror. Lucky was standing in the back with his ears flat, watching the road unwind behind them. “He owes me. But that won’t matter once you’re in the air. He’ll sign what he sees.”

“Understood.”

“After Bill, we’ll do the supply run at Crowley’s. Keith and Donna. They run the shop — only one in town. They’ll want to talk. Let them.” He said this without impatience. “Then you should meet Rennie. Dave Rennie. Sergeant. He’s the police in Mulga Creek — him and a constable who’s mostly on leave. Good cop. Been here eight or nine years. Knows everyone.”

“You want me to mention the tracks?”

“I want you to mention whatever you want. Rennie’s not the type to panic. If there’s something to know, he’ll want to know it.”

They drove on. The highway was straight and empty and the sky was white with heat. Arthur watched the country — flat scrub, red earth, the occasional road train thundering past in the other direction with a wall of air that rocked the ute. Mulga Creek announced itself gradually: a fuel station, then a church, then a row of low buildings along a main street that didn’t need to be longer than it was.

The airstrip was on the eastern edge of town — a sealed runway with faded markings, a tin hangar, a windsock that hung limp in the still air. A Cessna 172 and a battered Piper were tied down on the apron. Bill Harker was standing outside the hangar with a mug of tea, watching them pull up the way a man watches something he's already decided to have an opinion about.

He was mid-seventies, wiry, sun-damaged in the way of people who'd spent decades in cockpits with perspex canopies and no sunscreen. His hands were brown and steady and his eyes were sharp behind glasses that sat on a face full of weather.

"You'd be Arthur," he said. He didn't offer his hand. He looked at the 172 on the apron and then at Arthur. "Miro says you were current on one of these."

"Two years ago."

"Two years is a long time in a cockpit." He drank his tea. "Walk-around first. I'll watch."

Arthur did the walk-around on the 172 — fuel drains, control surfaces, tire pressures, oil. His hands knew the sequence even if his mind had to catch up in a few places. Harker watched without comment, mug in hand.

"Get in," Harker said. "Left seat."

The cockpit was hot and smelled like avgas and dust and old vinyl. Arthur adjusted the seat, set the mirrors, ran through the checklist. His hands found the switches and levers in the right order, muscle memory surfacing like water through sand. He started the engine and let it settle and ran the mag check and called the CTAF and taxied to the threshold.

The first circuit was rough. Not dangerous — he was ahead of the aircraft, his scan was working — but his turns were late and his approach was fast and the landing was firm. Harker said nothing. Arthur taxied back and did it again. The second circuit was better. The third was clean — base turn on the numbers, approach speed nailed, the flare timed so the wheels touched and stayed.

"Again," Harker said.

They did stalls, engine-out drill, steep turns. Arthur's rust fell away in layers. By the fourth circuit his hands had stopped thinking and started flying.

Harker had him climb to three thousand feet and hold heading for a minute. Then he said: "You can fly the paddock. That's established. But Miro doesn't need a paddock pilot. If he sends you to town in weather, can you find this strip when you can't see it?"

"NDB approach?"

"That's what we've got. No GPS overlay, no ILS. A beacon and a needle and your brain." Harker pointed at the ADF dial. "Track inbound on the published bearing, time your descent, fly the procedure. If you can do it in VMC today, you can do it in cloud next month."

Arthur hadn't flown an NDB approach in three years. It was old technology — a ground beacon broadcasting a signal, a needle on the instrument panel that pointed at it, and a series of calculations the pilot did in real time to track inbound on a specific course. No computer. No moving map. You flew headings and watched a needle and corrected for wind and if you did it right you came out of the cloud pointed at a runway. If you didn't, you went around and tried again or you went somewhere else.

He set up the approach from ten miles out. Tuned the frequency, identified the beacon, turned inbound. The needle swung and he corrected. The wind was from the northwest — he could see the drift on the ground — and he adjusted his heading five degrees to compensate. He flew the published altitude steps, descending in stages, watching the needle, cross-checking the altimeter. At decision height he looked up and the runway was there, slightly left, exactly where the procedure said it would be.

He landed. Harker looked at the runway centerline and then at Arthur.

"Do it again. This time I'm covering your windows below two thousand."

Arthur flew it again with the side windows covered by Harker's cardboard screens — simulating cloud, forcing him onto instruments. The needle drifted and he corrected. He held the descent profile. At decision height

Harker pulled the screens and the runway was ahead, slightly right this time, close enough.

“That’ll do,” Harker said.

They taxied back to the apron where Miro was leaning against the ute with Lucky at his feet. Harker got out and walked over to him.

“He can fly,” Harker said. “Rusty on the first lap. Clean by the third. The NDB work was solid.” He looked at Arthur, who was tying down the 172. “I’ll do the paperwork this week. He’s current when I say he’s current.”

Miro nodded. His expression said he had identified a gap in his operation and filled it. “Thanks, Bill.”

“Thank me by not calling during the cricket.”

Crowley’s General Supply was on the main street between the pub and the post office — a tin-roofed building with a verandah and a hand-painted sign that said CROWLEY’S in letters that had once been red and were now the color of old brick.

Keith Crowley met them at the door, which was open because the door was always open.

“Miro! And this must be — you’re Helen’s cousin? Ted mentioned you’d be coming through eventually. Keith Crowley. Come in, come in. Donna! It’s Miro and the new fellow.”

Keith was mid-sixties, round, energetic, with a voice calibrated for a room twice this size. He shook Arthur’s hand with both of his and didn’t let go for a while. Donna appeared from the back — same age, shorter, glasses on a chain, already wiping her hands on her apron for the handshake.

“Arthur, isn’t it? Ted’s told us about you. How are you settling in? It’s a lot to take in at first, isn’t it, Keith?”

“Lot to take in. I remember when we came out from Adelaide — what was it, Donna, ninety-six?”

“Ninety-seven.”

“Ninety-seven. Right. And I said to Donna, I said—”

“He said he’d give it two years.”

“I said I’d give it two years.”

“That was twenty-eight years ago.”

“Twenty-eight years,” Keith confirmed, with the satisfaction of an argument lost so completely it had become a point of pride.

Miro moved through the shop with the ease of long practice, collecting items from a list and stacking them on the counter. Arthur helped carry and watched the prices go onto the station account. Fencing wire. Fuel additive. Veterinary supplies — drench, pour-on, a box of syringes. Food staples — flour, sugar, tinned goods, rice in twenty-kilo bags. A case of beer. The numbers accumulated on Keith’s pad in pencil, and Arthur’s mind did what it always did with numbers: it organized them, categorized them, started running ratios. Fuel was expensive. Everything was expensive, because everything came from somewhere else — Adelaide, Darwin, Alice Springs — and the freight cost was baked into every price.

“How’s Ted going?” Donna asked, wrapping the veterinary supplies.

“Good,” Miro said. “Same as ever.”

“And the Warners? Sarah looked tired last time she was in.”

“They’re working hard. You know the Warners.”

“Tell Sarah I’ve got those seeds she asked about. Native basil. I’ll put them aside.”

They loaded the ute. Keith and Donna helped carry boxes and talked through the process without pausing — about the weather, about a road crew that had come through last month, about whether the pub had fixed its hot water yet. Arthur liked them. They were the kind of people who made a small town hold together, not because they did anything extraordinary but because they were always there, always open, always glad to see you.

The pub was called the Mulga Creek Hotel, which was generous by about three stars. It was a low brick building with a corrugated iron roof and a verandah with two plastic chairs and a dog bowl. Inside it was dim and cool and smelled like beer and floor polish and the particular stillness of a room that had hosted ten thousand quiet afternoons.

Arthur got a beer at the bar. There were three other people in the room — two at a corner table over a newspaper, one at the bar nursing something short.

“You’d be the new bloke on the station.”

The man beside him at the bar was mid-forties, solid through the shoulders, with a face that looked like it had been assembled for reliability rather than show. Short hair going grey at the sides. Hands around a beer glass, relaxed. He was in a polo shirt and jeans — no uniform, no badge, nothing that announced anything except a man having a drink after work.

“Arthur.”

“Dave Rennie.” He shook hands without standing up. “Miro said you might come in. I’m the police presence in Mulga Creek, such as it is. Me and Constable Hayes, who’s on leave more than he’s on duty, so mostly just me.”

“Miro mentioned you.”

“Did he say anything flattering?”

“He said you were a good cop who doesn’t miss much.”

“That’s flattering by Miro’s standards. I’ll take it.” He gestured toward a table by the window. “You want to sit? It’s more civilized than shouting over the bar.”

They moved. The light through the window was late afternoon, warm and angled, casting the room in shades of amber. Rennie drank his beer without hurry. He’d learned that silence wasn’t a gap to be filled but a space to be used.

“How are you finding it?” he asked. “The station.”

“I like it. It’s — big.”

“It is that. Biggest property this side of the highway. Helen’s old man built it up from nothing much. Good operation, when it’s running right.” He looked at Arthur over his beer. “Ted tells me you’re from the government side of things. Back in the States.”

“Was. Federal agency. I left.”

“People leave government work for all kinds of reasons. Most of them bad.” He said this with a half-smile that made it an observation, not a question.

Arthur liked him.

“I saw some things on the supply run that I wanted to ask you about,” Arthur said. “The Patersons had a fence cut on their eastern boundary. Clean, deliberate. And June Paterson’s been keeping a log — road closures, service changes, contractors who don’t explain themselves. Five disruptions in seven months, always the east access.”

Rennie listened.

“Then from the air a few days ago, Miro and I spotted vehicle tracks on station land — eastern section, near the government boundary. Fresh. No one from the station had been out there.”

Rennie set down his beer. “You’re not the first person to mention this sort of thing. I’ve had three other properties come to me in the past few months. Access disruptions, survey crews nobody called for, that kind of business. I drove out to the Henrys’ place — they’re about forty K east of you — and found tracks and a fence down. Same story. Clean cut, no explanation.”

“Any idea who?”

“Meridian Resources. Mining company. They got exploration licenses across the district from the Territory government last year. Mineral assessments — rare earths, mostly. Doesn’t mean it’s them doing the cutting and the driving, but they’re the ones with boots on the ground out here. They’ve got crews and contractors and subcontractors and I’d wager half of them don’t know the boundaries of what they’re licensed to do.”

Arthur drank his beer. Meridian Resources. A mining company with government licenses and contractors who overstepped. It was exactly the

kind of thing June had been documenting — institutional pressure applied through bureaucratic channels by people who assumed remote meant unoccupied. He'd spent a career watching this pattern. Companies got licenses, licenses got interpreted broadly, contractors got sloppy or aggressive, and the people on the ground got squeezed. It happened in Virginia. It happened in Mongolia. It happened here.

"Is there anything actionable?" he asked.

"Not yet. Trespassing's hard to prove when the other side has government paper. Fence damage I can write up, but it goes to a magistrate in Alice Springs who's got a hundred files ahead of it." Rennie shrugged. "I'm watching. It's what I can do right now."

The door opened and Miro came in, the light behind him, Lucky waiting outside. He got a beer at the bar and came to the table.

"Bill signed him off," Miro said to Rennie, by way of greeting.

"Congratulations," Rennie said to Arthur. "You're now qualified to fly in the middle of nowhere. The perks are tremendous."

"We were talking about the tracks," Arthur said to Miro.

Miro sat down. "Someone's been on our land. It's not the first time — fence cut at the Patersons', road closures, contractors nobody sent for." His tone was harder than Arthur's had been. Not angry — definite. "I've been on that station twenty years. I know every track. That wasn't one of ours."

"I hear you," Rennie said. "Same thing at the Henrys' and a couple of others. Meridian's name keeps coming up. I'm keeping a record." He looked at Miro. "If you find anything else — tracks, damage, people where they shouldn't be — let me know. Dates, locations. The more I've got, the more I can do with it."

"I will," Miro said.

They finished their beers. Rennie shook Arthur's hand at the door and said to come back anytime — the pub wasn't going anywhere and neither was he. He said it lightly but Arthur heard the other thing in it: *I'm here. If you need me, I'm here.*

The drive back was quiet for the first twenty minutes. Lucky slept in the back. The highway was empty and the sun was dropping and the country was turning the color it turned at this hour — red going deep, shadows stretching, the sky beginning its long shift from white to gold.

“The station account at Crowley’s,” Arthur said. “The numbers are high.”

Miro drove. “Everything’s high out here. Freight adds thirty percent to anything that comes from Adelaide. Fuel’s worse.”

“I’m not talking about the prices. I’m talking about the volume. The station’s spending a lot for what it’s producing.”

Miro was quiet for a moment. “That’s a question for Ted and Helen. I do the work. Ted does the books. Helen owns it.” He adjusted his grip on the wheel. “But if you’re asking whether the numbers add up — I’ve wondered myself.”

Arthur let it sit. He watched the road and thought about margins and freight costs and the price of cattle at the Alice Springs yards and the number of head the station was running and the cost of maintaining fourteen bore pumps across an area the size of a small country. His mind did this without being asked. It was what his mind was for.

That evening, after dinner — lamb chops, straightforward, nobody experimenting — Arthur sat at his desk.

Hel — Town day. Miro took me to the airstrip and a man called Bill Harker put me through a check-ride. I’m current again — he ran me through his 172 and is sorting the paperwork for the station’s 182, which means Miro has a second pilot and I have something I’m actually good at. We did an NDB approach, which is instrument flying with equipment from approximately 1953. I enjoyed it more than I should have.

Met the Crowleys at the supply shop — Keith and Donna. They’ve been in Mulga Creek since 1997 and I think they’ve talked continuously since then. Good people. Everything goes on the station account.

Which brings me to something I noticed. The running costs on that account are substantial. Fuel, fencing, vet supplies, food — the freight alone is significant. I don't know what the revenue side looks like, but the expense side made me pay attention. I'm not trying to insert myself into the finances. I just notice numbers. It's what I do.

Also met Sgt. Dave Rennie — the local cop. Dry, smart, unhurried. He says other properties in the district are seeing the same kind of disruptions June Paterson's been logging. Apparently a mining company called Meridian Resources has exploration licenses across the region. Same story everywhere — contractors who overstep, fences down, roads closed without notice. Rennie's keeping a record. It's a regional problem, not specific to us. I told him what we've seen and he said to keep noting anything new.

The town is small and real and I liked it. —A

He sent it and went to the verandah. Miro was there, but Ted had turned in early. They sat in the dark and listened to the night — wind in the mulga, something moving in the scrub, Lucky dreaming under the chair.

"Thanks for today," Arthur said. "The check-ride. Setting it up."

"Thank me by flying when I need you to fly."

"I will."

Miro drank his beer. "Rennie's a good man. He'll do what he can. But he's one cop in a town with two hundred people and a district the size of Belgium. If Meridian decides to push, he can't push back on his own."

"You think they will?"

"I think someone's already been on our land," Miro said. "And I think they didn't ask."

He finished his beer and went to bed. Arthur sat on the verandah and listened to the dark and didn't think about Meridian Resources, because it was a mining company he'd never heard of, doing what mining companies did everywhere, and it had nothing to do with him.

Helen's reply came at eleven.

Arthur — I'm glad about the flying. That sounds like you.

The finances. You're right to notice. The station has been running at a loss for about three years. Not a crisis — I can cover it — but it's a drain, and it's been getting worse. Dad ran it lean. Since he died the economics have shifted — cattle prices are flat, fuel costs are up, and the distance kills us on freight. Ted does his best but he's a stockman, not an accountant. I haven't pushed it because I didn't know what to push toward. Selling is an option I haven't wanted to think about.

If you see things that could be done differently, I want to hear them. You're the first person on that station who thinks in systems.

And Arthur — Meridian Resources. That name is everywhere in the Territory right now. Big company, government backing, lots of money. Be careful what you step into out there. Not everything that looks like bureaucratic sloppiness is sloppy.

Love, H

He read it twice. He thought about the account at Crowley's and the fourteen bore pumps and the freight costs and the price of beef. He thought about Helen saying *you're the first person on that station who thinks in systems*. He thought about the station bleeding money for three years while the economics shifted around it.

He didn't think about Meridian. Helen was cautious by nature. Mining companies were always stepping on people out here. It was the industry, not the company.

He closed the laptop and went to bed.

Chapter 8 — The Truck

Ted was up before the light.

Arthur heard him moving through the house — the creak of the hall floorboard, the kettle, the screen door opening and closing with the careful quiet of a man trying not to wake anyone and not quite managing it. By the time Arthur came out to the kitchen, Ted had tea made and was sitting at the table with a list, reading glasses low on his nose, pencil moving down the page.

“Supply run,” he said, without looking up. “Warners and Reg. I want to get out early — the track to the Warners’ is better before the heat softens it.” He circled something on the list. “You want to help load?”

“I’ll get dressed.”

The truck was in the shed — the big Toyota, the one that carried the fuel drums and fencing wire and everything else the route families needed. Arthur had ridden in it with Ted on the first supply run and knew its sounds: the diesel rattle, the suspension complaint, the way the steering pulled left on corrugations. Ted backed it into the yard and they started loading.

Ted talked while he worked, the way he always did — not filling silence but genuinely wanting to share what was on his mind. This morning it was the families.

“Sam Warner’s reading about Alexander the Great now,” he said, lifting a box of tinned goods onto the tray. “His mother told me last time I was out. Twelve years old, sitting on the verandah with a book about Macedonian cavalry tactics. I asked him what he’d learned and he talked for ten minutes straight. Didn’t draw breath.” He settled the box and reached for the next. “And Lily — Lily asked me to bring her a chess book. A proper one, with notation. I found one in Alice Springs, secondhand. She’ll have it memorized by the time I get back.”

Arthur handed up a fuel drum. “She beat me in about fifteen moves.”

“She beats everyone in about fifteen moves. I’ve got a theory that she’s some kind of chess genius and the world just hasn’t noticed because she

lives three hours from the nearest town.” He grinned. “I told Sarah. She said Lily’s also a genius at leaving her boots in the middle of the kitchen floor.”

They loaded fencing wire, veterinary supplies, a box of mail. Ted had a system — heavy items low and forward, lighter goods stacked behind, everything lashed. He’d done this hundreds of times and his hands knew the sequence the way Miro’s hands knew the bore pump.

“I want to check the Patersons’ fence on the way through,” Ted said. “See how the repair’s holding. And I’ll have a look at those tracks Miro spotted from the air — they’re not far off the eastern route.” He pulled a strap tight and tested it. “Reg’s knees are getting worse. He won’t say so but he’s moving slower every time I’m out there. I keep telling him to see the doctor in Alice and he keeps telling me he’s fine.”

“Is he fine?”

“He’s seventy-eight and he’s been on his feet since he was sixteen. He’s not fine. But he won’t leave that place and I can’t make him.” Ted climbed down from the tray. “I’ll take him some of Donna Crowley’s ginger cake. She made one for him last week and he ate the whole thing in two days, which for Reg is practically gluttony.”

Arthur looked at the loaded truck. “You know all of them.”

“Twenty-five years of supply runs. You get to know people.” Ted took off his hat and wiped his forehead. “That’s the job, really. The cattle and the fencing and the bores — that’s the work. But the job is the people. Making sure they’ve got what they need. Making sure they’re all right.” He put his hat back on. “I’ll head out after breakfast. Should be at the Warners’ by noon.”

Miro came out of the stockman’s quarters at six-thirty. He walked to the truck without greeting anyone, which was normal, and started his check, which was also normal. He’d done this before every supply run Arthur had been aware of — tires, oil, coolant, the load straps, the lights. He did it the way he did everything: methodically, without hurry, trusting the routine because the routine caught things.

He was under the truck for about a minute. Then the movement stopped.

Arthur was on the verandah with his tea. He watched Miro's boots, which were visible beneath the chassis. They didn't move. Five seconds. Ten.

Miro slid out and stood up. He didn't look at Arthur. He looked toward the kitchen where Ted was making toast.

"Ted."

One word. Flat. Ted came to the door.

"Come here."

Ted walked over. Arthur set his tea down and followed. Miro was crouched beside the front axle, pointing at the underside of the truck.

The brake line ran along the chassis rail, a rubber hose connecting the master cylinder to the front calipers. There was fluid on the ground — a small dark stain on the red dirt, fresh enough that the edges were still wet. Miro pointed to the line itself. Arthur crouched beside him and saw it: a cut. Not a crack, not a wear point. A slice through the rubber, clean and deliberate, made with something sharp. The line wasn't severed — it was opened enough to weep.

"That's not wear," Miro said.

Ted was on his knees now, looking. His face changed. Arthur watched it happen — the warmth going out, replaced by something cold and focused.

"No," Ted said. "That's not wear."

"The brakes would work when you pulled out," Miro said. "Pressure in the system, fluid still there. But it's leaking. An hour, maybe two, and they'd start going soft. After that—" He didn't finish.

After that, Ted would be on a station track in a loaded truck with no brakes. On flat ground he'd roll to a stop. On the descent to the creek crossing, or coming into a cattle grid at speed, or on the curve before Reg's gate — maybe not. And if he was hurt and alone, the HF radio in the cab was only useful if he could reach it.

Nobody said anything for a moment. The three of them crouched by the truck in the early light and looked at the cut line and the stain on the ground.

Ted stood up first. "Who's been on the property?"

"Nobody I've seen," Miro said. "Nobody I've sent for."

"The shed's not locked."

"It's never been locked."

Ted looked at the truck. He looked at the shed, the open door, the yard that anyone could have driven into in the dark. His jaw was set. Arthur had seen Ted warm, seen him patient, seen him amused. He hadn't seen this — an anger that didn't raise the temperature but lowered it. Cold and clean and directed.

"The families," Ted said. "If someone did this here, they could do it at the Warners'. At the Patersons'. Reg doesn't check anything — he just gets in and drives."

He was already walking toward the house.

Ted's voice on the HF radio was calm, specific, and carried the authority of twenty-five years talking to these families. He called the Warners first.

"Matt, it's Ted. Listen to me carefully. Before you drive anything today, I need you to get under your vehicles and check the brake lines. Both of them. You're looking for any cut or damage to the rubber hoses — anything that looks deliberate. Check for fluid on the ground underneath. Don't drive until you've looked."

Matt Warner's voice came back thin and scratched with static. "Ted? What's happened?"

"Someone's tampered with our supply truck. Cut a brake line. I don't want to assume it's just us. Check everything and call me back."

He called the Patersons. June's voice was sharp and immediate — she didn't need things explained twice. She said Don would check both vehicles and the quad bike and she'd call back within the hour.

He called Reg. Reg's radio was slow to answer and when it did his voice was gravel and distant. Ted told him what to look for. Reg said something Arthur couldn't hear. Ted said: "I know you don't think anyone's been out there. Look anyway. For me."

Then Ted called Rennie.

Miro had already phoned ahead on the satellite phone, so Rennie was expecting the call. Ted gave him the details — when the truck was last driven, when Miro found the cut, what it looked like. Rennie said he'd drive out. Ted said he'd appreciate it. He put the handset down and sat at the radio for a moment, both hands flat on the desk.

"Twenty-five years," he said. He wasn't talking to Arthur or Miro. He was talking to the room, or to himself. "Twenty-five years and I've never locked the shed."

Rennie arrived just before ten. He'd driven fast — the dust on his vehicle was fresh and his face was set in a way Arthur hadn't seen in the pub. He went to the truck without small talk.

He photographed the brake line from three angles. He photographed the fluid stain on the ground. He took notes — the position of the cut, the type of line, the age of the vehicle. He got under the truck himself and looked at everything Miro had already looked at and came to the same conclusions.

"That's a blade," he said, standing up and brushing dirt off his shirt. "Utility knife, box cutter, something like that. One stroke, controlled. Whoever did it knew where the line was."

"That's not hard to know," Miro said. "It's a Toyota. Every mechanic in the Territory could find it with their eyes closed."

"True. But they came here at night, found the right vehicle, got under it, made the cut, and left without anyone hearing them. That's not random." Rennie looked at Ted. "When did you last drive this truck?"

“Four days ago. Short run to the south bore and back.”

“Brakes fine then?”

“Fine.”

“So sometime in the last four days, someone came onto the property at night and did this.” Rennie closed his notebook. “This isn’t trespass. This isn’t a fence. I can take this to Alice Springs as criminal damage, possibly endangering life. It’ll get attention that the other reports didn’t.”

“Will it get results?” Arthur asked.

Rennie looked at him. “It’ll get it on a desk in Alice Springs that matters more than mine. Whether it gets results depends on things I can’t control.” He paused. “I’ll push it. This is the first thing that’s happened in this district that I can call a crime without qualifying it.”

He asked about security. The answers were what everyone already knew — the shed was unlocked, the property was unfenced at the homestead approach, the dogs hadn’t barked or if they had nobody had woken. Rennie told them to lock the shed. Lock the vehicles at night if they could. Check everything before driving. Document anything unusual — dates, times, details.

“I’ll get out to the families this week,” he said. “Check their vehicles myself. The Henrys and the McAllisters too — if this is escalation, I want to know if it’s wider than your station.”

Ted walked him to his vehicle. Arthur watched them talk — two men in their fifties and sixties, standing in the yard in the morning heat, having a conversation about something that shouldn’t have been necessary. Rennie put his hand on Ted’s shoulder briefly before he got in. Ted stood and watched him drive out until the dust settled.

The supply run was postponed. Miro replaced the brake line — he had spares in the shed, because Miro had spares for everything — and tested it twice before he was satisfied. Ted spent the morning on the radio, following up with the families. The Warners’ vehicles were clean. The Patersons’ vehicles were clean. Reg reported, with audible irritation, that nothing was

wrong with his truck and never had been and he'd appreciate it if people stopped calling him before he'd finished his tea.

Arthur spent the morning thinking.

He stood in the yard and looked at the shed and the approach track and the homestead and ran the sequence in his mind. The fence cut at the Patersons' — clean, deliberate. The road closures June had logged — systematic, escalating. The vehicle tracks on station land, fresh, unauthorized. And now a brake line sliced on the supply truck, positioned to fail after an hour on the road.

This wasn't regional mining pressure. Rennie had said other properties were seeing disruptions, and they were. But those properties had fence damage and road closures. Nobody else had reported a cut brake line. This was different — targeted, specific, aimed at the vehicle that went to the families. Aimed at Ted.

Arthur didn't know who was doing it or why. He didn't know what they wanted — nobody had made demands, nobody had offered to buy, nobody had delivered terms. The pressure was faceless and purposeless, or its purpose wasn't visible yet. But the pattern was unmistakable now. Someone was escalating against this station, and they'd moved from inconvenience to something that could kill.

He thought about the rifle rack in the supply truck and the gun cabinet in the hall and for the first time the thought wasn't reflex. It was assessment.

The verandah that evening was different from every verandah that had come before.

The beer was the same. The chairs were the same. Lucky was under Ted's chair, not Arthur's, as if he'd felt the shift in gravity. The tin roof ticked as it cooled and the stars came out in their usual rush and the country beyond the homestead was dark and enormous and silent.

Ted drank his beer and looked at the dark. He was quiet in a way Arthur hadn't seen — not the comfortable quiet of a day's work done, but the heavy quiet of a man carrying something he hadn't put down yet.

Miro was contained. He'd spent the afternoon fitting a hasp and padlock to the shed door and checking the other vehicles. He'd moved the rifle from the truck rack to inside the house, leaning it by the front door. He hadn't explained why. Nobody had asked.

"Lily's chess book is still in the cab," Ted said, after a while. "I'll take it out tomorrow."

Nobody answered. The sentence sat in the air. Ted had loaded that book this morning while talking about a twelve-year-old boy who read about Macedonian cavalry and a nine-year-old who beat everyone at chess, and then someone's cut brake line had nearly sent him and the fuel drums and the fencing wire and Lily's chess book off a track and into the scrub at sixty kilometers an hour.

"The Warners' kids," Ted said. He stopped. Started again. "If anything happened out there — if someone did this to Matt's vehicle and he was driving with the kids—"

"It didn't happen," Miro said. "We checked. They're clean."

"This time."

Miro didn't answer that. There wasn't an answer.

Arthur drank his beer and watched Ted and understood what he was seeing. Ted had been on this station for twenty-five years. He'd managed drought and flood and broken equipment and injured stock and the slow attrition of distance and isolation. All of that was hard but none of it was hostile. The land didn't care about you, but it didn't come for you. This was different. Someone had come onto the property in the dark and done something that could have killed him, and the thing Ted couldn't put down wasn't the danger to himself — it was the danger to the people on his run. The Warners. The Patersons. Reg alone out there with knees that didn't work and a truck he didn't check.

Ted finished his beer. "I'm going to bed," he said. He stood up slowly, as if he'd aged during the day. "Lock up when you come in."

He'd never said that before.

Arthur sat at his desk and wrote to Helen. The email was different from every email he'd sent her.

Hel — Someone cut the brake line on the supply truck last night. Miro found it this morning during his routine check. The line was sliced — not worn, not cracked. Deliberate. Ted was about to drive it loaded with fuel drums on a five-hour run to the Warners and Reg. If Miro hadn't checked, Ted would have lost brakes somewhere on the track. On flat ground maybe he stops. On the creek descent or a cattle grid approach, maybe he doesn't. And if he was hurt, the HF radio only works if you can reach it.

Rennie came out and documented everything. He's calling it criminal damage, possibly endangering life, and taking it to Alice Springs. The families checked their vehicles — all clean. But Ted's right: this time.

This isn't what I told you about before. The road closures and fence cuts could be explained as regional mining pressure — contractors overstepping, boundaries tested. This can't. Someone came onto the station at night and tampered with a vehicle that a man was about to drive alone into remote country. That's targeted. I don't know what they want. Nobody's made demands or offers. The pressure has no visible purpose, which makes it worse.

We've locked the shed. Miro's moved the rifle inside. We're checking vehicles daily. Rennie's pushing it up the chain. I don't know if that will be enough.

Tell me what you need from me. —A

Helen's reply came within twenty minutes. It was the shortest email she'd sent and the sharpest.

Arthur — I'm coming out there. Not yet, but soon. I need to talk to the solicitor in Alice Springs first and I need to talk to Rennie myself and I need to understand what Meridian Resources is doing in that district and why. Find out everything you can about their operations — licenses, contractors, anything with a name attached. Ask June. Ask Rennie.

In the meantime: whatever you and Ted and Miro need — security, legal, equipment — spend what you need to spend. I'll cover it.

That's my station. Those are my people. Nobody cuts a brake line on my property and walks away from it.

Love, H

He read it twice. He thought about Helen in her house in Bethesda, reading his email at her kitchen table, and the distance between that kitchen and this desk and the dark country outside his window where someone had walked to the shed last night with a knife.

He closed the laptop. Through the wall he could hear Ted's bed creak as the old man turned in his sleep. Through the window, Miro's light was still on.

He sat in the dark and listened and didn't sleep for a long time.

Chapter 9 — The Child

Lily opened with the Sicilian.

Arthur hadn't expected that. On his first visit she'd played the Italian Game — solid, classical, the kind of opening a beginner learns from a book. But the chess book Ted had brought her was not a beginner's book, and Lily had spent two weeks with it, and now she pushed her c-pawn forward two squares and looked at Arthur with an expression that said she'd been waiting for this.

"Where did you learn that?" he said.

"Page forty-seven. It says the Sicilian is the most popular response to e4 at the grandmaster level." She adjusted a piece that didn't need adjusting. "I'm not a grandmaster yet. But I'm practicing."

They played at the kitchen table after dinner. Matt was washing up. Sarah was mending something in the chair by the lamp, her needle moving steadily. Sam was at the other end of the table with a book about Hannibal — he'd moved on from Alexander — and Captain the dog was under the table with his head on Lily's feet, which was apparently where Captain's head always was when Lily was sitting down.

The house was warm and lit by battery lamps that gave everything a yellow cast. It smelled like the stew they'd eaten and the wood fire that Sarah kept going even in weather that didn't need it, because the fire was the center of the house and she wasn't going to let it go out.

Lily played well. Better than well — she played with a patience that was new, thinking three and four moves ahead, sacrificing pieces in ways that made sense only when the trap closed. Arthur lost the first game in twenty-two moves and the second in thirty, and the second loss was worse because he'd been trying.

"You've gotten better," he said.

"I practice against myself. Sam won't play anymore."

Sam looked up from Hannibal. "She cheats."

"I don't cheat. You just can't see what I'm doing until it's too late."

“That’s what cheating looks like from the outside.”

Matt laughed from the kitchen. Sarah shook her head without looking up. Arthur set up the pieces for a third game and felt something settle in him that had been unsettled for days. The brake line. Ted’s face. The locked shed. Miro’s rifle by the front door. All of it was real and none of it was here. Here was a nine-year-old studying grandmaster openings and a twelve-year-old reading about Carthaginian generals and a dog under the table and lamps in the windows against the dark.

He lost the third game too.

In the morning they went to collect eggs.

The chook shed was behind the house — a wire enclosure with a tin roof and nesting boxes along the back wall, home to eleven chickens that Lily had named after chess pieces. The queen was a large red hen who ruled the yard. The two bishops were identical brown birds that Lily could tell apart and Arthur couldn’t. The pawns were everybody else.

“Queen’s been laying double yolks,” Lily said, reaching into a nesting box with the confidence of a child who’d been doing this since she could walk. “Dad says it means she’s healthy. I think she’s showing off.”

Arthur held the basket. The morning was cool and bright — the sky pale blue, the air still, the red dirt dark with overnight dew that would burn off within the hour. Captain had followed them out and was sitting by the wire gate with his ears up, watching the scrub without urgency but without stopping — a station dog’s permanent vigil.

“I want to try the King’s Indian next time,” Lily said. She placed an egg in the basket carefully. “It’s a defensive opening but it has counterattack potential in the middle game. Page sixty-two.”

“You’re going to run out of book.”

“Then I’ll need another book.” She looked at him. “Will you bring me one? Next time you come?”

“I’ll bring you one.”

She smiled and went back to the nesting boxes. Arthur stood in the chook shed holding a basket of eggs and listening to a nine-year-old explain counterattack potential and he was, for that moment, happy in a way that didn't need qualification.

Then he heard the engine.

Diesel, moving fast, coming from the direction of the main track. Not a station vehicle — the sound was wrong, too smooth, too new. Captain stood up at the gate, ears forward. Lily looked at Arthur.

"That's not Dad's truck," she said.

"No."

Arthur set the basket down. Through the wire of the chook shed he could see the yard — the house, the Warners' vehicles parked by the shed, the track coming in from the east. A truck appeared around the bend. White, newish, a dual-cab with no dust on it. It pulled into the yard and stopped and a man got out of the passenger side.

He was mid-thirties, neat, wearing a collared shirt and clean boots. He looked at the house and then at the yard and adjusted his sunglasses on his head. He moved with practiced ease — he'd done this before, walked onto someone else's property and stood in their yard and waited for them to come out.

Matt came out of the house. He was in a work shirt and jeans, still holding his coffee mug. He looked at the man, then at the truck. He set the mug on the verandah rail.

"Can I help you?"

"Matt Warner?" The man smiled. Professional, rehearsed. "Sorry to drop in unannounced. My name's Craig. I'm with a group that's been working in the district — consulting, mainly. We've been talking to a few families in the area."

"Consulting about what?"

"About options. The future out here — it's changing, as I'm sure you know. Services getting harder to access, infrastructure costs going up. We repre-

sent people who could help families like yours transition to something with a bit less pressure. Better opportunities, closer to town.” He said it like a brochure — smooth, reasonable, and entirely without substance.

Matt’s face had gone still. “Who are you with?”

“Just a consulting group. Looking out for your interests.”

“Nobody asked you to look out for my interests.” Matt came down off the verandah. He was a young man and a strong one and his body had changed in the last ten seconds — shoulders square, weight forward. “Someone cut the brake line on our neighbor’s truck a couple of weeks back. Now you’re standing in my yard talking about helping us move. You want to tell me those two things aren’t connected?”

The man called Craig held up his hands. “I don’t know anything about that. We’re just here to have a conversation—”

“Get off my property.”

Craig looked at Matt and saw what Arthur could see from the chook shed: Matt was not going to have this conversation. Craig’s smile didn’t change but his eyes went to the truck. The two men in the cab were watching.

“Matt, there’s no need to—”

“I said get off my property.”

The two men got out of the truck.

They were bigger than Craig and they weren’t wearing collared shirts. They were wearing work boots and jeans and they moved with the unhurried confidence of men who’d been brought along for a reason that had nothing to do with consulting. One was tall and heavy through the chest. The other was shorter, thicker, with arms that said manual labor or gym or both. They walked around the front of the truck and stood behind Craig, and the geometry of the yard changed.

Lily heard her father’s voice. She was already moving — out of the chook shed, past Arthur’s reaching hand, across the yard toward Matt.

“Lily —”

She was fast. Nine years old and fast and she didn't hear him or didn't stop. She ran across the open ground toward her father. Matt saw her and his face changed — he turned toward her and at the same time the tall one stepped forward and Matt shoved Craig hard in the chest, two-handed, and Craig stumbled back into the tall one and the tall one pushed Matt and Lily was between them.

She went down. An elbow or a hip — nobody's hand, nobody's intent — caught her as she ran into the space where bodies were colliding. She hit the hard-packed dirt on her side and her hands went out and she skidded and she screamed. Not a loud scream. The short sharp cry of a child in pain and surprise.

Arthur was already moving. He'd come out of the chook shed when Lily ran and he'd been crossing the yard and when she hit the ground something in him that had been banked since a parking lot in Virginia went to full burn. He wasn't thinking. His body was thinking. His body had been keeping inventory since the day he arrived — the rifle rack, the gun cabinet, the distances, the exits — and now his body took over and his mind went quiet.

The tall one had his back half-turned. He was still tangled with Matt and Craig and he didn't see Arthur until Arthur hit him from the side, low, driving his shoulder into the man's ribs and taking him off his feet. They went down together. The tall one was heavy and he knew how to fall — he got an arm up and caught Arthur across the jaw, a glancing shot that snapped Arthur's head sideways and filled his mouth with copper. Arthur drove his elbow into the man's solar plexus, felt it land, felt the air go out of him. He hit him again, in the same spot, and the man's grip loosened and Arthur got on top and hit him once more in the face with his right hand and the man's head went back against the dirt and he stopped.

Matt had the shorter one. He'd grabbed the man by the shirt front with both hands and lifted him — not technique, just the raw strength of throwing cattle since he was fourteen. He slammed the man against the side of the truck and held him there, feet off the ground, and the man's face went white. Matt hit him once, a short right hand with his whole shoulder behind it, and the man's head bounced off the truck panel and Matt dropped him and he sat down in the dirt and didn't get up.

Craig hadn't moved. He was standing where Matt had shoved him, three steps back from the truck, and his face had the blank look of a man watching a plan disintegrate. His hands were still up. He looked at his two men on the ground and then at Matt, who was breathing hard with blood on his knuckles, and then at Arthur, who was standing over the tall one with a split lip and hands that were shaking.

"Get off my property," Matt said again. He wasn't loud. He didn't need to be.

The screen door opened. Sarah came out of the house with a rifle — the .30-30 that hung above the kitchen door. She held it across her body, barrel angled down, finger outside the trigger guard. She didn't point it at anyone. She stood on the verandah and she didn't need to point it at anyone.

"You heard him," she said.

The tall one got up slowly, holding his ribs. The shorter one got up from the side of the truck, touching his jaw. Craig looked at Sarah and the rifle and then he walked to the truck. The two men followed. They got in. Craig started the engine.

The shorter one — the one Matt had put into the truck panel — looked back as they drove out. He didn't look at Arthur. He didn't look at Matt. He looked at the property — the house, the shed, the chook shed, the water tank, the fences. He looked at it the way you look at something you intend to come back to.

Then they were gone, and the dust lifted behind them and hung in the still morning air.

Sam was behind the water tank.

He was sitting on the ground with Lily in his arms, her face against his chest. She was crying — not the loud wail of a frightened child but the quiet, shaking kind that comes after the fear has peaked and settled into something worse. Her hands were scraped and bleeding. Her knees were torn through her jeans. Sam was holding her the way you hold something that might break, and his face above her head was pale and set.

Arthur knelt beside them. "Lily. Let me see your hands."

She held them out. Scraped palms, grit embedded, blood seeping. Her knees were the same. Nothing broken, nothing deep. She looked at Arthur with eyes that were wet and wide and wanted an explanation he couldn't give.

"You're okay," he said. "We're going to go inside and clean these up."

Sam looked at Arthur. "I got the plate," he said.

Arthur stared at him.

Sam held up his left hand. Written on the back, in pencil, in the careful handwriting Sam used for his notes on Macedonian cavalry and Carthaginian generals: a license plate number. Six characters.

"I could see the truck from here," Sam said. "I thought someone should write it down."

Inside, Arthur cleaned Lily's hands with antiseptic from the first-aid kit. She sat at the kitchen table and held still while he picked grit from her palms with tweezers. She didn't cry. Her jaw was set in a way that reminded him of her father. The chess book was on the table where they'd left it last night, open to page sixty-two. The King's Indian Defense. Counterattack potential in the middle game.

Matt was on the HF radio to Rennie. He gave the details — three men, a white dual-cab, the pitch about consulting and transition, the fight, Lily knocked down. He read out the plate number from Sam's hand. Rennie copied it and said he was leaving now.

Sarah put the rifle back above the kitchen door. She made tea. She put a cup in front of Arthur without asking and he drank it and realized his hands were still shaking. His lip was split and swelling. His jaw ached where the tall one had caught him. His right hand was swollen across the knuckles, the skin broken in two places.

"Thank you," Sarah said. She said it once and she said it looking at him and that was enough.

Matt came back from the radio. "Rennie's coming. An hour, maybe less." He looked at Arthur's face. "You've done that before."

“Once.”

“You’re good at it.”

“I’m adequate at it. Your cattle-throwing was the highlight.”

Matt almost smiled. He looked at Lily, whose hands were bandaged now and who was sitting at the table with the chess book open, not reading it but holding it. Matt’s almost-smile went away.

“They’ll come back,” he said.

“Maybe,” Arthur said. “But Rennie will have the plate by then. And next time they won’t find what they found today.”

“What will they find?”

Arthur looked at the rifle above the door. He looked at Matt. He looked at Lily, who was nine years old and had scraped hands and had been knocked down in her own yard by men who came to tell her family they should leave.

“They’ll find people who aren’t leaving,” Arthur said.

Rennie arrived in fifty minutes. Arthur gave his account, then waited while Rennie took statements from Matt, Sarah, and Sam. Sam showed him the plate on his hand. Rennie looked at it for a long moment and then looked at Sam and said, “That’s good police work, son.” Sam stood a little taller.

Arthur shook Matt’s hand and knelt down to Lily, who was on the verandah with Captain’s head in her lap.

“I’ll bring that chess book,” he said.

“The King’s Indian one?”

“Whatever you want.”

She looked at his swollen lip. “Does it hurt?”

“A bit.”

She said, “I hope you hurt them more.”

He drove back to the homestead in the late afternoon. The track was rough and the ute bounced over corrugations and his jaw ached with each one and his right hand throbbed on the steering wheel. The country rolled past — red earth, scrub, the long flat emptiness that had confused him when he'd first arrived and now looked like what it was. Home.

He pulled into the yard and got out and Ted and Miro were on the verandah. They'd heard the ute coming and they were standing now, beers in hand, watching him walk across the yard.

Ted saw his face first. The split lip, the swelling along his jaw, the knuckles. He looked at Arthur's hands the way he'd looked at them the day he'd picked him up at Alice Springs airport — the same quick glance, the same decision not to ask the obvious question. Except this time he knew the answer before Arthur said anything.

"Three men," Arthur said. "At the Warners'. They came to tell Matt his family should think about leaving. Matt disagreed. I helped him disagree."

Miro looked at Arthur's knuckles. "The other bloke look worse?"

"Both of them."

"Good."

Ted didn't say good. Ted sat down in his chair and put his beer on the armrest and looked at the yard. He was quiet for a long time.

"Lily?" he said.

"Scraped. Scared. Not hurt badly. She got knocked down when it went physical. Sam pulled her clear."

Ted nodded. He picked up his beer and drank and set it down again. "Sam's a good boy."

"He got their plate number. Wrote it on his hand while he was hiding with Lily behind the water tank. Rennie has it."

Ted looked at him. Something moved across his face — pride and grief and anger, all of it brief, all of it controlled.

“She’s nine,” Ted said. “She plays chess and she names her chickens and she’s nine years old and they knocked her down in her own yard.”

Nobody answered. There was nothing to answer. The three of them sat on the verandah as the light went long and the country turned the color it turned at this hour and the stars began to show. The tin roof ticked. Lucky came out from under Ted’s chair and lay at Arthur’s feet, and Arthur reached down and scratched his ears and said nothing.

The rifle was still by the front door where Miro had put it. Nobody had moved it. Nobody was going to.

Chapter 10 — The Truth

Lucky was waiting on the verandah when Arthur came out.

Not waiting, exactly. Lying in the cool near the door with his head on his paws, a station dog holding the line between night and morning. He lifted his head when the screen door opened and his tail moved once against the boards.

Arthur hadn't planned to walk. He'd come out for the quiet before anyone else was up — to sit with his tea and think about what he needed to write to Helen and what he owed Ted and Miro and how to begin saying it. But Lucky stood when Arthur stepped off the verandah, and stood in a way that was clearly an invitation, and Arthur found himself walking.

They went east, toward the low ridge that ran behind the bore paddock. The light was grey and building. No wind. The air was cool enough that Arthur could feel the night still in it, and the red dirt under his boots was dark with moisture that would burn off within the hour. Lucky moved ahead of him on the track — not far, ten or fifteen meters — and then circled back and moved ahead again, checking, returning, the easy rhythm of a dog who knew this country and was pleased to have company in it.

Arthur walked and let his mind go where it needed to go.

The Warners' yard. Lily on the ground. His own hands, still swollen, the knuckles scabbed and stiff. Matt's grip on the shorter man's shirt, lifting him off his feet like a fence post. Sarah on the verandah with the rifle. Sam's pencil handwriting on the back of his hand.

He flexed his right hand and felt the pull of split skin. His jaw ached when he worked it. These were not old injuries. He'd acquired them yesterday in someone else's yard, fighting someone else's fight, and the thing that surprised him — the thing he'd been turning over since the drive home — was how little hesitation there had been. At Best Buy he'd been ambushed and his body had responded before his mind caught up. At the Warners' he'd seen Lily go down and crossed the yard with something that felt less like reflex and more like purpose.

Lucky stopped ahead and looked back at him. Arthur caught up and they stood together on the low ridge. Below them the bore paddock stretched south, the windmill turning slowly in air Arthur couldn't feel. Beyond that, scrub and distance and the pale line of the track running toward the ranges. He could see the homestead behind him — tin roof, the machinery shed, the yard where the vehicles sat. Miro's quarters. The water tank. Small and coherent against the vast country around it.

He'd been here long enough now that the landscape had begun to make sense. Not Miro's sense — he'd need twenty years for that — but a basic grammar. The colour of the soil told him what grew there. The pattern of the mulga said something about water. The ridgeline's broken profile said something about wind. Miro had taught him these things without teaching them, the way you learn a language by living in it.

Lucky sat beside him, ears up, watching something Arthur couldn't see. Arthur put his hand on the dog's head and left it there and looked at the country and composed in his mind what he would write to Helen.

He wrote the email after breakfast, sitting at his desk while Ted and Miro loaded the truck for the postponed supply run to Reg.

Hel — Yesterday three men drove onto the Warners' property. The front man called himself Craig. Collared shirt, clean boots, a speech about helping families transition to something easier. Corporate relocation pitch — smooth, practiced, empty. Matt told him to leave. The two men in the truck got out. They weren't there for conversation.

It went physical. Lily ran out during the confrontation and got knocked down — not hit, not targeted, but caught in the collision. Scraped hands, scraped knees, scared. Matt and I handled the two men. Sarah came out with a rifle. They left.

Sam — twelve years old — pulled Lily behind the water tank and wrote down the license plate number. Rennie has it.

I've been putting pieces together. The fence cuts, the road closures June logged, the vehicle tracks on station land, the brake line, and now this visit. It's the same playbook. Pressure the families, cut services, make the land untenable,

offer to help them leave. I've seen this before. I saw it in the files I reported on — different country, different resources, same method. I don't think this is a coincidence anymore.

I need to tell Ted and Miro what's going on. The full story — not just why I'm here, but what I think is happening and who I think is behind it. They've earned that. Ted had his brake line cut and he's heard about Lily. Miro's been locking sheds and moving rifles. They're in this and they deserve to know why.

What do you want me to do? —A

He sent it and went outside. The morning was heating up and the yard smelled like diesel and dust. Ted was checking the load straps on the truck, his hat pushed back, muttering through his checklist. Miro was in the shed doing something with a wrench that involved concentration and occasional profanity.

Arthur helped Ted finish the lashing and then spent an hour on the water pump behind the house, which had developed a rattle that Miro had diagnosed from forty meters away and prescribed a new bearing for. Arthur pulled the housing apart, replaced the bearing from Miro's supply of spares, and reassembled it. The work was good. It occupied his hands and let his mind rest and when the pump ran clean and quiet he felt the small satisfaction of a thing put right.

Helen's reply came just before noon.

Arthur — Tell them. Tell them everything. They're not bystanders and you're right, they've earned it.

Here's where I am. The station has been losing money for three years. Not dramatically — it's not a crisis — but the trend is clear and I've been covering the shortfall because Dad loved that place and I wasn't ready to make a decision about it. I'm telling you this because Ted and Miro should know: I am not selling. I am not walking away. The station is funded and will stay funded as long as this situation is active. Whatever you need — a solicitor, security, equipment — spend it.

But I'll be honest with you the way you're honest with me. This can't go on indefinitely. The station needs to pay for itself eventually, or at least get close.

That's not an ultimatum and it's not urgent. It's just the truth. If there are ways to run it better or bring in more revenue, I want to hear them.

Find a solicitor in Alice Springs. Someone sharp, someone who knows mining and land rights, someone who is absolutely not connected to Meridian Resources. Use your judgment on timing. I trust you on the ground.

And Arthur — be careful. These people have already cut a brake line and sent men to intimidate a family with children. They'll do more.

Love, H

Arthur read it twice. Helen's voice was there in every sentence — the intelligence, the warmth, the refusal to soften what needed to be said. She'd laid out the financial truth without apology and backed it with commitment. He thought about Ted and Miro on the verandah tonight, and what Helen's words would mean to them, and what they might mean for Miro, who'd worked twenty years without equity, and Ted, who'd managed a station for twenty-five without ever being asked what he thought it could become.

The afternoon was fence wire.

A section of the holding paddock near the yards had come loose — not cut, not tampered with, just old wire and older posts giving way to time and cattle. Ted had flagged it that morning and Arthur and Miro drove out in the ute to fix it. They worked for two hours in the heat, pulling wire, resetting staples, bracing a post that had rotted at the base. Miro worked with the economy of long practice — every motion purposeful, nothing wasted. Arthur was slower but competent now. He'd learned the fencing pliers and the wire strainer and the knack of holding tension while setting a staple, and Miro had stopped checking his work a few weeks ago.

They didn't talk much. The heat discouraged conversation and the work had its own rhythm. At one point Miro straightened up and looked at the repaired section and said, "That'll hold," and it was the only assessment Arthur needed.

On the drive back, Lucky rode in the tray. He'd followed the ute out and supervised the fencing from the shade of a mulga tree, appearing at the

vehicle when the tools went back in, as if he'd been timing the job. He stood in the tray with his nose into the wind and his ears flat and looked like the happiest creature in Central Australia.

"Dog's taken to you," Miro said, without looking over.

"He followed me this morning. We walked out to the ridge."

"He doesn't follow everyone."

Miro said it flat, a statement of fact, and went back to watching the track. Arthur let it sit. Lucky's claws clicked on the tray behind them as the ute bounced over a rut.

The verandah that evening was quiet as always — the tin roof ticking, the chairs, the beers, the dark coming on. Ted was in his usual spot. Miro was in his. Lucky had come to Arthur's chair instead of Ted's and was lying with his head on Arthur's boot. Ted noticed but didn't comment.

Arthur drank his beer and looked at the two men and decided there was no right way to begin this, so he began.

"I need to tell you both something. Not because anything's changed — you already know what's happening out here. But you don't know all of why, and you should."

Ted set his beer on the armrest. Miro didn't move.

"I worked for a federal agency in Washington," Arthur said. "Environmental oversight. My job was reviewing compliance reports from companies with government contracts — mining, mostly. Foreign operations. Three years ago I found a company called Meridian Resources running a rare earth mining operation overseas that was in violation of about fifteen different statutes. Environmental dumping. Labor violations. Safety numbers that were fiction. The works."

He kept it short. The facts in order, no editorializing. He told them he'd filed a report through proper channels and his supervisor had buried it. He'd filed again, higher, and been told the matter was under review. Six months of under review while the violations continued. He'd gone to the Inspector

General. The IG had referred it to the FBI. Special Agent Diana Marsh at the Washington Field Office had been assigned to the case. Nothing happened. His friend Rob Kessler, in a different division, had warned him that Meridian's government affairs budget was larger than some agencies' operating budgets.

"So I went outside," Arthur said. "Gave the files to a journalist. The story ran. Congressional inquiry opened, Meridian's stock dropped four percent for about a week, and then the lobbying machine spun up and the inquiry went sideways and I became the problem instead of the solution."

Ted was leaning forward in his chair. "They came after you."

"Whistleblower protections are supposed to prevent that. They didn't. I was reassigned, investigated for unauthorized disclosure, had my clearance pulled. Then the threats started. Phone calls, a car outside my apartment, my gym broken into. Nothing I could prove came from Meridian directly — it never does. The agency had a slush fund for problems like me. Meridian contributed independently. Two sources of pressure, both deniable."

"CWIR," Ted said.

"That's what I told Helen. Cowards With Infinite Resources. Two men jumped me in a parking lot outside a Best Buy in Virginia. They expected a bureaucrat. I'd been doing Krav Maga for six years because my friend Maya ran a gym and it was cheaper than therapy." He looked at his knuckles, still scabbed from yesterday. "I hurt them both. Then I called Helen and she offered me this place. And I came."

The dark had settled fully now. The stars were out — the dense bright wash of them that Arthur had never seen before he came here and still couldn't look at without feeling the scale of it. Ted's face was in shadow but Arthur could see his posture — upright, attentive, processing.

"Meridian Resources," Ted said. "That's the name."

"That's the name. Mid-cap mining company, operations on four continents. Government affairs budget that dwarfs their R&D. They operate through subsidiaries and partners — layers of separation between the parent and whatever's happening on the ground."

“And you think they’re here.”

“I think what’s happening to this station and these families looks exactly like what I saw in the files I reported on. Different country, different resource, same playbook. Pressure the people on the land. Cut their services. Make it untenable. Wait for them to leave or sell cheap. If they don’t, escalate. The fence cuts, the road closures, the brake line — that’s not random. That’s a sequence.”

Ted was quiet for a long time. He picked up his beer and drank and set it down. When he spoke, his voice was careful.

“You came here to get away from them. And they’re already here.”

“I don’t know that for certain. But the pattern is the same. And now they’ve sent men to the Warners’ yard to tell them to leave.” Arthur paused. “I should have told you sooner. I didn’t because I wasn’t sure, and because I didn’t want to be the man who brought his problems to someone else’s door. But after yesterday — after Lily — you and Miro deserve to know what you’re standing next to.”

Ted shook his head. “You didn’t bring this. If Meridian is here, they were here before you. The road closures started before you arrived. June’s been logging things for months.” He looked at Arthur. “You just recognized it.”

Miro had been quiet through all of it. He sat in his chair with his beer in his hand and his face unreadable and he’d been listening — completely, without interruption, absorbing everything and giving nothing back until he was ready.

Now he spoke. “I wondered when you’d get around to it.”

Arthur looked at him.

“A bloke turns up from Washington with busted knuckles and checks every door in the house. Notices the rifle rack before he notices the road. Knows how a brake line gets cut before Rennie explains it.” Miro drank his beer. “I didn’t know the details. But I knew it wasn’t a family visit.”

Arthur almost laughed. “How long?”

“Since the first week. Ted’s too polite to say it.”

Ted shook his head again, but he was almost smiling. “I’m not too polite. I just figured you’d tell us when you were ready. And here we are.”

The three of them sat with it for a moment. The night sounds — insects, a distant bird, Lucky’s breathing at Arthur’s feet. Arthur felt something loosen in his chest that had been tight since he’d arrived. Not relief exactly. More like the end of carrying something alone.

“Helen’s been in touch,” Arthur said. “She wants you to know the station is covered financially. Whatever we need — legal, security, equipment — she’s backing it. She’s committed to this.”

“Helen’s a good woman,” Ted said.

“She’s also honest. The station’s been losing money for three years. She’s been covering the shortfall. She’ll keep covering it as long as this situation is active, but she’s clear-eyed about it — the station needs to become viable on its own eventually. She’s not selling and she’s not walking away, but she wants ideas about how to run it better.”

Ted nodded slowly. He looked at his beer, then at Miro. A look passed between them that Arthur caught but couldn’t fully interpret — something old, something that had been between these two men for longer than Arthur had been here.

“Miro’s got thoughts on that,” Ted said. “If anyone’s interested.”

Miro looked at Ted. Ted looked back at him steadily. Arthur watched the exchange and understood he was seeing something that had been waiting for this moment — Ted, who knew everything about everyone on his run, who knew what Miro thought and what Miro wanted and had never had the standing to bring it forward until now.

“Go on,” Arthur said.

Miro turned his beer in his hands. He looked out at the dark paddock, and when he spoke it was measured and direct.

“This country will carry sheep. The eastern paddocks — past the ridge, down to the creek system. Good browse, reliable water from the two eastern bores. The cattle need the flats and the better grass. The scrub country east

is wasted on them, but Dorpers would do well there. Hardy breed, don't need shearing, finish on natural browse." He paused. "I've walked that country for twenty years. I know what it can carry and what it can't. Cattle alone, this station breaks even in a good year and loses in a dry one. Add sheep on the eastern side, you've got a second income stream off land that's currently earning nothing."

It was more words than Arthur had heard Miro speak in sequence since he'd arrived. Ted was looking at his beer with an expression that was trying not to be proud and not quite succeeding.

"How long have you been thinking about this?" Arthur asked.

"A while."

"He's been thinking about it for ten years," Ted said. "He's just never had anyone to say it to."

Miro gave Ted a look that was half irritation and half something warmer. "I said a while."

Arthur smiled. He couldn't help it, and he didn't try to stop it, and when he looked at Ted, Ted was smiling too, and even Miro's mouth had changed in a way that could have been a smile if you knew where to look.

"I'll tell Helen," Arthur said. "She'll want numbers eventually, but the idea is sound and she'll know it."

"The idea's been sound for a decade," Ted said. "It just needed someone to listen."

They were on their second beers when the HF radio crackled inside. Ted went in. Arthur heard his voice, low and even, and then Ted came back to the verandah.

"Rennie," he said. "He's got something on the plate."

Arthur stood up. Lucky's head came off his boot and the dog watched him go inside.

Rennie's voice on the radio was flat and deliberate. "The plate traces to a rental outfit in Alice Springs. The rental agreement is in the name of a company — Dryden Pastoral Consulting. Registered in New South Wales. I ran a basic search. It's a shell company, Arthur. Registered eight months ago, no visible operations, no employees listed. A PO box in Sydney and a registered agent who handles about forty similar companies."

"A shell," Arthur said.

"That's what it looks like. I can push the inquiry further but I'll need help from Alice Springs CIB, and that takes time and a reason. The assault at the Warners' gives me the reason. The time is what it is."

"What's the registered agent's name?"

Rennie gave it to him. Arthur wrote it down on the pad by the radio, along with the company name and the registration details.

"I appreciate this, Dave."

"Don't appreciate it yet. This is the easy part. The hard part is connecting a shell company in Sydney to whoever's actually running operations in this district. There'll be layers."

"There always are."

He went back to the verandah. Ted and Miro were waiting. He told them what Rennie had found — the rental, the shell company, the PO box in Sydney. Ted shook his head slowly. Miro said nothing, which was its own commentary.

"I'll send the details to Helen tonight," Arthur said. "She's got resources I don't have — access to corporate registries, legal databases. If Dryden Pastoral Consulting connects to Meridian Resources, she'll find it."

"And if it does?" Ted asked.

"Then we know who we're dealing with. And we start building a case that's bigger than one cut brake line and one visit to the Warners."

Ted finished his beer and stood up. "I'm going to bed. Lock up." He paused at the door. "I'm glad you told us, Arthur. I know that wasn't easy."

“It was easier than I expected.”

“That’s because we’re easy people.” He went inside. The screen door closed behind him.

Miro stood up. He looked at Arthur for a moment. “The sheep thing. You think she’ll go for it?”

“I think she’ll wonder why nobody brought it up sooner.”

Miro nodded. He walked toward his quarters. At the edge of the verandah light he stopped and turned back. “Best Buy,” he said. “That’s where they jumped you? A Best Buy?”

“Parking lot. Tuesday evening.”

Miro shook his head. “Of all the places.” He walked into the dark.

Arthur sat alone on the verandah. Lucky hadn’t moved — still at his feet, warm weight against his boot. The stars were thick and the silence was the big silence, the one that had nothing human in it for a hundred kilometers in any direction.

He went inside and sat at his desk and opened the laptop.

Hel — I told them. Ted and Miro. The full story. Ted asked good questions. Miro said he’d known since the first week, which I believe. They took it the way good men take hard news — straight on, with their feet planted.

I shared your position on the finances. Ted’s been quietly championing something for years, and tonight it came out: Miro has a plan to run sheep on the eastern paddocks. Dorpers — a hardy breed that finishes on natural browse. He knows the country, he knows the water, he’s been thinking about it for a decade. Nobody ever asked him. I think it’s worth serious consideration and I’ll get you details when I have them.

Rennie called. The plate traces to a rental in Alice Springs. The rental agreement is in the name of Dryden Pastoral Consulting — a shell company, registered eight months ago in New South Wales. No operations, no employees, a PO box in Sydney. Registered agent handles forty similar companies. I’ve got the name. Can you run Dryden Pastoral Consulting through whatever

databases you can access? If there's a connection to Meridian Resources, it won't be on the surface, but it'll be there.

I'll start looking for a solicitor in Alice Springs this week.

It was a good night, Hel. The kind of night where things get said that needed saying. —A

He closed the laptop and sat in the dark. Through the wall, Ted's room was quiet. Through the window, Miro's light went off.

Lucky padded into the room and lay down beside the desk. Arthur reached down and put his hand on the dog's head and kept it there for a while. The house settled around them — the creak of tin, the tick of cooling wood, the vast quiet pressing in from every direction.

He went to bed and for the first time in weeks he didn't check the locks before he turned in. Miro had already done it. He'd heard the bolt slide home while he was writing.

Chapter 11 — The Log

Ted was on the HF radio at six-thirty, coffee in hand, raising the Warners on the morning schedule.

Matt's voice came through with the static-edged clarity of high-frequency transmission — not clean, but readable. Arthur stood in the hallway with his own coffee and listened. Miro was at the kitchen table, eating toast and not pretending he wasn't listening too.

"Quiet the first two days after," Matt said. "We figured they were regrouping or licking their wounds. Then a light plane came over — single engine, flew low, circled the property twice and headed northwest. Day after that, Sarah spotted a helicopter way out east, just sitting in the air for about twenty minutes. And there's been vehicles. Two different ones that we've seen, both at distance on the boundary track. They don't come in. They just drive past slow."

"Same vehicles?" Ted asked.

"Can't tell at that range. White, maybe silver. Dual-cabs. Could be the same, could be different."

Ted looked at Arthur. Arthur nodded his head slightly — not surprise, just confirmation. Surveillance. The playbook escalating from pressure to observation.

"You want us out there today?" Ted said. "Arthur and I are running supplies to Reg this morning. We can swing by after."

"No need. Rennie's got a bloke — Tommy Birch, you know Tommy — drives past every four or five hours and waves. Checks in on the radio if he sees anything. We're right. If it changes, I'll call."

"You do that."

"How's Lily?"

"Good. Scraped up still but she beat Arthur at chess three times last visit so her brain's working fine."

Ted smiled at the radio. "Tell her I'll bring a new book next run."

“She’ll hold you to that.”

Ted signed off and set his coffee down and looked at Arthur and Miro. The three of them stood in the kitchen with the morning light coming through the windows and the implications of Matt’s report sitting between them like something physical.

“They’re watching,” Arthur said. “That’s what this is. Plane for aerial mapping, helicopter for sustained observation, ground vehicles for the road network. They’re building a picture of the property before they decide what to do next.”

“Professional,” Miro said.

“Yes.”

Ted picked up his coffee again. “Well. Let’s go see Reg. He ought to hear this from us before he hears it from the wind.”

They took the supply truck — the same truck with the new brake line, loaded with flour, tinned goods, fuel, and a case of beer that Ted said was medicinal. Lucky jumped in the tray without being invited and stood with his paws on the rail as they pulled out of the yard. Arthur watched him in the side mirror — ears back, nose up, reading the air with the same patience Miro gave the ground.

The track to Reg’s place ran south and west through mulga scrub and open spinifex country, corrugated in places where the rain had cut channels that the grader couldn’t keep up with. Ted drove steady and unhurried — one hand on the wheel, talking. He talked about the families as his own people, because that’s what they were.

“June started that notebook about eight months ago,” Ted said. “Called me one night on the radio and said something wasn’t right. Roads getting closed for no reason she could see. A government surveyor turned up at their boundary without notice — no appointment, no letter, just a bloke with a tripod and a clipboard. She asked who sent him and he said the Department of Mines and Energy. She called the Department of Mines and Energy and they said they hadn’t sent anyone.”

“She told you that?”

“She tells me everything. Has done for fifteen years. June doesn’t trust easily but once she does, she’s all in. Her husband’s the same — Don’s quiet but he sees things. Between the two of them, they’ve been keeping track of every strange vehicle, every unexplained closure, every time someone turned up who shouldn’t have been there.” Ted glanced at Arthur. “She didn’t know what it meant. She just knew it was wrong.”

“It was wrong.”

“You’ll see the notebook today. She called this morning while you were walking the dog — said she and Don are driving over to the homestead. She wants to show you.”

Arthur looked at him. “She called you?”

“She called Miro. Miro told her we’d be at Reg’s this morning but back by noon. She said they’d be there.” Ted smiled. “Word gets around out here. She heard about the Warners — Matt told Don on the radio. June decided it was time to stop keeping her notebook to herself.”

They drove in silence for a while. The country opened up — the mulga thinned and the ground was red and flat and the sky was the depthless blue that Arthur had stopped noticing until he noticed it again. A wedge-tailed eagle turned in a thermal ahead of them, unhurried, patient, scanning the ground from a height that made the truck irrelevant.

“I’ve been on this run twenty-five years,” Ted said. He said it without weight, just a fact. “Knew every family that’s come and gone. Some of them lasted a year, some lasted a generation. The ones who stay — the Warners, the Patersons, Old Reg — they stay because they love it. Not because it’s easy. It’s never easy. But there’s something about being out here that gets into people, and once it does, they don’t leave.”

He was quiet for a moment. The truck bounced over a washout and Lucky braced in the tray.

“Miro’s the same. Twenty years and he’s never asked for a thing. Never asked for a raise, never asked for a title, never asked for a stake. He just does the work. Every day, better than anyone I’ve ever seen.” Ted’s hands

were easy on the wheel. “I’ve been trying to get Helen to see that for years. Not formally — I’m not good at formal. But dropping it into conversations. Mentioning what Miro did, what Miro thinks, what Miro knows that nobody else knows. She always listened but it never went anywhere. Wasn’t her fault. She’s in Bethesda and the station’s a line item on a spreadsheet she inherited.”

“It’s not a line item anymore,” Arthur said.

“No. It’s not.” Ted looked at the road. “What you did last night — telling us about Helen’s finances, asking Miro what he thought — that’s the first time anyone’s treated him like he has a say in the place. And he’s got more than a say. He’s got the answer. Those Dorpers on the eastern paddocks would change everything.”

“I know.”

“Don’t let that idea die. Whatever happens with the rest of this — the mining company, the lawyers, all of it — don’t let Miro’s idea get lost in the noise.”

Arthur looked at Ted — the lined face, the hat pushed back, the steady hands, the calm certainty of a quarter century spent taking care of people and land and never once asking for credit. Arthur thought about what it would be like to lose him and then put the thought away because it wasn’t a thought he was ready to have.

“I won’t,” he said.

Reg’s place looked the same as Arthur remembered — bare red earth, the water tank, the shed, the single tree that had been coaxed to survival against all odds. The yard was clean, organized with a system refined over forty years. Reg’s dog came out to meet the truck, and Lucky dropped off the tray and touched noses with him in the ancient protocol of station dogs.

Reg was on the front step. He was thinner than Arthur remembered from the first supply run — whittled down further, if that was possible, pared to essentials by decades of heat and work and solitude. He stood when Ted pulled up and watched them get out and his face didn’t change but his eyes

moved from Ted to Arthur and back to Ted and Arthur saw something in that look that wasn't surprise. It was assessment.

"Brought you flour, tinned pears, and beer," Ted said, walking up the steps.

"Flour I needed. Pears I'll tolerate. Beer I'll accept under duress."

"You're welcome."

They unloaded the supplies while Reg made tea. The kitchen was sparse and clean — a wood stove, a table, two chairs, a shelf of books that ran to bush poetry and stock breeding manuals. A photograph on the wall: two young men standing by a truck, hats in hand, squinting into the sun. Ted and Reg, maybe thirty years ago. The resemblance was there if you looked — the jaw, the set of their shoulders. But Reg had been weathered by solo decades into something harder and sparer than Ted, who'd been kept supple by the constant company of other people.

They sat on the front step with tea. Ted told Reg what was happening. Straight, warm, thorough — the only register Ted had for hard news. The brake line. The Warners' fight. The shell company. Arthur's background. He didn't rush and he didn't soften it.

Reg listened without interrupting. He held his tea in both hands and watched the yard and when Ted was finished Reg was quiet for a long time.

"How's the little girl?" he said.

"Scraped up. Fine. Mad as a cut snake about it, which is the right response."

Reg almost smiled. "Warners are good people. That boy of theirs — Sam — he's going to be something."

"He already is."

Reg looked at Arthur. "You fought for them."

"Matt did most of the fighting. I helped."

Reg held his gaze for a moment, then nodded once and looked at the yard. The nod contained something Arthur couldn't quite parse — acceptance, maybe, or acknowledgment that Arthur had crossed a line from visitor to participant.

“You watch out for my brother,” Reg said. He said it to Arthur but it was about Ted, and it was the most direct thing Arthur had heard Reg say.

“I will.”

Ted shook his head. “I don’t need watching out for.”

“Everybody needs watching out for,” Reg said. “Even you.”

The brothers looked at each other. Something passed between them that was older than the station and didn’t need words and wouldn’t have survived them. Ted finished his tea and stood up and put his hand on Reg’s shoulder for a moment, and Reg let him, and that was all.

Rennie saw the truck at ten-fifteen on a Tuesday morning, parked outside the fuel station on the main road through town.

White dual-cab. Newish. No dust on it, which in this country was the equivalent of a neon sign. He was walking from the station to the pub — not for a drink, for a conversation with the publican about a missing fuel delivery that was probably just late but might not be — and the truck caught his eye because trucks like that didn’t belong to anyone he knew.

He walked over. The driver was coming out of the fuel station shop with a bottle of water and a pair of sunglasses he was peeling the sticker off. Mid-thirties, solid build, short hair, wearing clothes that were new enough to have creases from the packaging. He clocked Rennie — maybe the build, maybe the walk, maybe the police vehicle at the curb — and his hands stopped on the sunglasses.

“Morning,” Rennie said. “Nice truck. Haven’t seen it around.”

“Just passing through.”

“Where to?”

The man put the sunglasses on. “North. Up the highway.”

“From?”

“Alice.”

Rennie nodded. He looked at the truck. The tray was empty, the windows were clean, and the plates were Territory. He took out his notebook in the unhurried way he did everything and wrote down the plate number while the man watched.

“What’s this about?” the man said.

“Routine. We had an incident at a property south of here. White dual-cab was involved. I’m noting vehicles that match the description.”

“Well, this isn’t that vehicle.”

“Probably not. Mind telling me your name?”

The man’s jaw tightened. “I don’t have to give you my name.”

“You don’t,” Rennie agreed. “But most people passing through are happy enough to chat. The ones who aren’t tend to be the ones I’m interested in.”

The man looked at Rennie for a long moment. Rennie looked back. He was forty-eight years old and he’d been a police sergeant in remote postings for twenty of those years and he’d dealt with drunks and domestics and cattle thieves and the occasional genuine hard case, and this man — whoever he was — was not going to stare him down on a street he’d walked every day for six years.

The man decided the same thing. He unclenched his jaw and walked to the truck and got in. He started the engine and pulled out without looking at Rennie, turned onto the highway, and accelerated north.

Rennie stood in the street. He took out his phone and held it up and photographed the truck — the rear plate, the model, the colour, the direction of travel. The photo was steady and clear.

In the truck’s side mirror, the man saw him do it. Rennie could tell because the brake lights flicked on for a second — the involuntary flinch of realizing he was on the record. Then the lights went off and the truck kept going and Rennie put his phone in his pocket and wrote a note beside the plate number: *Uncooperative. Agitated. New clothes, new truck, no dust. Photographed departing northbound.*

He went to the pub and asked about the fuel delivery.

The Patersons' ute was in the yard when Ted and Arthur got back from Reg's.

June and Don were on the verandah with Miro, drinking tea. Lucky jumped off the tray before the truck stopped and trotted to the verandah steps, tail going. June stood up when she saw Ted — her whole face lifting — and Don rose too, shaking Ted's hand, asking about Reg.

"He's Reg," Ted said. "Doesn't change. Sends his regards, which from Reg means he grunted when I mentioned you."

Don laughed. June was already looking at Arthur. She had a canvas bag over her shoulder and she was holding it the way you hold something you've been carrying alone for too long.

"I brought the notebook," she said. "I think it's time someone who knows what they're looking at had a proper read."

"Let's go inside," Arthur said.

They sat at the kitchen table — Arthur, June, Ted, Don. Miro leaned against the counter. June opened the bag and took out a hardback notebook, A4 size, with a dark blue cover. It was full. She'd been writing in it for eight months and the pages were dense with her neat, precise handwriting — dates in the left margin, descriptions in the center, and a column on the right where she'd noted her own thoughts or questions.

Arthur opened it to the first page and began reading.

The first entries were tentative. A road closure on the western boundary track — no notice, no signs, just a locked gate where there'd never been one. A government vehicle parked at the Patersons' fence line for two hours. A phone call from someone asking about land valuations. June had recorded them because they felt wrong, not because she knew they meant anything.

By the third month the entries were more confident. She'd started noting times, vehicle descriptions, plate numbers where she could get them. She'd logged conversations with neighbours — other families who'd had similar visits, similar calls. She'd recorded the dates that two bore pumps on their lease had failed and the unusually long wait for the repair crew.

Arthur turned pages. He was aware of June watching him but he was in the work now, the part of his mind that had spent years reviewing compliance reports and operational timelines. The notebook wasn't a log. It was a dataset.

"These sighting entries," he said, running his finger down a sequence of dates. "The vehicle descriptions are consistent — white or silver dual-cab, no station markings, no dust. And they run on intervals. Here — this one, this one, this one." He pointed. "Roughly forty-eight hours apart. That's not random traffic. That's a patrol."

June leaned forward. "I noticed they came regularly but I didn't note the timing."

"It's every other day, give or take a few hours of variation. Probably a rotating crew on a two-day cycle." He turned back several pages. "This road closure — the one on the western track in March. You logged it on the fourteenth. Two days before that, on the twelfth, you have an entry about a lease inquiry phone call. And here —" he flipped forward, "in May, another road closure on the fifteenth, and a lease inquiry on the thirteenth. The closures follow the inquiries by forty-eight hours. The same interval as the patrols. They're running the whole operation on a two-day clock."

June looked at Don. Don looked at the notebook.

"I didn't see that," June said.

"You wouldn't, unless you were looking for an operational pattern. You recorded the facts — that's the hard part. The pattern only shows up when you lay the timeline flat and look for rhythm." Arthur turned to another section. "This entry here — the surveyor who turned up without authorization. You noted the date and description but also that he had a handheld GPS unit and was taking readings at your bore sites. Did you mention that to anyone at the time?"

"I called the Department. They said they hadn't sent him."

"Right. But look at this — three weeks later, that bore failed. The one at your western boundary. And this one —" he pointed to another entry, "the

eastern bore failed six weeks after a similar unannounced visit. Someone was mapping your water infrastructure and then interfering with it.”

The kitchen was quiet. Ted was leaning forward with his elbows on the table. Don’s face had gone still.

“You’re saying it’s coordinated,” Don said.

“Yes, I’m saying it’s a campaign. Everything in this notebook — the closures, the surveys, the bore failures, the vehicle patrols, the lease inquiries — follows a pattern I’ve seen before. Different country, different resource, same method. You pressure the people on the land by degrading their infrastructure and services. You make the land untenable. Then you offer to help them leave.”

June sat back in her chair. Her eyes were bright and her jaw was set. “I knew it,” she said. “I knew something was organized. Don told me I was being paranoid.”

“You weren’t being paranoid. You were keeping evidence.” Arthur closed the notebook carefully. “This is valuable, June. More valuable than you know. When we get a solicitor involved, this is the kind of documented pattern that holds up.”

“A solicitor?” Don said.

“We’re getting legal advice. There’s a process for challenging what’s happening here, and your records are the foundation of it.”

June looked at Ted. Ted nodded. It was a small thing — a nod, nothing more — but June’s shoulders settled. Ted’s endorsement still carried weight that Arthur’s expertise alone couldn’t match. Not yet. Maybe not ever in this country.

The Patersons stayed for lunch. Ted cooked — steak and eggs, the universal station meal, cooked in a cast-iron pan that was older than anyone present. Don and Miro talked cattle in the yard while June sat at the table and watched Arthur photograph every page of her notebook. Lucky lay under Arthur’s chair and didn’t move until lunch was served, at which point he repositioned himself under Ted’s chair with the precision of a dog who knew where scraps came from.

“Traitor,” Arthur said.

“He’s a pragmatist,” Ted said, and dropped a piece of steak.

The Patersons left in the mid-afternoon. June shook Arthur’s hand at the truck and held it for a moment longer than a handshake required. She didn’t say anything. She didn’t need to. Eight months of notebook entries had just been validated, and the relief on her face was plain.

The verandah that evening was the war room.

Arthur had Helen’s email open on his laptop, balanced on the arm of his chair. Ted and Miro had their beers. Lucky was at Arthur’s feet. The last of the daylight was going and the bats were out, fast dark shapes against the paling sky.

“Helen found the layers,” Arthur said. He read from the screen. “Dryden Pastoral Consulting is a subsidiary of a company called Eastmark Holdings, registered in Western Australia. Eastmark holds two other entities — a survey firm and something called Redland Resource Services. All three were incorporated within two months of each other, all through the same registered agent, all with the same PO box in Sydney. Eastmark itself is owned by an offshore entity. She’s still tracing it upward but the structure is clearly international. This isn’t a local operation.”

“How far up does it go?” Ted asked.

“She doesn’t know yet. The offshore layers take longer to trace — different jurisdictions, different registries. But the pattern is corporate. This is how large mining companies operate when they want deniable local operations. You create a network of shell companies with clean names and local registrations. The money flows down. The liability stays at the bottom.”

Miro was quiet for a moment. Then he said, “While you two were at Reg’s, I made some calls.”

Arthur looked at him.

“About the solicitor. I rang a few people — a bloke I know in Alice who works at Legal Aid, and Maggie Daniels at the Land Council. Asked who

they'd go to if they had a mining company problem and needed someone who wasn't afraid of it." He paused. "Name that came back twice is Karen Lowe. Solicitor in Alice Springs. Used to work for one of the big firms in Melbourne — mining and resources — and left. Went north. Set up her own practice five years ago. She does land rights, native title, environmental challenges. Maggie says she's smart, she's tough, and she doesn't owe anyone in the resource sector a thing."

"Karen Lowe," Arthur said.

"I've got her number. I figure we drive in and sit down with her. Better face to face."

"When?"

"Tomorrow's no good — I've got the eastern bores to check. Day after."

Arthur nodded. "Day after."

Ted raised his beer. "Miro rang a bloke who rang a bloke. That's how it works out here."

"That's how it works everywhere," Miro said. "Some places just pretend it doesn't."

The radio crackled. Arthur went inside.

Rennie's voice was flat and professional. "Got a sighting for you. White dual-cab, Territory plates, parked outside the fuel station this morning. Driver was mid-thirties, short hair, new clothes, no dust. I asked him a few questions. He got agitated and didn't want to give his name. Decided to leave in a hurry."

"You get the plate?"

"Photographed the vehicle and plate as he drove off. He saw me do it — hit his brakes for a second when he checked his mirror, then kept going. Plate's different from the Warners' truck but the vehicle description is close. Could be the same outfit with different plates, could be a second vehicle."

"Where'd he go?"

“Northbound on the highway. Toward Alice. I’ve sent the plate to CIB along with the Dryden one. They’re aware of the Warners’ incident and they know I’m building a file.”

“You told him it was routine.”

“I told him we’d had an incident. He told me it wasn’t his vehicle. Most innocent people don’t specify what their vehicle *isn’t* before you’ve accused them of anything.” A pause. “Arthur, these people aren’t subtle. New trucks, new clothes, no local knowledge. They stand out like dog’s balls in a town this size. If they’ve got more people in the area, I’ll know about it.”

“Thanks, Dave.”

“I’ll keep you posted.”

Arthur went back to the verandah and gave them Rennie’s report — the truck, the driver, the photo, the plate, the man’s brake lights flashing when he saw Rennie’s phone in the mirror.

Ted shook his head. “They’re sending city boys to the bush. That never goes well.”

“It goes well enough when nobody’s watching,” Arthur said. “The problem for them is that people are watching now. June, Rennie, the Warners, Tommy Birch. They thought they were operating in a vacuum. They’re not.”

Miro finished his beer. “Karen Lowe. Day after tomorrow.”

“Day after tomorrow.”

The dark had come in fully. The stars were out. Ted stood up and stretched and looked at the sky in the way he did every night — not studying it, just acknowledging it — an old greeting between him and the dark.

“Good day,” he said. “Difficult, but good. I’m turning in.”

He walked past Arthur’s chair and paused. “June’s notebook,” he said. “Eight months she kept that going. Alone, not knowing if it meant anything. That’s a brave thing.”

“It meant everything,” Arthur said.

Ted nodded and went inside. The screen door closed. His footsteps went down the hall, and then his door, and then quiet.

Miro sat for another minute. Lucky had moved to Arthur's feet and was breathing the slow breath of a dog who'd had a full day and was done with it.

"Reg looked thin," Miro said.

"He did."

"Ted worries about him. Doesn't say it, but he worries."

Arthur thought about Reg on the verandah. *You watch out for my brother.*
"They're close."

"Closer than they let on. Reg lost his wife twelve years ago. Ted's the only family he sees regular." Miro stood up. "Night."

"Night."

Arthur sat alone with the dog and the dark and the sound of the house settling. He opened his laptop and wrote to Helen.

Hel — June Paterson's notebook is a goldmine. Eight months of documented sightings, closures, bore failures, and lease inquiries — all on a pattern. Forty-eight-hour operational cycle. Surveyor visits followed by bore failures. Road closures timed to lease pressure. She didn't know what she had. Now we do.

Rennie clocked a white dual-cab in town today — driver got nervous, wouldn't give his name, drove off northbound. Rennie photographed the plate. Second plate in the system now. He's building a file.

Miro found us a solicitor — Karen Lowe, Alice Springs. Ex-Melbourne mining law, now independent. Good reputation from people who'd know. We're driving in day after tomorrow.

Your Dryden research is critical. Three entities under Eastmark, offshore parent, same structure I've seen in every corporate pressure campaign I ever reviewed. Keep pulling the thread. The top of that chain is where the answers are.

Ted drove me to Reg's today. Watched Ted with his brother, with the Patersons, with Miro. Watched what happens to a room when he walks in. He's built something out here that has nothing to do with cattle numbers or P&L statements. I don't know what you call it. I just know it matters.

—A

He closed the laptop. Lucky lifted his head, then put it down again. Arthur sat in the dark and listened to the country and after a while he went inside and checked the locks out of habit, though Miro had already done it.

Chapter 12 — Ted

Arthur was up at five-thirty. Coffee on, boots by the door, the day already taking shape in his head — the eastern bores with Miro, then the trip to Alice Springs tomorrow to see Karen Lowe. He stood at the kitchen counter and drank his coffee and watched the light come through the window, pale and cool, the yard still grey.

Miro came in from his quarters at quarter to six. He poured coffee and leaned against the counter and they stood in the easy silence of men who'd learned each other's mornings. Miro drank. Arthur drank. The clock on the wall ticked.

At six-fifteen Miro looked at the hallway.

Ted's door was closed.

It was never closed at six-fifteen. Ted was a five-forty man — up before anyone, kettle on, radio check, already thinking about the day before the day had started. His routine was as fixed as the sunrise and as reliable. In the weeks Arthur had been here, Ted had never once been the last man to the kitchen.

Miro set his coffee down. He didn't say anything. He looked at the closed door and Arthur looked at Miro and something passed between them that wasn't a thought yet. Just a wrongness. A detail out of place in a pattern that never varied.

Miro walked down the hallway. Arthur followed. Their boots were quiet on the floorboards. Miro stopped at Ted's door and knocked once, not hard.

"Ted."

Nothing.

He knocked again. "Ted. You right?"

The silence had a quality to it. Not the silence of a man sleeping through a knock. Something else. Something still.

Miro opened the door.

Ted was in bed. On his back, one arm across his chest, the other at his side. The sheet was pulled up to his waist. His face was turned slightly toward the window, toward the east, toward the light that was coming in thin and pale through the curtain. He looked like he was sleeping. He looked like he'd been sleeping for a long time and had gone somewhere deeper than sleep and wasn't coming back.

Miro stood in the doorway. He didn't move. He didn't speak. He stood there and looked at Ted and Arthur stood behind him and watched Miro's shoulders and the back of his head and the stillness that came over him, and Arthur knew. They both knew. The room told them with its silence and its air and the particular quality of light falling on Ted, who would never see it again.

After a long time Miro stepped into the room. He went to the bed and put his hand on Ted's forehead, gently, the way you touch something that has become fragile. He held it there. Then he took his hand away and straightened up and turned around and walked past Arthur into the hallway and kept walking until he was outside.

Arthur stood alone in the doorway. Ted's room was neat — clothes folded on the chair, boots paired by the wall, his hat on the hook behind the door. The bedside table had a water glass, half full, and a book with a receipt for a bookmark. The window was cracked open an inch, as it always was, because Ted liked the air.

Arthur went to the bed. He looked at Ted's face. It was calm. Whatever had happened — his heart, a vessel in his brain — had happened while he slept, without warning, without pain. He'd gone to bed after a good day. He'd said good night. He'd said June's notebook was a brave thing. He'd looked at the sky, same as every night.

Arthur pulled the sheet up to Ted's shoulders and smoothed it and stood there for a moment and then went outside.

Miro was in the yard. He was standing by the truck with his hands at his sides, looking at nothing, and when Arthur came down the steps Miro

turned and his face was the face of a man holding himself together by force of will and not much else.

"I'll radio the clinic in Alice," Miro said. His voice was steady. "They'll send someone for the paperwork. Take a day or two."

"Okay."

"We should wash him. Get him dressed. It's what you do."

"Tell me what to do."

They went back inside. They worked together in Ted's room with the morning light strengthening through the curtain. Miro brought warm water in a basin and clean clothes from Ted's drawer — a good shirt, pressed trousers, the clothes Ted wore when he drove into town. They washed him and dressed him and Miro combed his hair with a comb from the bedside drawer, careful to get the part right, and neither of them spoke except when the work required it. Arthur held and lifted when Miro directed and Miro's hands were steady and sure and his eyes were dry and his jaw was set.

When they were finished, Miro straightened the sheet and stepped back and looked at Ted for a long time. Then he walked out of the room and out of the house and across the yard to the machinery shed. Arthur heard the shed door open and close. He didn't follow.

He sat at the kitchen table. The two coffee mugs were where they'd left them. Ted's mug — the blue one, chipped at the rim — was clean and upside down on the drying rack where Ted had left it last night after washing up. Arthur looked at it and his throat closed and he sat with that for a while.

He radioed the clinic in Alice Springs. He gave them the details — name, age, location, what they'd found. The woman on the other end was kind and practiced and said a nurse and a justice of the peace would fly out tomorrow if weather permitted. Arthur thanked her and signed off.

He radioed Rennie. Rennie listened and was quiet for a moment and said, "Christ." Then he said, "I'll tell the town. People will want to know." Arthur thanked him and signed off.

He didn't know who else to call. The Warners. The Patersons. Reg. But Reg had to be told in person and the others could wait until after. He sat at the table with the radio silent and the house silent and the yard silent and the wrongness of all that silence pressing in.

Miro came back from the shed after an hour. His eyes were red but his voice was the same — flat, practical, steady. He looked at the kitchen and at Ted's mug on the rack and then he looked away.

"Bores still need checking," he said.

"They can wait."

"No. They can't. Cattle don't know what happened." He picked up his hat from the hook. "I'll take the ute. Be back by noon."

Arthur watched him go. The ute started, pulled out of the yard, turned onto the track and disappeared into the dust and the scrub and the distance. Miro was going to check the bores because the bores needed checking and because the work was the only thing he had that would hold him together today.

Arthur washed the breakfast things. He swept the kitchen floor. He went out to the verandah and stood there and looked at the yard. The morning was heating up. The windmill was turning. A crow sat on the water tank and watched him with its head tilted.

Lucky came around the corner of the house. He'd been in the yard somewhere — Arthur hadn't seen him since before the discovery. The dog walked up the verandah steps and went to Ted's chair and lay down beside it. Not under it, not in it. Beside it, facing the yard, his head on his paws, his eyes open. He stayed there.

Arthur went inside and sat at his desk and opened the laptop.

Hel — Ted died in his sleep last night. We found him this morning. His heart, we think, or a stroke. He didn't suffer. Miro and I took care of him. A nurse is coming from Alice tomorrow.

I don't know what to say beyond that. He was here last night. He wasn't here this morning.

I'll call when I can. —A

He sent it and closed the laptop and sat in the quiet house with the closed door down the hall and the mug on the rack and the dog on the verandah.

Miro came back at noon. He'd checked the eastern bores — all running, no issues. He reported this to Arthur — same words, same tone he'd have used with Ted, and the habit of it — the reporting, the structure, the assumption that someone was listening — seemed to hold him upright.

They ate lunch in silence. Sandwiches, made without discussion, eaten at the table. Ted's chair was empty. Neither of them looked at it and neither of them didn't look at it.

"We should go to Reg in the morning," Miro said.

Arthur nodded.

"Maybe we should go together."

The word sat between them. Together. It meant: this is us now. It meant: the two of us, doing what Ted would have done. It meant: I don't want to do this alone and I don't think you should either.

"Together," Arthur said. "Yes."

The afternoon was long. Arthur tried to work — emails, the photos of June's notebook, notes on the Dryden structure — but his mind wouldn't hold it. He kept hearing Ted's voice from the drive yesterday. *Don't let that idea die*. He kept seeing Ted's hand on Reg's shoulder. The photograph on Reg's wall — two young men by a truck, squinting into the sun.

He gave up on work and walked. Lucky came with him — off the verandah, down the track, out toward the ridge where they'd walked two mornings ago. The country was the same. The light was the same. The windmill turned. The mulga stood in the heat. Nothing had changed and everything had changed and the landscape bore no record of the loss. It just went on, vast and indifferent and beautiful. Here before Ted. Here after.

That evening they sat on the verandah. Two beers, two chairs occupied, one empty. The tin roof ticked as it cooled. The stars came out in the dense

wash that Arthur had once found overwhelming and now found necessary. Lucky had moved from Ted's chair to Arthur's feet sometime during the afternoon and stayed there.

Miro drank his beer and looked at the dark. Arthur drank his and didn't try to fill the silence. The silence didn't need filling. It needed holding.

"Twenty years," Miro said. Not to Arthur. To the dark, to the stars, to whoever was listening. "Twenty years I worked beside that man."

Arthur waited.

"He was the best boss I ever had. Only boss I ever had, really. But he'd have been the best regardless." Miro turned his beer in his hands. "First day I showed up here, I was twenty-nine, broke, no references. He looked at me for about ten seconds and said, 'You know cattle?' I said yeah. He said, 'Prove it.' That was the interview." He almost smiled. Almost. "I proved it."

"He knew," Arthur said.

"He knew everything. Knew every family, every bore, every fence post on this station. Knew what the cattle needed before they knew it themselves. Knew Reg was lonely before Reg admitted it." Miro paused. "Knew I had ideas and never got to say them. Tried to fix that. Couldn't, not on his own. But he tried."

They sat with it. The night sounds came in — insects, a distant bird, the faint hum of the generator. The sounds of a station that was still running because running was what it did.

"We'll take care of Reg," Arthur said.

"Yeah."

"And the families."

"Yeah."

Miro finished his beer and stood up. He looked at Ted's empty chair for a moment. Then he looked at Arthur.

"Goodnight," he said. He walked to his quarters. His door closed. Arthur sat alone.

In the morning they drove to Reg's.

The truck was loaded with nothing — no supplies, no beer, no excuse for the visit. Just two men in the cab and Lucky in the tray. Miro drove. Arthur rode. They didn't talk. The track unwound ahead of them through the mulga and the spinifex and the red country that Arthur had first seen from this same seat with Ted at the wheel, talking about the families, telling stories, one hand on the wheel and the other gesturing at the landscape he'd spent twenty-five years learning.

The single tree came into view, then the stone house, the bare yard. Reg's dog came out and Lucky dropped from the tray. Reg was on the front step. He stood when he saw the truck and watched them get out.

He looked at their faces. He looked at the truck and saw no supplies. He looked at Arthur and then at Miro and his hand went to the doorframe beside him and gripped it.

"No," he said.

Miro walked up the steps. "Reg. I'm sorry. Ted died in his sleep night before last. His heart, we think. He didn't suffer."

Reg's hand tightened on the doorframe. His face didn't crumble — it set like stone, hard and permanent. He looked at Miro and then past him at the yard, at the truck, at the empty passenger seat where Ted always sat when he came to visit.

"How's that fair?" Reg said. His voice cracked on the second word. "I should have been first to go."

Nobody answered. There was nothing to answer. Miro put his hand on Reg's arm and Reg let him and the three of them stood on the step in the morning heat with both dogs lying in the shade and the country going on in every direction without pause or sympathy.

They stayed for two hours. Miro made tea in Reg's kitchen, moving through the room with the familiarity of years of supply visits. Arthur sat with Reg on the front step. Reg didn't talk much. He asked when it happened and how they'd found him and whether he'd been in pain. Arthur told him the

truth — Ted had gone to bed after a good evening, after a good day, and he'd looked peaceful and there was no sign of distress.

"A good day," Reg said. "That counts for something."

"It does."

Reg was quiet for a long time. He looked at the photograph through the open door — the two young men by the truck. Arthur had noticed it on his prior visit. Now it was the only photograph in the world that mattered.

"He was supposed to bring the girl a book," Reg said. "The little one. The chess player."

"Lily."

"He told me. Said he'd promised her a new chess book." Reg's jaw worked. "Someone should bring her that book."

"I will."

Reg nodded. He picked up his tea and drank it and set it down and looked at the yard. Arthur sat beside him and let the time pass. When Miro came out with more tea, Reg looked at him.

"You'll run the place," Reg said.

"Arthur and I will. Together."

Reg looked at Arthur. The assessment was back — the same measuring look from yesterday's visit, but sharper now, stripped of everything except the question that mattered.

"You staying?"

"I'm staying."

Reg held his gaze. Then he nodded, once, the same single nod he'd given Arthur after the Warners' fight. It carried the same weight. More.

"Good," Reg said. "He'd want that."

Helen's email was waiting when they got back.

Arthur — I tried to call three times. I'm writing because I can't wait anymore.

Ted Barlow managed my father's station for twenty-five years. He was there when Dad bought the place, he was there when Dad got sick, he was there when Dad died, and he stayed on after because the station was as much his as anyone's. More his, in the ways that matter. Dad knew it. I knew it. Ted never said it because Ted never said things like that.

I am gutted. I am sitting at my desk at home crying for a man I saw twice a year at most and who meant more to the fabric of that place than any piece of paper with my name on it.

Tell Miro I'm sorry. Tell Reg I'm sorry. Tell yourself I'm sorry. And tell me what you need.

I love you. Take care of each other.

H

Arthur read it and sat with it. Helen's voice was in every line — broken open in a way her emails rarely were, the control that usually shaped her sentences cracked by loss. She'd known Ted longer than Arthur had. She'd inherited him with the station — part of its walls, its roof, the things that kept it standing.

He wrote back.

Hel — We told Reg this morning. He took it hard. He said, "How's that fair? I should have been first to go." I don't have anything to add to that.

Miro and I are running the station. There's no discussion to have about it — it's just what's happening. The bores get checked, the cattle get moved, the families get their supplies. Ted built something that works because people know what to do. We know what to do.

I need to talk to you by voice soon. Not today. But soon. There are things to figure out — the station, the families, Karen Lowe, the Meridian situation. None of it has stopped because Ted died. If anything, it matters more now.

He told me yesterday not to let Miro's idea die. I won't.

—A

He sent it and closed the laptop. The house was quiet. Miro was in the shed — Arthur could hear the faint sound of a wrench, the clink of metal, the small noises of a man finding something to do with his hands. Lucky was on the verandah, at Arthur's chair, waiting.

Arthur went out. He sat down. Lucky put his head on his boot. The evening was coming on and the light was going long across the yard, turning the red dirt gold, catching the tin roof of the machinery shed and the top of the water tank and the windmill turning in air that Arthur couldn't feel from the verandah.

The station was quiet. Not empty — quiet. The generator hummed. A bird called from the mulga beyond the yard. The cattle were out there somewhere, in paddocks that Miro had checked this morning and would check again tomorrow. The bores were running. The fences were holding. The track ran south and west to Reg and north and east to the Warners and the Patersons, and those families were out there too, in their houses, with their children and their dogs and their problems, and they needed supplies and news and someone to show up with a truck and know their names.

Ted had done that for twenty-five years. Now it was theirs to do.

Arthur sat on the verandah with the dog at his feet and the empty chair beside him and the country stretching out in every direction. He thought about Virginia. The apartment. The parking lot. The flight. He thought about Alice Springs and the drive in and the red dust and the sky. He thought about the first night on this verandah, when he'd sat in this chair and looked at this landscape and understood nothing.

He understood now. Not everything — not Miro's twenty years of understanding, not Ted's quarter century. But enough. Enough to know what this place was and what it asked of the people who stayed and what it gave back. Enough to know that he wasn't leaving. Not because of Meridian, not because Helen needed him, not because Miro couldn't manage alone. Because this was where he'd come to rest, and the rest had turned into something else, and the something else was home.

He didn't say it. There was nobody to say it to and it didn't need saying. It was just true, the way the land was true — true as the stars above him, as Ted's empty chair beside him. A fact. Settled. Done.

Lucky shifted at his feet. The stars thickened. The tin roof ticked. Arthur sat and watched the dark come in and didn't move until Miro's light went on across the yard, and then off, and then he went inside and locked the door and went to bed.

Chapter 13 — Partners

Hel — A week now. The station is running. Miro and I have checked every bore, moved the cattle off the southern paddocks onto fresh grass, repaired the pump housing on bore three, and restocked the shed. Rennie reports continued vehicle activity in the district — two sightings in the past week, both at distance, both matching the profile. Karen Lowe has been briefed by phone and has copies of everything — Rennie’s file, my notes, photos of June’s notebook. She wants to meet face to face. We’re driving in tomorrow.

We buried Ted on Saturday, here at the homestead — on the rise behind the windmill, beside your father. The families came. Most of the town drove out; Keith closed the shop for the first time anyone can remember. Rennie wore his dress uniform. Reg stood at the grave with his hat in his hands and never said a word. Miro spoke — not long, and exactly right.

The families are holding. Matt radios every morning. June called to check on us — word about Ted reached everyone on the HF. Reg is quiet but standing. We’ll do a supply run after Alice.

The work helps. I think Miro would say the same if he said things like that.
—A

Helen’s reply came within the hour.

Arthur — I want to call today. There are things I need to say that don’t work in writing. Can you and Miro both be near the phone around 2pm your time?
—H

At two o’clock Arthur was at the desk with the satellite phone and Miro was leaning against the doorframe with his arms crossed, looking like he’d rather be checking bores. Helen’s voice came through clear — the satellite connection was better than the HF, though it carried a half-second delay that made conversations feel slightly formal.

“Arthur. How are you?”

“I’m all right. We’re all right.”

“Don’t do that. Tell me the truth.”

He paused. "It's hard. The house is different. Mornings are different. But the work keeps us moving and the station doesn't care about our feelings, which is useful."

"And Miro?"

"He's here. Standing in the doorway looking uncomfortable."

"Put me on speaker."

Arthur pressed the button. Helen's voice filled the room.

"Miro. I'm sorry I haven't spoken to you directly until now. I should have called sooner."

Miro straightened against the doorframe. "You've had a lot to deal with."

"So have you. More than me. You were there." A pause. The satellite delay made it longer. "Ted managed that station for my father for twenty-five years. But you built it. You and Ted together, but the land work, the cattle work, the water, the fences — that was you. Dad knew it. Ted knew it. I knew it and I didn't act on it, and that's something I have to live with."

Miro said nothing. His arms were still crossed but his hands had tightened on his elbows.

"I want to offer you a partnership in the station," Helen said. "A real one. Equal. Your name on the papers, your stake in the operation, your say in how it runs. Karen Lowe will draw up the documents when you see her tomorrow. This isn't charity and it isn't a thank-you. It's twenty years overdue."

The room was quiet. Arthur watched Miro's face — the jaw working, the eyes fixed on the middle distance, the stillness of a man absorbing something he'd stopped allowing himself to want.

"The sheep," Miro said. "The Dorpers on the eastern paddocks. That's part of this?"

"That's the plan. Arthur tells me you know which paddocks, you know the water, you know the carrying capacity. I want you to run it. Both of you — the cattle, the sheep, the lot. Make the station what it should have been."

Miro looked at Arthur. Arthur looked back. Something passed between them that didn't need translating.

"All right," Miro said. "Yes."

"Good." Helen's voice steadied. She'd been holding herself together and now she could let go a little. "Ted tried to tell me for years. I heard him but I didn't act. I'm acting now."

"He'd be pleased," Miro said. It was the most Arthur had heard him say about Ted since the funeral, and it was enough.

"He would," Helen said. "Arthur — stay on for a minute after?"

Miro nodded to Arthur and walked out. His boots crossed the verandah and went down the steps and Arthur heard him stop in the yard. Just standing there.

"How is he really?" Helen asked.

"Holding. Working. Missing Ted in ways he won't talk about. This will matter to him more than he showed just now."

"I know." A pause. "And you? Are you staying?"

"I'm staying."

"Good. Because I need you there and I think you need to be there, and between the two of us we don't need to say more about it than that."

"We don't."

"Be careful tomorrow. Karen will tell you what she's told me — these people escalate. They don't go away because you hired a lawyer. They push harder."

"I know."

"I love you. Take care of Miro. Take care of Reg. Take care of those families."

"I will."

The line went dead. Arthur sat with the phone in his hand and the room quiet around him and the weight of what had just happened settling into the house. Miro was in the yard. Through the window, Arthur could see

him standing by the truck with his hands at his sides, looking at the country the way he always looked at it — but differently now, because some of it was his.

Karen Lowe's office was on the second floor of a converted house on Bath Street in Alice Springs, between a real estate agent and a physiotherapist. The building was old and the stairs were narrow and the office itself was small — a desk, two client chairs, filing cabinets, a window overlooking the street. Law books on shelves. A framed degree from Melbourne. No decoration beyond what was functional.

She stood when they came in. Mid-forties, lean, dark hair pulled back, a handshake that was firm and brief. She wore a cotton shirt and trousers and no jewelry except a watch, and she moved through her office with the efficiency of not wasting time — hers or anyone else's.

"Arthur. Miro. Sit down. I've read everything you sent and everything Rennie sent and I've spoken to both of you on the phone, so let's not cover old ground."

They sat. She opened a folder.

"First — the partnership papers. I've drafted them based on what Helen and I discussed. Standard pastoral partnership, equal shares, joint management authority. Have a read, sign if you're comfortable, and I'll register them this week."

She slid the documents across. Arthur read. Miro read. The language was clean and the terms were clear. They signed.

"Good. Now." She closed that folder and opened another. "June Paterson's notebook. You brought the original?"

Arthur handed it over. Lowe opened it and turned pages with focused attention; she'd already seen the photographs but wanted the physical object.

"I'll photocopy every page today and have the copy ready for you before you leave town. The original stays with me — it goes in the safe once I've

copied it. Chain of custody matters if this goes to court, and I want it in a safe that isn't on the property they're interested in."

"Understood."

"Your analysis of the notebook was good. The forty-eight-hour operational cycle, the correlation between surveyor visits and bore failures — that's the kind of pattern that holds up under examination. Combined with Rennie's file on the vehicle sightings and the Warners' assault, we have the beginnings of a case for coordinated interference with pastoral operations."

"What can you do with it?" Arthur asked.

"Several things. Formal complaints to the Department of Mines and Energy about unauthorized survey activity. Freedom of information requests on any mining exploration permits filed for land in your district. A cease-and-desist to Dryden Pastoral Consulting and its parent entities, once we've confirmed the corporate structure. And if the harassment continues, an application for a restraining order that names the corporate entities and their agents."

"Will any of that stop them?"

Lowe looked at him. Her eyes were steady and her expression said she'd been asked this question before.

"It raises the cost. Every legal action creates a record. Every record creates liability. Companies like this operate on deniability — the moment their actions are documented in court filings, the calculus changes. It won't stop them overnight. But it makes every subsequent move more expensive and more visible."

"And in the meantime?"

"In the meantime, document everything. Phone videos when possible — vehicles, plates, any contact. Keep Rennie informed. Stay visible and stay together. These operations follow a pattern. They start with indirect pressure — services, infrastructure, lease inquiries. Then direct intimidation — which you've already seen. If the legal pressure doesn't convince them to move on, the next step is usually more aggressive. I've seen it in the Pilbara,

I've seen it in Queensland. They escalate because escalation has worked for them before."

She paused. "I don't say that to frighten you. I say it so you're prepared."

"We're prepared," Miro said. It was the first time he'd spoken since they sat down, and Lowe looked at him with an expression that recalibrated something.

"Good," she said. "I'll have the notebook copy ready in an hour. Get a coffee. I'll see you back here."

They collected the copy and drove back to the station. The next morning they loaded the supply truck. Flour, tinned goods, fuel, fencing staples, a case of beer for Reg. Books for the Warner kids — Arthur had found them at the bookshop on Todd Mall while Lowe copied the notebook. A chess book for Lily, *Modern Chess Strategy* by Ludek Pachman — the woman at the counter had said it was a classic. And for Sam, a hardback on the campaigns of Hannibal, because Sam had finished Alexander and deserved the next great general.

Miro drove. Arthur rode. Lucky stood in the tray with his nose into the wind. The track rolled out ahead of them and the country opened up and they were on the supply run for the first time without Ted, and the absence was there in the cab like a third man — in the empty space between their seats where Ted's voice used to fill the air with stories and names and twenty-five years of knowing every family on the route.

They drove for a while without talking. Then Miro said, "He'd have something to say about this."

"About what?"

"About us doing the run. About the truck. About the weather. About what the Warners' boy is reading this week." Miro's hands were easy on the wheel. "He always had something to say."

"He did."

"I miss it."

Arthur looked at him. Miro was watching the track. His face was the same face it always was — composed, guarded, giving nothing away. But he'd said it. He missed it. And that was as much as Miro would give, and it was enough.

The Warners' place came into view around the last bend — the house, the shed, the chook enclosure, the water tank. Matt was in the yard working on a fence rail. Sarah was on the verandah. Sam was sitting on the steps with a book.

Matt set down his tools and walked to the truck. His handshake with Arthur was firm and held a beat longer than usual. He shook Miro's hand the same way.

"Good to see you both," Matt said. It was the condolence — compressed, real, sufficient.

"How are things?" Arthur asked.

"Quiet. Tommy Birch comes through regular. There was a helicopter two days ago — closer than the last time. Came in from the east, sat about a kilometer out for fifteen minutes, then headed north. Sarah got video on her phone."

"Good. Send it to Rennie and to Karen Lowe — I'll give you the email."

They unloaded supplies. Sarah brought tea. Arthur sat on the verandah and Lily came out with Captain at her heels. She was healed — the scrapes on her hands had closed to thin pink lines. She looked at Arthur with an expression that was expectant and trying not to show it.

Arthur took the book from his bag. "Ted promised you a chess book. I'm delivering."

Lily took it. She turned it over and looked at the cover and opened it to the table of contents and her eyes went wide. "This has the Nimzo-Indian."

"I'm told it's a classic."

She held the book against her chest. She looked at Arthur and her eyes were bright and her chin trembled once and then she had it under control. "Tell

Ted thank you,” she said. Then she stopped. She knew. Everyone knew. She looked at the book and then at Arthur. “Thank you,” she said. “For bringing it.”

“He would have brought it himself.”

“I know.”

She took the book inside. Sam watched her go. He looked at Arthur. “She’s been waiting for that,” he said quietly.

“I know she has.” Arthur reached into the bag again. “This one’s yours.”

Sam took the hardback and turned it over. His face changed — not Lily’s bright openness but something quieter, a recognition. “Hannibal,” he said.

“You finished Alexander. Hannibal’s the next one worth knowing.”

Sam held the book and nodded once, the way his father nodded — contained, serious, grateful without needing to perform it.

The Patersons’ place was forty minutes further on. June was in the yard when they pulled up. She looked at the truck and at Arthur and Miro in the cab and her face went through something complicated and private before it settled.

“Come in,” she said. “Kettle’s on.”

Inside, Arthur gave her the photocopy of her notebook. “The original is in Karen Lowe’s safe in Alice Springs. Chain of custody. This is your copy — every page.”

June held the photocopy and looked at it and then looked at Arthur. “She thinks it matters?”

“She thinks it’s the foundation of the case. Your documentation, your dates, your observations. Everything we’re building starts with what you wrote down.”

June nodded. She put the copy on the table and smoothed the cover. Don came in from the back and shook hands and asked about the station.

“Running,” Miro said. “We’re managing.”

“You’ll do more than manage,” Don said. He said it simply, a statement of confidence — and he didn’t offer those freely.

Don had his own report. A vehicle parked at the western boundary for two hours the previous Tuesday. He’d walked out with his phone and filmed it — the vehicle, the plate, the driver sitting in the cab looking at a tablet or a map. The driver saw Don filming and left.

“Good,” Arthur said. “Send it to Rennie and to Karen Lowe. Every piece of documentation matters.”

“June taught me that,” Don said. He looked at his wife. “She’s been right about this from the start.”

Reg’s place was the last stop. The single tree, the stone house, the bare yard. The dog came out. Lucky dropped from the tray.

Reg was on the front step. A week had passed since they’d brought the news and the week showed on him — thinner still, quieter, the lines deeper. But he was standing. He was dressed. The yard was maintained. He’d been keeping the place together with the discipline of forty years doing exactly that, and he wasn’t going to stop because his heart was broken.

“Brought you supplies,” Miro said, carrying a box up the steps. “Flour, tins, beer. The usual.”

“Ted’s order,” Reg said.

“Same order. Different delivery boys.”

Reg almost smiled. It was the first time Arthur had seen anything close to humor on his face since the news, and it came from Miro, which was right.

They unloaded and sat on the front step. Reg asked about the station, about the families, about Karen Lowe. Arthur told him — the partnership, the legal strategy, the escalation warning. Reg listened and nodded.

“Miro’s a partner now,” Arthur said.

Reg looked at Miro. “About time.”

“That’s what everyone keeps saying,” Miro said.

“Because it’s true.” Reg looked at the yard. “Ted would have said the same. Louder.”

Miro stood up. “Your pump’s making a noise,” he said. He walked off toward the water tank. Arthur watched him go — checking the fitting, adjusting something with his hands, the small maintenance that Ted had always done on these visits. The care continuing under different hands.

Reg watched too. “He’s a good man,” Reg said.

“He is.”

“So are you.” Reg said it without looking at Arthur, said it to the yard, to the country. “Ted thought so. I trust his judgment.”

They stayed until the shadows lengthened. When they left, Reg stood on the step and watched the truck pull out and Arthur saw him in the side mirror — small and upright against the stone house, one hand raised, the dog at his feet.

The verandah that evening was quiet. Two beers, two chairs, Lucky at Arthur’s feet. The supply run was done. The route was theirs now — not inherited, not borrowed, not temporary. Theirs.

Miro drank his beer and looked at the dark and after a while he said, “The Warners are being watched closer.”

“I know.”

“Lowe said they escalate.”

“She did.”

“Then we need to be ready for that.” Miro finished his beer. “I’ll talk to Matt tomorrow about what he’s seeing. Pattern and timing. If they’re running the same forty-eight-hour cycle as the Patersons, we can predict when they’ll be there.”

Arthur looked at him. Miro was thinking like an investigator. The partnership hadn’t just changed his title — it had changed his posture. He was

leaning forward now, into the problem, the way Arthur had been leaning since the Warners' fight.

"Good," Arthur said. "Let's map it."

Miro stood up. "Night, partner." He said it dry and flat and with the faintest edge of humor — the first time Miro had directed humor at Arthur since Ted died. He walked to his quarters. His door closed.

Arthur sat alone. Lucky breathed at his feet. The stars were out. He opened his laptop.

Hel — Supply run done. First one without Ted. The families are holding. Matt reports helicopter surveillance closer than before. Don Paterson filmed a vehicle at his boundary and has the plate. Everyone is documenting, everyone is watching. Karen Lowe has the notebook and the partnership papers are signed.

Lily got her chess book. She started to say "Tell Ted thank you" and then she stopped. I held it together. Barely.

Miro said "Night, partner" when he went to bed. First joke he's made in a week. I think we're going to be all right.

The surveillance is tightening and Lowe says to expect more. We'll be ready.

—A

He closed the laptop and sat with the dog and the dark and the country and the feeling of a day that had been full and hard and necessary. The station was his and Miro's now. The route was theirs. The families were theirs. The fight was theirs.

Ted's chair was empty beside him. It would stay empty. But the verandah was still the verandah, and the beers were still cold, and the stars were still thick and bright over the red country, and the work would go on tomorrow and the day after and the day after that.

Lucky shifted at his feet. Arthur finished his beer and went inside.

Chapter 14 — Strangers

Miro was at the kitchen table with the aviation chart spread flat and a mug of coffee holding down one corner. He'd drawn a circle in pencil around a section of the eastern boundary — the spot where Don had reported a vehicle parked for two hours the previous afternoon.

"I'll fly over at about ten," Miro said. "Low enough to see the plate if they're still there. If they've moved, I can follow the tracks for a bit."

"And if they're there?"

"Then I'll know where they are and they'll know I know." He folded the chart. "Not much else I can do from a Cessna."

Arthur poured his coffee and looked at the list on the counter. Fencing staples, diesel filters, a box of .308 cartridges that Miro had added without comment. "I'll do the Crowley's run. Check in with Rennie while I'm there."

"Good. Tell him about Don's vehicle. He'll want the location."

They finished their coffee and went out into the yard. The morning was clear and cool, the light still pale on the red dirt. Miro walked toward the airstrip with his hat on and the chart under his arm. Arthur loaded the truck — the list was short, half a dozen items, an easy run. Lucky jumped into the tray without being asked and stood with his paws on the rail, watching Miro's figure shrink down the track toward the strip.

Arthur started the engine and pulled out of the yard. In the mirror, the homestead settled into the landscape behind him — tin roof, water tank, windmill turning. Ahead, the track ran straight through the mulga toward the highway and the hour's drive to Mulga Creek.

Crowley's was quiet. Keith was restocking shelves and Donna was behind the counter with her glasses on her nose and a pencil behind her ear. The bell above the door rang when Arthur came in and Keith looked up and smiled — wide, genuine, as if Arthur's arrival was the best thing that had happened all morning.

"Arthur. Good to see you. How's the station?"

“Running. Miro and I are managing.”

“More than managing, from what I hear.” Keith came around the end of the aisle. “Donna, Arthur’s here.”

“I can see that, Keith. I have eyes.”

Arthur handed over the list. Donna read it and went to work, pulling items from shelves — she knew where everything was and resented being asked. Keith talked — about the weather, about a road crew that had come through last week, about whether the pub had finally fixed its hot water. Arthur listened and helped carry boxes to the counter.

“Anything else?” Donna asked.

“That’s the lot. Put it on the account.”

She wrote it down in pencil on Keith’s pad, the same pad that had been tracking the station account since before Arthur arrived. He carried the boxes to the truck, stacked them in the tray beside Lucky, and walked up the street to the pub.

The Mulga Creek Hotel was dim and cool inside, same as always. The smell of beer and floor polish. Two men at a table by the window — locals, Arthur recognized them from previous visits. A woman behind the bar he hadn’t seen before, younger than the usual barman, drying glasses with a cloth.

He ordered a beer and sat at the bar. Rennie wasn’t here yet. Arthur had seen his vehicle outside the station — the police station, not the pub — and figured he’d come over when he saw the truck. The beer was cold and the bar was quiet and Arthur drank and looked at the light coming through the front window and waited.

A man came in. Arthur heard the door and the footsteps and registered the details without turning his head — steady gait, deliberate, shoes not boots. The man walked to the bar and sat on the stool next to Arthur. Not the next stool down. The one right beside him.

Arthur looked at him. Mid-forties, fit through the shoulders, clean-shaven. He wore a collared shirt and dark trousers and his shoes were leather and

polished and wrong for Mulga Creek. His hands were on the bar and they were still — comfortable being watched.

“Hot out there,” the man said. American accent. East Coast. The vowels were flat and precise.

“It’s Central Australia,” Arthur said. “It’s always hot.”

The man smiled. It was a practiced smile, the kind that used the right muscles without engaging anything behind the eyes. He ordered a beer from the girl behind the bar and waited until it arrived and took a sip and set it down.

“You’re Arthur,” he said.

Arthur didn’t answer. His hands were on the bar, one around his glass, the other flat on the wood. The two locals by the window were talking about cattle prices. The girl behind the bar was at the far end, sorting bottles.

“I know who you are,” the man said. “I know where you worked. I know what you filed and who you filed it with and what happened after. I know about the Office of Special Counsel and I know about Diana Marsh and I know about the parking lot in Sterling.” He said it quietly, conversationally, the way you’d discuss the weather with a stranger. “I also know about Karen Lowe, and June Paterson’s notebook, and the little operation you’ve been running out here with your cousin and the local cop.”

Arthur’s chest tightened. The names hit him in sequence — Diana Marsh, Sterling, Karen Lowe — each one a door that should have been closed, opened from the outside. He took a breath and let it out and kept his hands where they were.

“That’s a lot of knowing,” Arthur said. “You must read a lot.”

“I’m a thorough person.” The man turned his beer on the coaster. “Here’s what I want you to understand. You left the country. That was smart. Nobody was going to follow you to the other side of the world over a compliance dispute that was already fading from the news cycle. You were off the board. Done. Finished.” He paused. “And then you decided to play the same game on a different board. Same company, same patterns, same crusade. You hired a lawyer. You organized the locals. You started building

a case that connects what's happening here to what happened there." He looked at Arthur. "That was not smart."

"I didn't plan it."

"I don't care what you planned. I care what you did. You put yourself back in play. People who were content to let you rot in the desert are now very much not content. You've become a problem that solves itself only if you stop."

"Stop?"

"Everything. The lawyer, the notebook, the families, the documentation. All of it. Walk away from it and go back to being invisible and this conversation is the last one we'll need to have."

Arthur picked up his beer and drank. The glass was wet and cold in his hand. The two locals had stopped talking. They were looking at the bar now, at the two men sitting side by side, and the room had gone quiet in the way rooms go quiet when something is wrong and people haven't decided yet what to do about it.

"You flew a long way to deliver a message you could have emailed," Arthur said.

"Emails get forwarded." The man's voice dropped half a register. "This doesn't."

Arthur set his glass down. "Here's what I understand. You weren't coming. You said it yourself — I was off the board. You came because I started making noise about what Meridian is doing to families out here, and that noise connected to the noise I made in Washington, and now someone has a two-continent problem they didn't have before." He looked at the man. "Which means what I'm doing is working. Which means I'm not going to stop."

The man's jaw tightened. Something shifted behind the practiced composure — a recalculation, or the absence of one. He'd expected the message to land. It hadn't.

He put his hand on Arthur's forearm. Not a grip — a placement. Firm, deliberate, his fingers pressing into the muscle above the wrist. "You should reconsider."

Arthur moved. His right hand came off the bar and caught the man's wrist and stripped it off his arm in a single motion — a Krav release, fast and mechanical, wrist turned outward against the thumb. The man's hand came free and Arthur kept hold of it and twisted and the man's shoulder dropped and his body followed and Arthur drove him sideways off the stool.

The man was faster than the Best Buy thugs. He caught himself before he hit the floor, got his feet under him, and threw a short hard punch at Arthur's ribs. It landed. Arthur felt the impact through his side and the air went out of him for a second and then the training took over — the part of him that Maya had built in six years of Wednesday and Friday and Sunday sessions, the part that didn't think, just moved. He stepped inside the man's reach and hit him twice, fast — an open-palm strike to the jaw and an elbow to the temple — and the man staggered and Arthur hit him again, a straight right to the center of the face, and the man went down on one knee with blood coming from his nose.

The pub was silent. The two locals were on their feet. The girl behind the bar had backed against the wall. Arthur's ribs were on fire and his knuckles were split and his lip was bleeding where the man's first punch had caught him on the way in.

Then the second man stood up.

He'd been at the table by the far wall. Arthur hadn't marked him when he came in — he'd been sitting with a newspaper and a glass of water, unremarkable, invisible. He was bigger than the first man. Younger. He came off his chair and crossed the room in four strides and Arthur turned to face him with the first man still on the floor behind him and his ribs screaming and his hands up and the knowledge that this was where it got bad.

The second man was good. He feinted left and came right and Arthur caught the punch on his forearm but the force of it drove him back against the bar. Arthur grabbed a glass and threw it — not at the man's face, at his feet, to make him look down — and in the half-second gap he stepped forward

and drove a knee into the man's thigh. The man grunted and swung and Arthur ducked it and hit him in the kidney and they were locked together now, grappling, too close for clean strikes, and the man was stronger than Arthur and getting his arms around him and squeezing.

The door opened. Rennie filled it. He stood there for one second — the wrecked bar, Arthur bleeding, the first man on the floor, the second man bear-hugging Arthur against the bar rail — and then he moved. He crossed the room and got the second man from behind, one arm around his neck, pulling him off Arthur. The man let go and turned on Rennie and hit him hard in the stomach. Rennie doubled but didn't go down. He was a big man and he'd been hit before and he came back up swinging — not trained, not graceful, but solid, twenty years of remote postings where backup was hours away.

The operative caught Rennie's punch and twisted his arm and Rennie's face went white with pain. Arthur came off the bar and hit the man from the side — a short brutal hook to the jaw, everything he had left behind it. The man's head snapped and his grip on Rennie loosened and Rennie pulled free and Arthur hit him again and Rennie hit him and the man went down.

The pub was wrecked. Two overturned stools, a broken glass, beer on the floor. The first man was sitting against the wall holding his nose. The second was on the floor. Rennie was bent over with his hands on his knees, breathing hard. Arthur leaned against the bar and pressed his hand to his ribs and tasted blood from his split lip.

The two locals and the girl behind the bar were all talking at once.

"He started it," said the older local, pointing at the first man on the floor. "Grabbed him. We heard everything. Threatened him. American bloke, the both of them."

Rennie straightened up. He looked at Arthur. He looked at the two men on the floor. He pulled his handcuffs from his belt and cuffed the second man first, then the first, wrists behind their backs.

"Everyone all right?" he said.

"Been better," Arthur said.

“I’ll bet.” Rennie looked at the locals. “You two stay. I’ll need statements.” He looked at the girl. “You too.” He hauled the first man to his feet and then the second and walked them out the door. Arthur followed.

Their vehicle was parked behind the pub. White dual-cab, no dust, Territory plates. Rennie put both men in the back of his police vehicle and locked it and went to the dual-cab. Arthur leaned against the pub wall and watched. His ribs ached with every breath and his hands were shaking — not from fear, from the adrenaline coming off, the same shaking he’d had on Route 7 after Best Buy.

Rennie opened the driver’s door and looked through the cab. He opened the glovebox. He checked under the seats. Then he went around to the tray and lifted the tonneau cover and Arthur saw him go still.

“Arthur.”

Arthur walked over. In the tray, under the cover, was a black duffle bag. Rennie unzipped it. Inside: a laptop, a sat phone, a folder of papers, and a stack of photographs. Rennie put on gloves and lifted the photographs out and spread them on the tailgate.

The homestead. Taken from distance, telephoto lens. The verandah, the machinery shed, the water tank. Arthur’s truck in the yard. The Warners’ place — the house, the chook shed, the water tank where Sam had hidden with Lily. The Patersons’ property. Reg’s stone house with its single tree.

And then the last ones. Lily in the yard at the Warners’, hanging washing on the line. Sam sitting on the verandah steps with a book. Close shots. Their faces clear, framed with the care of wanting to know exactly what they looked like.

Arthur stared at the photographs and his hands stopped shaking. Something else replaced the adrenaline — something cold, something that had edges.

Rennie laid the photos of the children on the tailgate side by side. He looked at them for a long time. Then he gathered them up and put them back in the folder and zipped the duffle and carried it to his vehicle.

“Come to the station,” he said. His voice was flat. Not angry — past angry. He’d just found something that changed what he was willing to do.

At the police station, Rennie put the two men in the single holding cell and locked it. Then he went back to the front office and picked up the phone and called Keith Crowley.

“Keith. Dave Rennie. I need you to come to the station. Official business. Bring yourself and nobody else.”

Keith arrived in five minutes, still wearing his shop apron. Rennie sat him down in the office and told him what had happened at the pub and showed him the photographs from the truck. Keith looked at the photos of the homestead and the families’ properties and nodded. Then Rennie put the photos of Lily and Sam on the desk.

Keith’s face changed. He picked up the photo of Lily — nine years old, hanging washing, unaware — and held it and looked at it and then set it down carefully, as if it were evidence, which it was.

“Jesus Christ,” Keith said.

“I’m going to ask them about these,” Rennie said. “I want you here as a witness. You don’t need to say anything. Just be present.”

He brought the first man out — the one who’d talked to Arthur at the bar. Sat him in the chair across from the desk. The man’s nose had stopped bleeding but his face was swollen and his eyes were careful.

Rennie put the photos of the children on the desk between them.

“These were in your vehicle,” Rennie said. “Surveillance photographs of two minors. A nine-year-old girl and a twelve-year-old boy. I want to know what you intended to do with these.”

The man looked at the photos and then at Rennie. “I want a lawyer.”

“You’ll get one. I’m asking you a question.”

“I’m not answering questions without legal representation.”

Rennie nodded. He put the photos of Lily back on the desk, face up, positioned so Keith could see them clearly. “For the record, the suspect has declined to explain the presence of surveillance photographs of minors in his vehicle. Keith, you’ve seen these photographs?”

“I have,” Keith said. His voice was steady but his hands were gripping the arms of his chair.

Rennie took the man back to the cell and brought out the second. Same questions, same result — lawyer, no answers. Rennie showed the photos again. Keith saw them again. The record was made.

After both men were back in the cell, Rennie called Alice Springs. He gave the details to the duty officer — two arrests for assault, with witnesses, additional charges likely relating to surveillance of minors and possession of reconnaissance materials. He requested a transport team and was told tomorrow morning at earliest.

“That’s fine,” Rennie said. “They’re not going anywhere.”

The first man called out from the cell. He wanted his phone call. Rennie gave him the desk phone. Arthur and Keith stood in the office and listened to one side of a conversation that was short and unhappy. The man gave a number and asked for legal representation and was told — Arthur could see it in his face — that a lawyer would meet him in Alice Springs.

Not here. Not now. In Alice Springs, after transport. Whenever that might be.

The man hung up. He looked at the phone and then at the wall and his expression settled into something Arthur recognized from years of watching institutional machinery grind. The look of a man realizing he was a line item, not a person. Expendable. Deniable. Already written off.

Rennie noticed too.

Arthur drove back to the station with Lucky beside him in the cab — he’d moved the dog up front for the drive home, wanting the company. His ribs throbbed with every bump in the road and his lip had swollen and he could

feel the bruise spreading across his side. The shaking had stopped. In its place was a clarity that felt dangerous.

The operative had told him the truth without meaning to. You were off the board. You put yourself back in play. Which meant CWIR hadn't been coming. Arthur in Australia was a solved problem — irrelevant, distant, fading. What brought them was the same thing that had brought the corporate operatives to the Warners' yard and the Patersons' boundary: Arthur's refusal to watch it happen and do nothing. His pattern-recognition, his analyst's instinct for connecting data points across systems, his inability to see corruption and walk past it.

The same trait that had gotten him fired and hunted and beaten in a parking lot had now gotten him beaten in a pub on the other side of the world. And the same trait was the only thing that could end it. Not running. Not hiding. Breaking the operation — here, where the evidence was fresh and the people were real and a nine-year-old girl's photo was sitting in a police station as proof that the machine didn't care who it hurt.

He pulled into the yard as the Cessna was taxiing up the strip. Miro cut the engine and climbed out and walked toward the truck and stopped when he saw Arthur's face.

"What happened to you?"

"I met some people in town."

Miro looked at the split lip, the arm pressed against his ribs. "How many?"

"Two. Rennie helped with the second one." Arthur got out of the truck and Lucky jumped down and went to the verandah. "There's more. Let's sit down."

He told Miro everything. The American accent, the DC references, Diana Marsh and Sterling and the Office of Special Counsel — names that meant nothing to Miro but meant everything to the story. The operative's message: you were off the radar, you made yourself visible again, the two problems have converged. The fight. Rennie walking in. The truck. The photographs. He told him about the photos of Lily and Sam.

Miro was leaning against the verandah post. He didn't move while Arthur talked. His face was still and his hands were still and the only thing that changed was his eyes — they narrowed when Arthur mentioned the children's photographs and stayed that way.

"How long has Rennie got them?" Miro asked.

"Until tomorrow. Alice Springs is sending a transport team."

"And after that?"

"Charges. Lowe will push for a restraining order against the corporate entities. But these two are the muscle, not the brain."

"There are more of them."

"Yes." Arthur paused. "You flew the eastern boundary this morning. Tell me what you found."

Miro straightened. "White four-wheel drive, parked in the scrub about three kilometers inside the eastern fence. I came in low — fifty feet. Driver was in the cab with a tablet or a phone. He saw me and bolted. I got the plate — wrote it down as soon as I landed. Different plate from anything Rennie has on file."

"So there's at least one more out there beyond the two in custody."

"At least." Miro looked at the yard, at the shed, at the track running south. "They'll know their boys got arrested. They'll either pull back or push harder."

"Lowe says they push harder."

Miro nodded. He went inside and came back with the gun cabinet key and opened the cabinet in the hallway. Two rifles and a shotgun. He took out the bolt-action — the same rifle that had lived in the truck rack and then by the front door — and carried it to the verandah along with the shotgun and a cleaning kit and the box of cartridges.

Arthur watched him lay them out on the verandah boards. Miro sat down and picked up the bolt-action and began disassembling it with the practiced hands of twenty years maintaining station firearms. He didn't say anything.

He oiled the bolt and wiped the barrel and checked the action and moved on to the shotgun. Arthur sat beside him and loaded cartridges into the magazine for the second rifle — the one from the cabinet — and they worked in the evening light with Lucky at Arthur's feet and the tin roof ticking above them and the country going dark in every direction.

They didn't talk about what they were preparing for. They didn't need to. The guns were clean and oiled and loaded and leaning against the wall by the front door when Arthur opened his laptop.

Hel — Two men found me in the pub in Mulga Creek today. Americans. One of them knew about the agency, about Diana Marsh, about Sterling. He told me I'd been off their radar until I started fighting the land campaign here. The Australian operation reported up, someone connected my name, and now I'm a two-continent problem.

He told me to stop. I didn't.

It went physical. Rennie arrived and helped. Both men arrested — multiple witnesses, they started it. Rennie searched their truck and found reconnaissance photos of the station, the families' properties, and surveillance shots of Lily and Sam. Close-ups. Framed. I can't describe what that felt like.

Miro flew over the eastern boundary today and spotted a third vehicle — different plate, not in Rennie's files. There are more of them out there.

The two in custody called for a lawyer. They were told the lawyer would meet them in Alice Springs. Not here. Not now. Meridian is cutting them loose. Rennie noticed.

I know what this means. They came because what we're doing is working. The path out is through, not away. But it's going to get worse before it gets better and I need you thinking about the next move.

—A

He sent it and sat on the verandah with Miro and the clean guns and the dark. Lucky breathed at his feet. The stars came out. Neither of them went inside.

Helen's reply arrived at eleven.

Arthur — I read your email and called Karen Lowe before I finished it. She's already moving. Emergency restraining order against Dryden Pastoral, Eastmark Holdings, and their agents — the arrest and the children's photos give her grounds. She's also calling a journalist she knows at ABC — the Australian Broadcasting Corporation. A US operative arrested in outback Australia with surveillance photos of local children is a story, Arthur. It's the kind of story that makes corporate boards very uncomfortable.

You're thinking tactically. I'm thinking strategically. Let me handle the exposure side. You and Miro handle the ground. Rennie handles the law. Karen handles the courts. We are not alone in this and we are not improvising anymore.

Be careful. Lock the doors. Watch the guns. I love you.

—H

Arthur read it twice. Helen had moved before he'd asked. She'd called the lawyer, started the media strategy, reframed the situation from defense to offense — all in the time it took him to write an email and oil a rifle. She was ahead of him. She'd been ahead of him since the phone call, maybe since the beginning. He'd been thinking about the fight. She'd been thinking about the war.

He showed the email to Miro. Miro read it and handed the laptop back.

"Your cousin," Miro said.

"Yeah."

"She's good."

"She is."

Miro stood up. "I'll do the HF calls in the morning. The families should hear it from one of us, not from town gossip."

"Together," Arthur said. "I'll talk to the Warners and the Patersons. You talk to Reg."

"Right." Miro picked up the shotgun and leaned it inside the door.

He didn't walk toward his quarters. He walked across the yard to the stockman's building and came back three minutes later with his swag under one arm and a canvas bag in the other. Everything he owned. He carried it down the hallway and into Ted's room and Arthur heard him set the bag down and unroll the swag on the bed.

He came back to the hallway. "Makes more sense," he said. "One building."

"It does."

"Night."

"Night."

Arthur sat alone. The verandah was dark. The guns were by the door. Lucky was at his feet. Somewhere out in the district, beyond the homestead lights, beyond the mulga and the spinifex and the vast red ground, there were people who had photographs of a nine-year-old girl and a twelve-year-old boy and a plan that didn't care about either of them. And somewhere in Bethesda, his cousin was on the phone to a lawyer and a journalist and the machinery of exposure that was the only weapon that had ever worked against people like this.

He locked the door. He checked the windows. He went to bed with the rifle leaning against the wall beside him and Lucky on the floor and the silence of the station pressing in — not the peaceful silence of the first weeks, not the grieving silence after Ted. A different silence. The silence before.

Chapter 15 — The Wall

The Alice Springs transport team arrived at nine — two officers in a white police van, unhurried, professional. They signed Rennie’s paperwork at the front desk while the two operatives sat in the holding cell and watched through the bars. Arthur stood by the truck across the street with Lucky at his feet and a coffee from Crowley’s going cold in his hand.

Rennie came out after the van pulled away. He crossed the street and leaned against the truck next to Arthur and they watched the van disappear south on the highway in a plume of dust.

“Charges are solid,” Rennie said. “Assault, witness intimidation, possession of surveillance materials. Alice will process them today.”

“And then?”

“Bail hearing. Probably tomorrow.”

“They’ll make bail.”

Rennie looked at him. “Probably. Corporate money, no prior record in this jurisdiction, no flight risk because they’ve got no reason to flee — their employers want them here.” He drank his own coffee. “But the charges don’t go away. The file doesn’t close. And Keith Crowley saw those photos, which means by lunchtime every person in Mulga Creek will have heard about the two Americans with pictures of Lily and Sam in their truck.”

“That helps?”

“That helps more than you’d think. Out here, people knowing is people watching. Every station, every roadhouse, every truckie on the Stuart Highway. These blokes can’t sneeze without someone calling me.”

Arthur finished his coffee. It was bitter and cold. “Lowe said they escalate.”

“They might. But they’re doing it in a fishbowl now.” Rennie pushed off the truck. “I’ll be in touch.”

The call came that afternoon. Arthur was on the verandah replacing a hinge on the screen door — a job that required two hands and patience and kept

his mind off things that patience couldn't fix. His ribs complained every time he lifted the drill. Lucky was in the shade under Ted's chair.

The satellite phone rang inside. Arthur set down the drill and went in and answered.

"Arthur, it's Dave." Rennie's voice was flat — the tone he used when working through something. "Just had a conversation with my district superintendent in Alice."

"And?"

"The assault charges stand. That's solid — witnesses, my report, the photos. Nobody's touching that. But." A pause. Arthur could hear Rennie choosing his words. "The broader situation — the surveillance, the corporate entities, the connection to Dryden and Eastmark — that's being characterized as a civil matter. Commercial dispute over land use. My involvement should be limited to the criminal charges arising from the pub incident."

"That's the official position."

"That's the official position." Another pause. "Unofficially, nobody told me to stop keeping my eyes open. The assault file gives me reason to maintain awareness of the individuals and their associates in my district. If I happen to notice things in the course of my normal duties, that's professional diligence, not overreach."

"He said that?"

"Not in those words. But he said it." Rennie's voice shifted — drier, almost amused. "He also mentioned that the assault file is well-documented and that my witness management was, quote, thorough. I took that as encouragement."

"So you've got a ceiling but not a wall."

"I've got a ceiling with a crack in it. I'll work with that."

Arthur hung up and stood in the kitchen with the phone in his hand. The ceiling was familiar. In Washington it had been the Office of Special Counsel — theoretically his protector, practically a bottleneck that converted urgent complaints into administrative reviews that took eighteen months and

concluded nothing. The machinery existed to process problems, not solve them. He'd spent three years learning that distinction.

He went back to the hinge.

The HF crackled at five. Matt Warner's voice, thin and strained through the static.

"Arthur, we've got a problem. The bore on our eastern boundary's gone. Pump seized this morning — I pulled the housing and the intake's packed with something. Rocks, clay, I don't know. It didn't fail on its own."

"When did you last check it?"

"Three days ago. It was fine. Running clean." A pause. Static hissed. "Arthur, that bore feeds the eastern paddock and the house tank backup. Without it we're on the main tank and that's got maybe ten days in this heat."

Arthur looked out the window. Miro was crossing the yard from the machinery shed, drawn by the sound of the HF.

"I'll get Miro on the radio. He'll know what you need."

"I know what I need. I need someone to pull that pump and clear the intake and reassemble it. I can do it but it's a two-man job and I can't leave Sarah and the kids alone right now."

Miro was in the doorway. Arthur tilted the handset so he could hear.

"Matt, Miro's here. Hold on."

Miro took the handset. "Matt. Tell me about the intake." He listened. His face didn't change but his eyes narrowed the way they'd narrowed when Arthur told him about the photos. "Right. I'll bring the pump kit and the generator. I can be there by dark if I leave now."

He handed the radio back to Arthur and was already moving — toward the shed, toward the tools, toward the truck. Arthur followed him into the yard.

"I'll stay overnight," Miro said, loading the pump kit into the tray. "Fix the bore in the morning, check the other two while I'm out there." He looked at Arthur. "You'll be right here on your own?"

“I’ll be fine.”

“Lock the doors.”

“I will.”

Miro threw his swag into the tray and climbed in. He started the engine and pulled out of the yard without ceremony — the way he did everything, as Ted had before him. The truck disappeared down the track and the dust settled and Arthur was alone at the homestead with Lucky and the guns by the door and the long evening ahead.

He sat on the verandah and watched the light change and thought about a bore that had been running clean three days ago and wasn’t now. The timing was precise. The operatives arrested, the families warned, and within forty-eight hours the Warners’ water supply was compromised. Not the Patersons, whose notebook was the legal foundation. Not Reg, who was old and alone and would have been easier to pressure. The Warners. The family with the children whose photos had been in that truck.

The message was clear: we know what you found and we don’t care.

He couldn’t sit still the next morning. Lucky watched him pace the kitchen, eat half a piece of toast, pour coffee he didn’t drink. The homestead was too quiet with Miro gone — not the comfortable quiet of early mornings when they moved around each other in practiced silence, but an empty quiet that pressed on him.

He called Rennie. “I’m driving to Alice. Lowe, then the Department of Mines. I need to push on both.”

“Want company?”

“Stay here. Stay visible. If anyone’s watching the station, I’d rather they see your vehicle than an empty yard.”

“Fair enough. I’ll park out front for a few hours.”

Arthur loaded Lucky into the cab, filled a bowl of water and wedged it behind the passenger seat, and drove south. The highway unrolled ahead of him — red dirt shoulders, mulga scrub, the sky huge and pale and empty. His

ribs ached with every corrugation in the road. The split lip had closed but the bruise along his left side was deep purple now, tender when he breathed too hard or turned too fast. He drove with his left arm braced against the door to absorb the bumps and Lucky sat beside him with his head on his paws and his eyes half-closed.

The drive was three hours and he spent most of it thinking. Not constructively — the circling kind of thinking that covers the same ground and finds nothing new. The bore at the Warners'. The operative's voice in the pub: *you were off the board*. Lowe's counter-motion and the magistrate who wanted more time. Rennie's ceiling. The same pattern he'd watched unfold in Washington — not conspiracy, not corruption in any room he could point to, just the slow institutional preference for inaction over action, for process over urgency, for the comfort of doing nothing over the risk of doing something.

He'd written a report once, early in his career, about a chromium contamination site in West Virginia. Fourteen families on well water. The data was clear, the violations documented, the remedy straightforward. The report went up the chain and came back with requests for additional sampling, revised methodology, inter-agency consultation. By the time the remediation order was signed, three families had moved and two had stopped drinking the water and started buying bottled. The system had worked, eventually. It just hadn't worked in time.

He pulled into Alice Springs at eleven and parked on Bath Street in the shade of a eucalyptus and cracked the windows for Lucky and put the water bowl on the floor.

Karen Lowe's office was the same — small, functional, the law books and the Melbourne degree and the window overlooking the street. She stood when he came in and looked at his face — the fading bruise on his lip, the arm braced against his left side — and didn't comment.

"Sit down. I'll give you the short version."

She opened a folder. "The restraining order application is before the magistrate. Meridian's lawyers — and they have good ones, a firm in Sydney

— filed a counter-motion arguing that Dryden Pastoral is a legitimate consulting entity with no connection to the incidents described in my application. They’ve produced registration documents, a business plan, client references. All fabricated, I’m certain, but fabricated well enough that the magistrate wants more evidence before he’ll grant an interim order.”

“How long?”

“Two weeks. Maybe three. He’s not hostile — he’s cautious. The corporate structure is opaque and he doesn’t want to restrain a legitimate business on the basis of one arrest and a collection of photographs that could be characterized as due diligence imagery.”

“Photos of children?”

“Photos of properties that happen to include children. That’s how they’ll frame it and it’s not a frivolous argument.” Lowe’s voice was steady. She’d been through this before. “The FOI request to the Department of Mines has been acknowledged. No response timeline. I’ve sent a follow-up citing the statutory deadline but the department has sixty days and they’ll use every one of them.”

Arthur sat with it. Two weeks on the restraining order. Sixty days on the FOI. The operatives would make bail today or tomorrow. The bore at the Warners’ was already sabotaged. The timeline of the legal system and the timeline of the physical threat were operating on different clocks.

“I told you they raise the cost,” Lowe said. “They’re raising it back.”

“I know.”

She closed the folder and opened another — thinner, just a few pages. “There’s something else. The ABC journalist I contacted — Rachel Tan, in the Alice bureau. She was interested after the arrest. I sent her the outline — US operative, outback assault, children’s photos, corporate chain. She took it to her editor and it went to legal review.” Lowe paused. “She hasn’t called me back. It’s been four days.”

“Editorial caution?”

“Possibly. Or pressure. I don’t know which and I don’t want to speculate without more.” She looked at him. “She’s in the Todd Street office. If you’re here anyway, it might be worth stopping in. It’s harder to not return a call when the person is sitting in front of you.”

The Department of Mines and Energy was on Gregory Terrace — a low government building with tinted windows and a car park full of white sedans. Arthur signed in at reception and waited twenty minutes in a corridor with fluorescent lighting and framed photographs of mining operations on the walls. The carpet was gray. The air conditioning hummed. He could have been in any government building in any city in any country and the feeling was the same — the particular hush of institutions that process paper instead of problems.

A man came out. Mid-fifties, shirt and tie, a lanyard with his photo and a name Arthur didn’t retain. He shook Arthur’s hand and led him to a small meeting room and offered water and sat down with a folder that was too thin to contain anything useful.

Arthur laid it out. The station, the families, the pattern of interference — services cut, bores sabotaged, roads closed, unauthorized survey activity. The corporate chain: Dryden Pastoral to Eastmark Holdings to an offshore entity. The arrest of two operatives with surveillance photos. He spoke for ten minutes, clearly and specifically, the way he’d learned to present findings in a different government building on a different continent.

The man listened and nodded and took notes and when Arthur finished he said, “Thank you for bringing this to our attention. I can confirm that exploration permit applications have been lodged for areas in the district you’ve described. These are currently under standard assessment. The process is thorough and includes consideration of existing pastoral leases and stakeholder concerns.”

“When were the permits lodged?”

“I’d need to check the specific dates. That information would be available through a formal request.”

“I’ve already filed an FOI.”

“Then you’ll receive a comprehensive response within the statutory time-frame.”

Arthur looked at him. The man’s face was pleasant and closed. He had answered questions like this many times and learned that courtesy was a more effective barrier than hostility. He wasn’t corrupt. He wasn’t malicious. He was a functionary in a system that moved at its own speed regardless of what was happening on the ground, and he would go home tonight and not think about a nine-year-old girl whose bore water had just been cut off.

“The families I’m describing are living under active threat,” Arthur said. “Sabotaged infrastructure, surveillance, physical intimidation. The entities applying for those permits are connected to the people doing this.”

“I understand your concern. As I said, the assessment process is thorough and stakeholder submissions are welcomed.”

Arthur stood up. He shook the man’s hand because there was nothing else to do with it and walked out through the corridor with the mining photographs and the gray carpet and into the sunlight, where the heat hit him like a wall and the sky was white and the parking lot shimmered.

He sat in the truck for a minute with Lucky panting beside him. He ran the air conditioning and drank water from a bottle and let his hands stop gripping the steering wheel. The Department of Mines and Energy. The Office of Special Counsel. Different buildings, different continents, same carpet.

The ABC office was on Todd Street, a small bureau in a commercial building. Arthur left Lucky in the truck with the air conditioning running and went in. A young man at the front desk asked if he had an appointment.

“No. I’m looking for Rachel Tan. Karen Lowe suggested I stop by.”

The young man went into the back. Arthur waited. The office was open-plan behind the reception area — a few desks, monitors, a television on the wall showing the ABC News channel with the sound off. Two people at desks, neither of them looking up.

Rachel Tan came out. She was younger than Arthur had expected — early thirties, sharp-featured, wearing a cotton dress and sandals. She looked at Arthur's face — the bruise, the split lip — and something registered.

"You're Arthur."

"I am."

"Let's go across the street." She grabbed a notebook and they walked to a café on the corner and sat at a table by the window. She ordered a long black. Arthur ordered water.

"Karen Lowe sent me the outline," Tan said. "It's a story. US-linked operatives, a corporate entity running an intimidation campaign against pastoral families, surveillance photos of children. The arrest gives it a news hook."

"But."

She turned her coffee cup on its saucer. "My editor wants more sourcing before we go to air. The corporate chain — Dryden to Eastmark to offshore — needs independent verification. The connection between the arrested men and Meridian Resources needs documentation beyond circumstantial. The FOI on the exploration permits would help but we don't have it yet."

"Is that editorial caution or something else?"

Tan looked at him directly. Her eyes were steady and undefended. "It's editorial caution that might have been amplified by something else. I can't prove that and I won't speculate on the record. What I can tell you is that the story isn't dead. It's in a holding pattern."

Arthur nodded. The coffee shop was quiet. A ceiling fan turned overhead.

"Can I tell you something off the record?" Tan said.

"Go ahead."

"Meridian Resources has come across my desk before. Not here — a contact in Melbourne flagged them eighteen months ago. A researcher named Peter Caruso, works out of Monash University. He's been tracking Meridian's operations in the Pilbara and in central Queensland. Community displace-

ment, environmental violations, the same pattern — indirect pressure on families holding pastoral leases over ground Meridian wants to mine.”

“Same playbook.”

“Same playbook. Different states, different families, same corporate behavior.” She tore a strip from her notebook and wrote a name and phone number. “Caruso’s been trying to get media traction for a year. He’s got documentation. If your evidence connects to his, you don’t have an outback story about one station. You have a national pattern.”

Arthur took the paper and folded it and put it in his shirt pocket. “Thank you.”

“Don’t thank me. Get me the sourcing and I’ll run the story. That’s how this works.”

They shook hands outside the café. Tan went back to the bureau. Arthur stood on the footpath and looked at the name on the paper — Peter Caruso, Monash — and put it away and walked back to the truck.

He almost missed it. He was thirty meters from the truck, walking up Bath Street past Lowe’s building, when a man came out of a doorway on the other side of the street. Mid-forties, clean-shaven, collared shirt. A strip of surgical tape across the bridge of his nose.

Arthur stopped.

The operative from the pub. The talker. Walking out of what looked like a lawyer’s office, moving with the unhurried gait of somewhere to be but no rush to get there. He’d made bail. Less than forty-eight hours.

The man reached a silver sedan parked at the curb and opened the door and paused. He looked up the street and saw Arthur. Twenty meters of footpath and parked cars between them. The man’s hand rested on the car door. His face showed nothing — no surprise, no hostility, nothing at all. He held Arthur’s gaze for three seconds and then he got in the car and drove away.

Arthur stood on the footpath and watched the sedan turn the corner and disappear. Lucky was visible through the truck windscreen, head up,

watching him. The sun was directly overhead and Bath Street was quiet and the operative was free and the restraining order was stalled and the Department of Mines was reviewing applications within the statutory timeframe.

He got in the truck and drove north.

The drive back was long and the thinking was different this time. Not circular — linear, building toward something. The journalist had given him a name. Caruso at Monash. A researcher who'd been tracking Meridian across multiple states for a year, who had documentation, who was looking for the same connection that Arthur was building from the other end. If Caruso's evidence linked to theirs — the notebook, the corporate chain, the surveillance, the arrested operatives — then Lowe had a stronger case, Tan had her sourcing, and Helen had the international angle she'd been building toward.

The legal system was slow. The media was cautious. The bureaucracy was deaf. But the evidence existed and the people who'd gathered it were still gathering it and the wall was a wall, not a cliff. Walls had doors. You just had to find them, and sometimes finding them took longer than you wanted.

He pulled into the yard at dusk. Rennie's vehicle had been and gone — tire tracks in the dust, a note wedged in the screen door: *All quiet. Back tomorrow. —D.R.*

Arthur fed Lucky and heated a tin of soup and sat on the verandah in the dark and opened his laptop.

Hel — Drove to Alice today. Three meetings, three walls.

Lowe: restraining order stalled. Meridian's lawyers counter-filed, magistrate wants more evidence, two to three weeks minimum. FOI acknowledged, sixty days. She's solid but she can't make the system move faster than it moves.

Dept of Mines: exploration permits already lodged. Standard assessment, stakeholder submissions welcomed, thank you for your concern. I sat in a government office with fluorescent lights and gray carpet and heard the same

words I heard for three years in Washington. Different building, different hemisphere, same language.

ABC journalist — Rachel Tan. Story's in a holding pattern. Editorial wants more sourcing, and she hinted at pressure she can't name. But she gave me something. A researcher at Monash University in Melbourne — Peter Caruso — has been tracking Meridian's operations in the Pilbara and Queensland. Same pattern. Community displacement, environmental violations, families pushed off pastoral leases. If his evidence connects to ours, we don't have a local story. We have a national one.

Caruso's number is in my pocket. I think you should call him. You'll be better at this than I am — connecting the dots across jurisdictions, building the case for a bigger story. That's your kind of fight.

One more thing. I saw the operative. The first one, the talker from the pub. Walking out of a lawyer's office on Bath Street. Free. Bail. Less than 48 hours. He looked at me and got in a car and drove away.

The wall is the same wall. We'll go through it. It'll just take longer than I wanted.

—A

Miro came back the next afternoon. Arthur heard the truck before he saw it — the engine note coming up the track, the rattle of tools in the tray. Miro pulled into the yard and Lucky ran out and circled the truck and Miro got out and looked tired in a way that had nothing to do with the drive.

“Bore's fixed,” he said. “Intake was packed with calcium slurry — the kind you get downstream from a treated bore, not naturally. Someone dumped it in. Took four hours to clear and reassemble.”

“Deliberate.”

“No question. Matt said the other two bores are running clean. I checked them both.”

They unloaded the truck. Miro moved the pump kit back to the shed and Arthur carried the swag to the verandah and they stood in the yard in the late afternoon light.

“How are they?” Arthur asked.

“Sarah’s steady. Matt’s angry. Lily asked if the bad men were going to come back.” Miro looked at the yard, the shed, the track. “A vehicle came past twice while I was there. White four-wheel drive, different plates from anything Rennie has. Circled the property and drove off. Didn’t stop. Didn’t need to.”

“They wanted you to see them.”

“They wanted Matt and Sarah to see them.” Miro sat on the verandah step. “I parked the truck out front both nights. Slept on their verandah with the rifle.”

Arthur sat beside him. The two of them on the step, the yard between them and the country beyond, the light going gold.

“Alice was the same,” Arthur said. He told Miro about Lowe and the counter-motion, the bureaucrat with the thin folder, Tan and the holding pattern. He told him about Caruso.

“Melbourne,” Miro said.

“Helen’s going to call him. If his research connects to ours, the story gets bigger than one station.”

“And until then?”

“Until then we hold the ground.”

Miro looked at him. His face was the face it always was — composed, giving nothing away — but something behind the composure had settled into place, the way a post settles into packed earth. He wasn’t waiting for the system to protect him. He’d never been waiting for that.

“I’ll go out to the Patersons tomorrow,” Miro said. “Check their bores. Stay a night.”

“Good.”

Helen's email arrived that evening.

Arthur — I called Caruso. He picked up on the second ring and talked for forty minutes. He has documentation going back three years. Community submissions dismissed, environmental assessments overridden, pastoral families who sold under pressure and families who held out and lost their water or their access roads. Three states. Fourteen families he's tracked. He nearly cried when I told him about June's notebook.

He's sending me everything. I'm sending him everything. Karen Lowe is now in a three-way email chain with a Monash researcher who can provide the pattern evidence her restraining order needs and the independent sourcing Rachel Tan's editor requires.

This is the door, Arthur. It won't open tomorrow. But it will open.

I'm hitting walls here too. The media contacts I tried in DC — nothing yet. The story needs the Australian angle to lead, not the US angle. Caruso and Tan are the key. Let me work this end. You hold the ground there.

I love you. Tell Miro I said he's a good man.

—H

Arthur showed the email to Miro. Miro read it and handed the laptop back.

"She says you're a good man."

"She says a lot of things." Miro stood up. "You told her about the bore?"

"I will."

"Tell her about the vehicle too. Caruso will want to know it's still happening. Current. Not historical."

Arthur looked at him. Miro was thinking in evidence now — what was admissible, what was current, what built a case. The partnership had done more than change his title. It had given him a stake in the outcome, and a stake changed how a man thought about every piece of information that crossed his path.

"I'll tell her," Arthur said.

Miro went inside. His door closed down the hall. Arthur sat on the verandah with Lucky at his feet and the guns by the door and the night pressing in. The wall was real. The institutions wouldn't move fast enough to protect anyone in the near term. But Helen had found a door, or Caruso had, or the two of them together had, and somewhere in Melbourne the man who'd been tracking Meridian for three years was sending files to a woman in Bethesda who would send them to a lawyer in Alice Springs who would send them to a journalist down the street.

The machinery was slow. The threat was fast. And somewhere between the two, Arthur and Miro and Rennie and the families on the route would have to hold the ground with what they had — each other, the guns, the work, the stubborn refusal to leave.

He closed the laptop and went inside and locked the door and checked the windows and went to bed with the rifle against the wall and Lucky on the floor and the silence of the station around him. Not the silence before. The silence during.

Chapter 16 — Night

Lucky woke him.

Not a bark. A growl — low and steady from the hallway floor, the sound a dog makes when something is wrong and he knows it before you do. Arthur's eyes opened to darkness and the growl and the shape of Lucky in the doorway, head up, ears forward, body rigid.

Arthur lay still. His hand found the rifle against the wall beside the bed. He listened. The house was silent except for Lucky and the tick of the tin roof cooling and, underneath both of those, something else. A sound he couldn't place. A pressure in the air, the way a room changes when someone is near it who shouldn't be.

He swung his legs off the bed. The floor was cold under his bare feet. He moved to the doorway and touched Lucky's head once — the dog's muscles were wire — and then crossed the hallway to Miro's door. One knock, soft. He heard the creak of Miro's bed, the pad of feet, and then Miro was there in the dark, already awake, already reading it.

"Lucky," Arthur whispered.

Miro nodded. He was a shape in the hallway, nothing more. Arthur pointed toward the front door. Miro went back into his room and came out with the bolt-action from beside his bed.

Arthur moved down the hallway with the rifle. The front room was dark. The windows were pale squares of starlight. The front door was closed. The screen door beyond it was closed.

Lucky was beside him now, pressed against his leg, still growling.

Then the screen door moved.

A faint sound — metal on metal, the new hinge Arthur had bolted on two days ago. The hinge was tight and the tightness made it squeak, a thin high note that lasted less than a second. Someone was pulling the screen door open from outside. Slowly. Testing the weight of it.

Arthur raised the rifle and moved to the wall beside the front door and waited. His ribs ached from the pub fight. His heart was loud in his ears.

Lucky had stopped growling and was crouched low, watching the door, every line of his body pointed at it.

The screen door opened fully. A pause. Then the inner door handle turned.

The door swung inward and a shape came through it — a man, crouched, moving fast but not fast enough. Arthur stepped forward to meet him but the man came from the hinge side, not straight on, and hit Arthur's arms before he could bring the barrel around. The rifle spun out of his grip and clattered across the floor into the dark. The man lunged for it and Arthur hit him — left hook to the side of the head, hard enough to change his mind about the rifle. The man staggered back against the doorframe and Arthur hit him again. Right to the jaw, then a body shot, the combinations Maya had drilled into him three nights a week for six years. But it was dark and the man was bigger than Arthur expected and the body shot landed on an arm instead of ribs and the man grabbed Arthur's shirt and pulled him off balance and they went into the wall together.

Lucky hit the man's legs. Not a trained attack — a dog lunging and snapping at what was nearest, snarling in the dark, teeth finding cloth and maybe skin. The man kicked and Lucky yelped and came back and bit again, lower, at the ankle, and the man's balance shifted and Arthur drove a knee into his thigh and got a hand behind his head and slammed it forward into the doorframe.

The man's hand came up with something in it. Arthur felt it before he saw it — the shape, the weight of it against his forearm as he grappled. A handgun. Small, compact. The man was trying to bring it around between them and Arthur grabbed the wrist and twisted and they fought for it in the dark, pressed together in the doorway, Lucky still at the man's legs.

The gun went off.

The sound was enormous. A white flash and a crack that filled the hallway and left a ringing in Arthur's skull that erased every other sound. He felt a line of heat across his left side — a bright, thin burning below his ribs, like someone had drawn a hot wire across his skin — and behind him something splintered. The doorframe. The bullet had grazed him and buried itself in the wood.

The flash blinded both of them. Arthur couldn't see but he could feel — the man's wrist in his grip, the gun still in the man's hand. He twisted the wrist hard, the way Maya taught, rotating against the joint until something gave, and the man screamed and the gun clattered to the floor and Arthur hit him twice more in the dark, short punches, and the man went down.

"Don't move." Miro's voice from the hallway. Flat, unhurried. Arthur blinked and his vision came back in pieces — the hallway, the door, the man on the floor, and Miro three meters away with the rifle shouldered and the barrel pointed at the man's chest.

Arthur stepped back. His ears were ringing. His left side was wet and hot. Lucky was between him and the man on the floor, hackles up, teeth bared, a continuous growl coming from deep in his chest.

The man was on his back. White. Mid-thirties, maybe forty. Dark clothing, dark shoes, no dust on them. He was holding his wrist against his body and breathing hard and his eyes were moving between the rifle and the dog and Arthur.

Miro looked at him. The rifle didn't waver.

"You're the one from the eastern fence," Miro said.

The man's face changed. A small thing — a tightening around the eyes, the recognition that he'd been identified not from tonight but from weeks ago, from the air, from the plane that had buzzed him while he sat in scrub three kilometers inside the boundary. He'd been known before he started.

Arthur picked up the handgun from the floor and cleared it — magazine out, chamber checked, safety on. His hands were doing it automatically while his mind caught up with what had happened. He set the gun on the hall table. Miro covered the man. Lucky stayed exactly where he was.

"Get up," Arthur said. "Slowly. Hands where I can see them."

The man got up. He was favoring his right wrist and his left ankle where Lucky had connected. Arthur walked him to the verandah and sat him down against the wall and went inside and found a length of fencing wire and came back and secured his wrists behind his back. Not elegant. Functional. The man didn't resist.

Arthur stood on the verandah and looked out at the yard. Starlight. The machinery shed was a dark shape against the sky. The track stretched away into nothing. Somewhere out there — a kilometer, maybe two — there would be a vehicle parked off the track with the lights off.

“Where’s your car?” he asked.

The man didn’t answer.

“Rennie will find it in the morning,” Miro said from the doorway. “He’s not going anywhere.”

Arthur went inside and found the sat phone and called Rennie’s mobile. It rang four times.

“Rennie.”

“Dave, it’s Arthur. We’ve got a man at the homestead. He broke in. There was a fight. A gun went off.”

Silence. Then: “Anyone hurt?”

“Grazed. I’m fine. The man’s restrained on the verandah. He’s the one Miro spotted from the Cessna — eastern fence, two weeks ago.”

“Armed?”

“Handgun. I’ve cleared it. It’s inside.”

“I’ll send Tommy. He’s on patrol near the eastern boundary tonight — forty minutes, maybe less. I’ll call Alice first thing. Don’t touch anything you don’t have to.”

“Understood.”

Arthur hung up and stood in the kitchen in the dark. The sat phone was heavy in his hand. The ringing in his ears had faded to a thin high whine. His left side burned. He looked down and saw the shirt was dark with blood — not soaked, but wet, a stripe of it across the lower ribs. He pulled the shirt up. A furrow in the skin, shallow, maybe fifteen centimeters long. The bullet had passed across him and kept going. An inch to the right and it would have broken a rib. Two inches and it would have been inside him.

He let the shirt drop and went back to the verandah.

Miro had brought a chair over and was sitting with the rifle across his knees, watching the man against the wall. Lucky had positioned himself between the man and the front door and hadn't moved. The night was cold — the desert cold that came after midnight and stayed until the sun hit the dirt — and the man against the wall was shivering.

"Tommy's coming," Arthur said. "Forty minutes."

Miro nodded. They waited.

Tommy Birch arrived in thirty-five. His headlights swept the yard and he got out of his ute and walked up to the verandah and looked at the man against the wall and at Arthur's bloody shirt and at the rifle on Miro's knees and said, "Christ."

"He's secured," Arthur said. "Fencing wire. Handgun's on the hall table — cleared. Rennie wants him in town."

Tommy loaded the man into the back seat of his ute. The man went without a word. He hadn't spoken since Miro's recognition on the hallway floor. Tommy drove away and the headlights shrank down the track and disappeared and the dark settled back over the yard.

Arthur sat down on the verandah step. The adrenaline was draining out of him and what it left behind was worse — a shaking in his hands that he couldn't stop, a looseness in his legs, a feeling in his chest that was too large for the ribs that contained it. He put his hands between his knees and pressed them together and breathed.

Miro set the rifle against the wall and went inside. Arthur heard the tap run and the kettle fill and the click of the burner. He sat on the step and shook and Lucky came and put his head on Arthur's thigh and Arthur put one trembling hand on the dog's neck and held it there.

Miro came back with a basin of warm water and a clean cloth and the first aid kit from the bathroom. He sat beside Arthur on the step and said, "Remove your shirt."

Arthur pulled the shirt over his head. The graze was a shallow trough across his lower left ribs — raw, still bleeding sluggishly, the edges of the skin white and pulled apart. Miro cleaned it with the cloth. The warm water stung and Arthur hissed through his teeth. Miro didn't comment. He dried the wound and pressed a gauze pad over it and taped it down with medical tape from the kit, three strips, firm and even.

"Doesn't need stitches," Miro said.

"Good."

Miro looked at Arthur's hands. They were still shaking. He looked at the bruise along Arthur's left ribs — the older bruise from the pub fight, yellow-green now, with the fresh graze cutting across it like a new line on a map.

He went inside and came back with two mugs. Tea. Strong, with sugar. He put one in Arthur's hands and sat down with the other and they drank in silence while the stars turned overhead and the cold pressed in around them.

Arthur looked at the doorframe. The bullet hole was at chest height — a ragged puncture in the wood, the raw timber showing pale against the weathered surface. It would be there tomorrow and next week and next year. Every time he walked through that door he'd see it.

"He came straight for the house," Miro said.

"Recon. Wanted to know how soft we were at night."

"Now he knows."

Arthur drank his tea. The shaking in his hands had slowed. Lucky was lying at the base of the step with his nose on his paws, eyes open, watching the yard. The growl was gone but the alertness wasn't. He wouldn't sleep again tonight. Neither would they.

"The vehicles are fine," Miro said. "I checked while you were on the phone. Land Cruiser, supply truck, both untouched. HF is working. He didn't get to any of it."

"He came for the house first."

“Bad decision.” Miro drank. “Both trucks are sitting in the yard. He walked past them to try the house. Should have cut a fuel line and gone home. Coming through a door at night when you don’t know who’s awake — that’s someone who was told to test and decided to go further.”

Arthur thought about that. An operative who exceeded his brief. Who came to check the defenses and decided to push through the door. The gun was insurance — he hadn’t planned to use it. But when Arthur met him in the dark, the plan evaporated and the gun came out and now a man was in the back of Tommy Birch’s ute with a broken wrist and a dog bite and Rennie had “shots fired” for his superintendent.

“They’ll send more,” Arthur said.

“They’ll send different.” Miro set his mug down. “This one was alone. Next time it won’t be one.”

The sky was beginning to lighten in the east. A thin line of gray along the horizon, then pink, then the first edge of gold. The yard emerged from the dark in stages — the shed, the water tank, the windmill, the track. The homestead behind them solid and quiet with a bullet hole in the doorframe and blood on the hallway floor.

Arthur went inside and opened his laptop and sat at the kitchen table and wrote to Helen.

Hel — A man broke into the homestead tonight. Around 2 AM. Lucky alerted us. There was a fight in the hallway — the man had a gun and it went off. I’m fine. A graze along the ribs, nothing serious. Miro bandaged it. We restrained him and Tommy Birch took him to Rennie in Mulga Creek.

Miro recognized him — the one he spotted from the Cessna two weeks ago, parked in scrub inside the eastern fence. He’s been in the district the whole time.

Second arrest in two weeks. Armed intruder, shots fired. Rennie is calling his superintendent at first light. The “civil matter” line won’t hold after this.

The man came straight for the house. Didn’t touch the vehicles or the radio. He wanted to know how soft we were. He found out. But Miro’s right — next time they won’t send just one.

If you can't reach me by HF or sat phone for more than 12 hours, call Rennie and Lowe both. Immediately. The comms are fine now but they're a vulnerability and I want you to have that protocol in your head.

Lucky was extraordinary. Woke me with a growl, stayed in the fight, bit the man's ankle. He's sleeping at my feet now. I'm going to give him steak for breakfast.

I'm tired, Hel. Not the kind that sleep fixes.

—A

He closed the laptop and sat in the kitchen with the first light coming through the window and the smell of tea and the sound of Miro moving on the verandah and Lucky breathing on the floor beside him. His side burned under the bandage. His hands had stopped shaking. Outside, the day was starting — the birds first, then the light, then the heat. The station didn't care what had happened in the night. The bores still needed checking. The cattle still needed water. The fences still needed riding.

He stood up and went out to the verandah where Miro was leaning against the rail with his mug, watching the sun come up over the eastern paddocks.

"I'll do the morning checks," Arthur said.

Miro looked at him. Looked at the bandage showing through the shirt. Looked at his face.

"We'll both do them," Miro said.

They went down the steps together, Lucky between them, into the yard and the light and whatever was coming next.

Chapter 17 — Converge

Helen's email arrived on a Monday.

Arthur — It's happening. Rachel Tan called Lowe this morning. Caruso's documentation checked out — her editor greenlighted the story. National angle, three states, fourteen families. She's filing Friday. Four days.

Lowe is filing supplementary evidence with the magistrate Wednesday, built on Caruso's research. The restraining order should move fast once the story airs. The FOI won't matter by then — the Department of Mines will be answering questions from journalists, not from us.

Four days. Hold the ground.

—H

Arthur read it twice and walked out to the verandah where Miro was drinking tea and watching the first light on the eastern paddocks. The bullet hole in the doorframe was at chest height, the raw timber already darkening at the edges. He handed Miro the laptop.

Miro read it. He set the laptop on the rail and looked out at the country and drank his tea and didn't say anything for a while.

"Four days," Arthur said.

"Yep."

"When the story breaks, they either pull back or come hard. If they come, it'll be in the window before the pressure hits — a day, maybe two."

Miro nodded. "We should get everyone in."

"That's what I was thinking."

They made the calls after breakfast. Arthur on the HF to the Warners and the Patersons. Miro on the sat phone to Rennie. Arthur called Lowe in Alice Springs.

"Can you come to the station?" he asked. "Tomorrow. We're bringing everyone together to plan. You should see the place you've been filing motions about."

A pause. "I'll leave at seven. I'll be there by ten."

"Bring whatever you need to work from Mulga Creek for a few days after. Keith Crowley's got a back room at the shop. It's not Bath Street but it's got power and phone reception."

"I've worked in worse." Another pause. "Arthur, are you expecting trouble when the story runs?"

"Yes."

"Then I'll bring my files."

They came throughout the morning, one vehicle at a time, dust rising on the track long before the engines were audible. The Warners first — Matt's ute with Sarah beside him, Sam and Lily in the back seat with a cooler bag and a pillow. Matt parked in the shade of the machinery shed and the kids spilled out and Lucky was on them before their feet hit the dirt, tail going, nose in Lily's hands. She crouched down and wrapped her arms around his neck and he stood there and let her.

Don and June Paterson arrived twenty minutes later. Don's ute, clean for once. June climbed out carrying a baking dish covered in foil. She looked at the homestead, at the bullet hole in the doorframe that nobody had mentioned on the HF, and her mouth tightened and she carried the dish inside without comment.

Reg came in his old truck — the same truck that had been parked at his stone house every time Arthur visited. Reg climbed out slowly, joints stiff from the long drive, and stood in the yard and looked around. The last time he'd been here was Ted's funeral. He looked at the verandah and at Ted's chair and then he looked away and walked over to where Matt was unloading the cooler.

Rennie arrived in the police vehicle and parked it facing the track — habit, Arthur thought, or readiness. He got out and nodded to Arthur and shook Don's hand and said something to Matt that made him almost smile.

Lowe was last. A white hatchback that looked wrong on the red dirt, city tires, a briefcase on the passenger seat. She got out and stood in the yard

and turned in a slow circle, taking in the homestead, the shed, the water tank with the windmill, the paddocks stretching away to the horizon in every direction. The scale of it. She'd been reading about pastoral leases and exploration permits and corporate shell structures, and now she was standing in the middle of what all those words actually meant.

"It's bigger than I thought," she said.

"It's bigger than anyone thinks," Miro said, "until they're standing on it."

They cooked. Miro had started a beef stew at dawn — station beef, potatoes, onions, the kind of meal that fed ten as easily as two. Arthur made damper from the recipe Ted had written on a card tacked to the kitchen wall. June's baking dish turned out to be a lemon slice. Sarah brought salads. They set up on the verandah — chairs pulled from inside, the kitchen table dragged out, plates and mugs and a pot of tea big enough to swim in. Eleven people on a verandah built for four.

The noise was extraordinary. Arthur stood at the rail and listened to it — Matt and Don arguing about bore pumps, June and Sarah comparing seed catalogs, Rennie telling Reg something about a truck that had rolled on the Stuart Highway, Lowe asking Miro about the Cessna. Sam was throwing a tennis ball in the yard and Lucky was retrieving it with the furious dedication of a dog who has finally found his calling. Lily sat on the verandah step and ate lemon slice and watched the ball and the dog and the red dirt and the sky.

Arthur looked at these people on his verandah — their verandah, the station's verandah — and felt something he couldn't name and didn't try to. The last time he'd been in a room with this many people who knew his name, he'd been sitting in a government conference room in Washington explaining why he'd filed a whistleblower complaint, and every face at the table had been looking at him the way you look at a man who's already gone.

This was different.

Miro caught his eye from across the table and gave him a nod so small nobody else would have seen it. Arthur nodded back.

After lunch they sent the kids to the yard. Sam took the tennis ball and Lucky followed him and Lily followed Lucky and the three of them disappeared around the side of the shed, their voices carrying in the still air.

The adults settled. Chairs arranged in a rough circle on the verandah. The tea was refilled. The mood shifted — not abruptly, but unmistakably. Everyone knew why they were here.

Arthur stood by the rail. He didn't plan to stand — it happened because the words needed to come from somewhere and sitting felt wrong.

"Friday," he said. "Four days from now, ABC runs a story on Meridian Resources. National scope — their operations here, in the Pilbara, in Queensland. Three states, fourteen families. A researcher at Monash University has been building the case for three years. Our evidence — June's notebook, the arrests, the photos, the corporate chain — connects to his. It's not an outback story anymore. It's a national one."

He looked at them. Matt leaning forward, elbows on knees. Sarah upright beside him, her hands in her lap. Don with his arms crossed, his weathered face giving nothing away. June with a pen in her hand — even now, she was the one who wrote things down. Reg in a chair by the wall, still, watching. Rennie with his hat off, turning it slowly in his hands. Lowe at the end of the row, briefcase open at her feet.

"When that story airs, Meridian's position here becomes untenable. The media pressure, the legal filings, the pattern evidence — they can't operate in the dark anymore. But." He paused. "Between now and when that pressure takes hold, there's a window. A day, maybe two. They'll know the story is coming — companies like this always know. And in that window, they'll either pull back or escalate."

"You think they'll escalate," Don said.

"I know they will. Three of their people have been arrested and charged — two are already back out on bail. Their operation is exposed. The playbook I've seen — in Washington, in the reports Caruso documented — is that they push hardest right before the door closes. One last attempt to make the problem go away before it becomes public."

Silence on the verandah. The sound of Sam's voice from behind the shed, calling to Lucky. The windmill creaking.

"What do we do?" Matt said.

Lowe spoke. She opened a folder on her lap. "Legally, the supplementary evidence goes to the magistrate tomorrow. With Caruso's documentation, the restraining order has a strong basis. Once the story airs, I expect the magistrate to act within twenty-four hours. I'm also filing a formal complaint with the Territory police commissioner — three arrests, an armed break-in, shots fired, sabotage of pastoral infrastructure. This is no longer something that can be characterized as a civil matter."

Rennie cleared his throat. "My superintendent agrees. Shots fired changed the conversation. I've got authorization to coordinate directly with Alice Springs and two extra officers on call when I request them. When the story runs, I'll have them deployed — patrolling the roads and sitting on your properties. Your homes," he said, looking at Matt, then Don. "Not just the roads. We know they've targeted infrastructure and I'm not leaving your houses empty."

"That's after the story," Arthur said. "Before the story, and in the window right after, we need to be together. One location, not scattered across two hundred kilometers. I'm asking everyone to come here — to the homestead — the day before the story runs. Thursday. Bring what you need for a few days. We defend one position, not four."

"Defend," Sarah said. The word sat in the air.

"Armed people have come onto this station twice," Arthur said. "They sabotaged your bore. They photographed your children. The man who broke in here had a gun. Yes. Defend."

Matt looked at Sarah. Something passed between them — not disagreement, but the weight of it registering. She gave a small nod.

"We'll be here Thursday," Matt said.

Don looked at June. June looked at her notebook. "We'll be here," she said. "I'll bring the copy of the log and the photographs Don's been taking. If anyone needs current evidence of ongoing surveillance, we've got it."

Arthur looked at Reg. The old man hadn't spoken. He was sitting in his chair by the wall — not Ted's chair, a different one, pulled from inside — and his face was the same weathered stone it always was.

"Reg?"

"I'm already here," Reg said. "I'll stay."

Arthur laid out the shape of it. Not a military briefing — he didn't have the training and these weren't soldiers. An organizational plan. The thing his mind did best.

"The homestead is the center. Everyone here, vehicles inside the yard perimeter. HF and sat phone both active — redundant communications. If one goes down, we've still got the other. The Cessna is fueled and on the strip — Miro can be in the air in ten minutes for observation if we need eyes."

"What about approaches?" Reg said. His voice was quiet but it carried. Everyone turned to him. "There's three ways in by vehicle. The main track from the north — that's the road to town. The eastern track that runs past the Warners' boundary. And there's an old stock route from the south that comes up through the creek bed. Nobody uses it anymore but it's still passable in a four-wheel drive."

Arthur hadn't known about the southern route. He looked at Miro.

"He's right," Miro said. "Hasn't been graded in ten years but the creek bed's solid. You could bring a vehicle up through there and be at the homestead in twenty minutes without being seen from the track."

"Then we watch all three," Arthur said. "And we block what we can."

"What are we blocking with?" Don asked. Practical as always.

"What we've got. Vehicles, equipment, whatever's in the shed. We're not building a wall — we're making it hard to drive up fast. Slow them down, give us time to see them coming."

Reg stood up. Slowly, with effort — but once he was up he was steady. "Show me the yard," he said.

They walked the homestead — all of them, spreading out across the yard and the ground beyond it. Reg moved slowly but his eyes moved fast. He pointed at the southern tree line. “You can see headlights from there to here at night. Long before they’re close. Put someone on the roof with binoculars and you’ve got ten minutes’ warning from any direction except the creek.”

“The fuel drums,” Miro said. He was standing by the machinery shed, looking at the four 200-litre drums lined against the wall. “We move two of them out into the yard. Here” — he pointed to a spot fifteen meters from the verandah, where the track widened into the open ground — “and here.” A second spot, angled toward the eastern approach. “Anyone coming on foot from a vehicle is going to want cover. The drums look like cover.”

Don looked at the drums and then at Miro and understanding crossed his face. “But they’re not.”

“A rifle round through a full drum,” Miro said. “Anyone behind it isn’t staying there.”

“That’s not exactly in the police handbook,” Rennie said.

“Send me a copy of that handbook,” Miro said. “I’ll read it first chance I get.”

Rennie grinned. He couldn’t help it.

They worked through the afternoon. Matt and Don moved the Land Cruiser to block the main track entrance to the yard — angled across the approach, heavy enough to stop anything short of a truck at speed. They dragged hay bales from the shed and stacked them along the verandah flanks — not bulletproof, but concealment and some absorption. The two fuel drums were rolled into position in the open ground, placed where Miro indicated, looking like station clutter to anyone who didn’t know better.

Reg directed. He stood in the middle of the yard with his hat pushed back and pointed and the younger men moved things where he said. He knew where the ground dipped, where water collected after rain, where the soil was soft and where it was hard-packed enough to support weight. Forty years of watching this piece of earth, and now that knowledge had a use he’d never imagined.

June set up a communications schedule — check-in times, frequencies, who calls whom and when. She wrote it on a single sheet of paper in her neat hand and made copies for everyone. Lowe took one and folded it into her briefcase.

“I’ll be at Crowley’s,” Lowe said. “Back room. I’ve got phone and laptop. When the story runs, I’ll be in contact with Tan in Alice, Caruso in Melbourne, and Helen in Washington. If anything happens here — anything — someone calls me and I start making noise.”

“Keith will look after you,” Rennie said. “Nobody’s getting past Keith Crowley without an argument.”

Sarah had been quiet through most of the planning. She sat on the verandah step and watched the men move equipment and listened to the communications schedule and when there was a pause she said, “The children.”

Everyone stopped.

“Lily and Sam can’t be here for this,” she said. Her voice was steady. “I need to know they’re safe before I can be useful.”

“My sister’s in Alice,” Matt said. “She’ll take them.”

“When?” Sarah asked.

Arthur looked at Lowe. “How much notice will we have before the story airs?”

“Tan will give me twenty-four hours. Maybe forty-eight.”

“Then the kids go to Alice the day before. Whoever drives them comes straight back.”

“I’ll take them,” Matt said.

“No.” Sarah’s voice was flat. “I’ll take them. I’ll be faster coming back because I won’t stop to talk to my sister.”

Matt looked at her. Whatever he saw made him nod.

Miro had been leaning against the verandah post through this exchange. He straightened up and looked at the group — at Matt and Sarah and Don and

June and Reg and Rennie and Lowe and Arthur — and the verandah was quiet and the afternoon light was long across the yard and the barricades cast shadows on the red dirt.

“We need to talk about what happens if someone gets killed,” Miro said.

The silence was immediate and complete. Not the comfortable silence of people who know each other well. A harder silence. The kind that comes when someone says the thing you’ve all been thinking and nobody wanted to voice.

Miro didn’t look away from any of them. His face held its usual composure, but his voice carried a weight Arthur had never heard in it.

“These people have guns. We have guns. We’re talking about blocking approaches and positioning fuel drums and watching through the night. That’s not a game. Someone could die.” He paused. “If you’re not willing to face that, you should go home now and nobody will think less of you. But if you’re staying, you need to know what you’re staying for.”

Nobody moved. Nobody spoke. The sound of Sam’s voice came faintly from behind the shed, calling to Lucky, and the ordinariness of it made Miro’s words land harder.

Don spoke first. “We know.”

June put her hand on Don’s arm. Matt reached for Sarah’s hand and she took it. Reg, in his chair by the wall, looked at Miro and gave a single nod that carried the weight of everything he’d already buried — his brother, his wife, most of the life he’d expected to live — and he was still sitting in that chair.

June was the first to move. “I’ll bring our first aid kit. The big one — the one we keep for the shearing shed. Bandages, tourniquets, saline, the lot.” She looked at Sarah. “You’ve done the remote first aid course?”

“Two years ago. I can handle bleeding and stabilize a break.”

“Kitchen table,” Miro said. “Clear line to the bathroom for water. We’ll have clean towels and the station kit as well.”

Rennie nodded. "I'll have the Alice ambulance service on standby when I call in my officers. If it goes bad, they can have a chopper here in under an hour."

Nobody said anything else about it. They didn't need to. The room they'd been sitting in for lunch was now a triage station in waiting, and everyone understood that without it being spelled out.

Rennie stood up. He put his hat on and adjusted it and said, "Right. I'll have my officers on the roads by Thursday. Lowe, I'll coordinate with you from town. Arthur, anything changes before then, you call me. Not the HF — the sat phone. Direct."

He shook Arthur's hand and walked to his vehicle and drove away. The dust settled on the track.

They left in the late afternoon, one at a time, the way they'd come. The Warners first — Sam and Lily loaded into the back seat, tired and sun-browned, Lucky watching them go from the verandah step. Lily waved through the rear window until the ute was too far to see.

The Patersons next. Don shook Arthur's hand with both of his. June gave Miro the remaining lemon slice wrapped in foil and said, "Thursday," and they drove away.

Lowe stood by her hatchback with the briefcase and looked at the homestead one more time — the barricades, the fuel drums, the bullet hole in the doorframe, the hay bales along the verandah.

"I've filed a lot of motions," she said. "This is the first time I've seen what they're actually about."

She got in and drove south toward Alice Springs. The white hatchback shrank on the track until the dust swallowed it.

Reg didn't leave. He'd brought a bag from his truck at some point during the afternoon — Arthur hadn't seen him do it — and put it in the spare room without asking. His rifle, the old one with the wooden stock and the scratched scope, was leaning against the wall by the front door next to the others.

Arthur and Miro and Reg sat on the verandah in the last of the light. Three men, three rifles against the wall, Lucky at Arthur's feet. The yard was rearranged — the Land Cruiser across the track entrance, the hay bales along the flanks, the fuel drums sitting in the open ground like they'd always been there. The homestead looked different. Not a fortress. A place that had been prepared by people who intended to stay.

The bullet hole caught the last light, the pale timber glowing for a moment before the shadow took it.

"Ted would have liked today," Reg said. It was the first thing he'd said in an hour.

Miro looked at him. "He would have done the cooking and complained about everyone's parking."

Reg almost smiled. "That's about right."

The dark came in from the east, the way it always did, fast and complete. The stars appeared. The windmill creaked. Lucky sighed and put his head on his paws.

Four days.

Chapter 18 — Stand

They were in position before the stars faded.

Arthur on the verandah, rifle across his knees. Miro beside him with the bolt-action, the barrel resting on the rail. Don Paterson behind the hay bales on the left flank, his .243 oiled and loaded. Matt Warner on the right, prone behind a second stack of bales, watching the eastern track. Reg on the roof with his old rifle and the binoculars, lying flat on the corrugated iron in the cold. Inside, June at the HF and sat phone with the communications schedule pinned to the wall above her, and Sarah at the kitchen table with the first aid kits — June's shearing shed kit and the station one, laid out in order, towels stacked, water boiled.

Lucky lay at Arthur's feet on the verandah boards. Alert, ears forward, nose working. He hadn't settled all night.

The families had come in Thursday as planned. Sarah had driven Sam and Lily to Alice Springs the day before and come straight back, nearly three hours each way, arriving at dusk with empty car seats and a face that didn't want to talk about it. Matt had met her in the yard and held her and neither of them said anything. By morning they were both steady.

Lowe was at Crowley's in Mulga Creek — back room, laptop, phone. Rennie was in town with his two extra officers, patrol cars on the roads. Everyone was where they were supposed to be.

Now they waited.

The cold was the worst part. Pre-dawn in the desert, the heat of the day a memory the earth had already forgotten. Arthur's fingers were stiff on the rifle stock. The bandage on his ribs pulled when he shifted — the graze had scabbed over but the skin was tight and the cold made it ache. Beside him, Miro sat motionless. He could have been part of the verandah.

The sky lightened in the east. Gray, then pink, then a thin line of gold along the horizon. The yard emerged — the Land Cruiser across the track entrance, the hay bales, the two fuel drums sitting in the open ground. The machinery shed. The windmill. The track stretching north into nothing.

Reg's voice came down from the roof. Quiet, steady, carrying in the still air.

“Dust on the north track.”

Arthur’s hand tightened on the rifle. Miro didn’t move.

A pause. Five seconds. Ten.

“Two more. East.”

Another pause. Longer this time.

“Movement in the creek bed. Two on foot. Coming up from the south.”

Three directions. Six men. They’d studied the recon photos, planned the approaches. What they didn’t know about was the old man on the roof who’d watched this land for forty years, or the fuel drums that looked like cover but weren’t, or the people inside who had decided that nobody else was going to protect them.

“How far?” Arthur called up.

“North vehicle’s a kilometer out. Eastern, maybe eight hundred meters. Creek pair are in the trees, four hundred.”

“They want to arrive together,” Miro said.

“The creek pair are ahead. They’ll hit us first.” Arthur looked at Matt. “Creek bed. Two coming up from the south.”

Matt nodded and moved — low, fast, off the verandah and along the side of the house toward the southern tree line. He moved low and fast through the scrub, reading the ground without thinking about it.

The north vehicle was visible now — a white four-wheel drive coming fast on the track, dust behind it. It reached the Land Cruiser barricade and braked hard, sliding sideways on the dirt. Two men got out before the dust settled. One sprinted for the nearest fuel drum — fifteen meters from the verandah, good cover, or so it looked. The other went wide into the scrub to the left.

The eastern vehicle appeared on the paddock track. Same speed. It stopped three hundred meters out and two men dropped from the passenger side and moved forward on foot, spread apart, working through the low scrub.

The first shot came from the man behind the fuel drum. It hit the verandah post a foot from Arthur's head and the splinter stung his cheek and the sound cracked across the yard and that was the end of the waiting.

Arthur fired back. The shot went wide — aiming at a shape behind a steel drum in the early light with cold hands and a hammering heart. Don was already shooting from the left flank, steady, measured, the .243 cracking at intervals. Don had shot feral pigs from moving vehicles for thirty years. He didn't rush.

The man behind the drum fired again. Two rounds, fast. One hit the hay bales on the left flank. The second punched through the timber wall of the house.

Inside, June made a sound — not a scream, a sharp intake of breath, then the clatter of the sat phone hitting the floor.

"June!" Sarah's voice.

Arthur heard Sarah moving, heard June say, "Shoulder. Left shoulder —" and then Sarah was on her and the words stopped and Arthur kept his eyes on the yard because there were five more men out there and the fight wasn't finished.

Don heard it too. His face changed — something went out of it and something harder came in — and he put his eye back to the scope and kept firing. He didn't go inside. He would go inside when it was over and not one second before.

The man in the scrub to the left was working toward the shed. Reg's voice from the roof, calm as weather: "One left, moving on the shed. Thirty meters."

Arthur swung the rifle and fired twice. The man went flat in the dirt. Not hit, but stopped.

From the roof, Reg's old rifle cracked. Then again. Slow, deliberate — Reg hadn't fired in years and was remembering how. The rounds hit close enough to the man in the scrub that he pressed himself into the earth and stayed there. Reg couldn't see him well from the roof angle, but he didn't need to. He needed to keep him down, and he did.

The eastern pair were closer — two hundred meters, moving through the paddock grass. Miro had been watching them with his usual patience — decades of reading movement across open ground. He fired once. The lead man stumbled and went down, hit in the leg. The second dropped into the grass and stayed there.

“Creek bed,” Reg called. “Matt’s engaged. One pinned down. Second one’s past him. Coming around the house, right side.”

Arthur turned. The right side — the blind angle from the verandah. The second creek bed operative had slipped past Matt and was coming around the corner of the homestead. Arthur couldn’t see him from where he stood.

Lucky could.

The dog was off the verandah before Arthur could speak. No bark — the same silent launch that had carried him into the hallway fight, the same instinct that didn’t wait for permission. He hit the corner of the house at a sprint and disappeared around it.

A handgun fired. Close to the house, flat and sharp. Lucky yelped — a sound Arthur had never heard from him, high and bitten off — and Arthur was off the verandah and running.

He came around the corner and saw them. The operative was on his back in the red dirt, Lucky on him, jaws locked on the man’s forearm, snarling through the grip even as blood darkened his right hindquarter and the leg dragged behind him. The operative was trying to bring the handgun around with his free hand for a second shot.

Arthur didn’t slow down. He drove his knee into the man’s chest and stripped the gun from his hand and hit him twice and the man went slack. Three seconds. The operative’s head rolled sideways in the dirt. Arthur kicked the handgun away and turned to Lucky.

The dog had let go of the arm and was lying on his side, panting hard. The bullet had taken him in the right hindquarter — a dark hole in the muscle, blood matting the fur and soaking into the dirt beneath him. His back leg wasn’t moving. But his eyes were open and fixed on Arthur’s face and his tail moved once against the ground.

“Stay,” Arthur said. His voice cracked. “Stay right here, mate.”

He pulled off his overshirt and pressed it against the wound and Lucky whimpered and then was quiet. Arthur held the pressure and looked into the dog’s eyes and the dog looked back at him and the tail moved again.

From the front of the house, gunfire. Miro’s voice: “Arthur.”

“I’m here. One down. Lucky’s hit.”

A pause. Then Miro, flat and steady: “I need you on the verandah.”

Arthur looked at Lucky. The dog was panting but conscious, the overshirt pressed against the wound, the blood slowing under the pressure. Arthur put Lucky’s paw on the shirt — a useless gesture, an instinct — and said, “I’ll be right back,” and went around the corner with the operative’s handgun in his belt and blood on his hands.

The man behind the fuel drum was still firing. Round after round into the verandah, methodical, keeping their heads down while the man in the scrub tried to work forward to the shed. The hay bales were chewed up. Fresh bullet holes pocked the timber walls. A window had shattered.

Miro was at the rail. A round hit the wood a foot from his hands. He didn’t flinch. He was looking at the fuel drum the way he looked at the land when he was reading it — taking the measure, waiting.

“Now?” Arthur said.

Miro settled the bolt-action against his shoulder. He exhaled halfway and held it and the barrel was steady and he fired.

The round punched through the drum and the drum blew apart.

A ball of orange fire and black smoke and a concussive thump that Arthur felt in his ribs. The operative behind the drum was lifted off the ground and thrown sideways and the dirt burned in a circle three meters wide and the heat washed across the yard and reached the verandah and the air tasted of petrol and smoke.

The man didn’t get up.

The shooting stopped. The man in the scrub by the shed looked at the burning ground and the smoke and put his weapon down and put his hands on his head.

Sirens. From the north track — distant, then closing fast, lights flashing through the dust. Rennie's vehicle and two patrol cars.

"The vehicles!" Miro was on his feet, pointing at the operative vehicles — the white four-wheel drive jammed against the barricade, the other three hundred meters out on the eastern track. "Put rounds in the tanks!"

Rennie's vehicle slid to a halt behind the Land Cruiser. He was out with his weapon up, his officers fanning left and right. He took in the scene — the burning drum, the surrendering operative, the bullet-scarred verandah — and started shouting commands.

"Police! Weapons on the ground! Hands where I can see them!"

Rennie put two rounds into the fuel tank of the nearest operative vehicle. Diesel pooled in the dirt. An officer did the same to the eastern vehicle. No one was driving out.

The third vehicle — the creek bed four-wheel drive — an engine started somewhere beyond the southern tree line. Tires on gravel, accelerating away.

"One running," Reg called from the roof. His voice was hoarse. "South. Through the creek."

One of Rennie's officers sprinted for his patrol car and tore out of the yard after it, lights and siren fading into the distance.

Then it was quiet.

Not silent — the drum was still burning, and a bird was calling somewhere in the scrub, and the eastern operative with the leg wound was making a sound through his teeth. But the shooting had stopped and the smoke drifted across the yard in the still morning air and nobody was firing and nobody was running and it was over.

Arthur counted. The drum operative was down. The shed operative had surrendered. The eastern pair were being cuffed by Rennie's officers — one

wounded, one prone with his hands behind his head. The creek bed pair — one pinned by Matt in the tree line, one unconscious behind the house. The sixth had fled. Five accounted for.

“Clear,” Reg called from the roof. The word came out thin and cracked. He’d been on that iron for over two hours, calling positions while rounds hit the metal around him. Seventy-eight years old. He hadn’t moved from his post.

Arthur picked up the sat phone and called Helen. She answered before the first ring finished.

“It’s over,” Arthur said. “We’re all right. June Paterson took a round in the shoulder — she’s stable, Sarah’s with her. Lucky’s hit. I’m taking him to the vet. Five in custody, one ran. Rennie’s here. Miro’s fine. Reg is fine. Everybody’s standing.”

Helen was quiet. When she spoke her voice was held together with wire. “Lowe called me when Rennie called her. I’ve been sitting here for forty minutes knowing.”

“I’m sorry.”

“Don’t you dare be sorry.” A breath. “I need to go. I need to call Lowe and get things moving. The story runs tonight and right now I have a Monash researcher and an ABC journalist and a solicitor who all need to know what happened at this station this morning. Call me from Alice Springs.”

“I will.”

“Arthur.” A pause. “Tell Miro I love him too.”

The line went dead.

“June’s stable.” Sarah’s voice from the doorway, steady and professional, her hands dark with blood. “Through-and-through, left shoulder. I’ve packed and bound it. She needs a hospital but she’s not critical.”

Don set his rifle against the hay bales. He walked inside and Arthur heard him say June’s name — just the name, nothing after it — and the quiet that followed had the weight of thirty years of marriage in it.

Arthur went around the side of the house to Lucky.

The dog was where he'd left him, lying on the overshirt. Panting. The blood had soaked through the fabric and into the dirt. Sarah came out the back door with the first aid kit, already kneeling, already assessing.

"Let me see." She moved the shirt and looked at the wound. "Muscle damage. Didn't hit bone — if it had, the leg would be wrong. He needs a vet. Today."

Arthur knelt beside Lucky and put his hand on the dog's head. Lucky's eyes found his and the tail moved — slow, just the tip. Arthur's throat closed and his eyes burned and he didn't look away.

"You're a good dog," he said. "The best dog I've ever known. You hear me?"

Lucky's nose pushed against Arthur's palm. A small, deliberate movement. *I hear you.*

Sarah was already bandaging — gauze from the shearing shed kit wrapped firm around the hindquarter, tape to hold it. Lucky whimpered but didn't snap. He knew her hands.

Miro came around the corner. He looked at Lucky and at Arthur's face and he went to the shed and came back with a blanket. The three of them lifted Lucky onto it — carefully, Arthur supporting the wounded leg — and carried him to the supply truck and laid him on the passenger seat.

"Alice is three hours," Miro said.

"I know. Have Rennie call the vet's office and tell them to be ready when I get there. Under penalty of law."

Miro almost smiled. "I'll tell him."

Reg was coming down the ladder. One rung at a time, his joints locked from two hours on cold iron, each step deliberate. His old rifle was still on the roof. He reached the ground and stood in the yard and looked around at what had happened — the burned circle where the drum had been, the bullet holes in the verandah, the operatives being led to Rennie's vehicles, the smoke, the shell casings in the dirt.

Matt came in from the southern tree line. His rifle was over his shoulder and his shirt was torn and there was dirt on his face and he looked like he'd aged a decade since dawn. He saw Reg standing alone in the yard and walked to him and put his arms around him.

Reg went rigid. Arms at his sides, chin up. The way old station men stand when they don't know what to do with something that isn't work.

Sarah came next. She still had June's blood on her hands and she put her arms around both of them — Matt and Reg together — and pressed her face against Reg's shoulder.

Don came out of the house. His eyes were red and his jaw was set and he crossed the yard and put his hand on Reg's back and held it there.

Miro stood on the verandah. Arthur stood beside him. Twenty meters away Rennie was loading operatives into vehicles and the yard held both things at once — the law and the family — and they occupied the same ground without touching.

Reg's arms came up. Slowly. He put one around Matt and one around Sarah and his eyes closed and he stood in the middle of the yard where his brother had worked for twenty-five years and let these people hold him up.

Arthur watched from the verandah. Miro put a hand on his shoulder. Brief, firm. Then dropped it.

"Helen says she loves you too," Arthur said.

Miro looked at him. His face didn't change, but something behind it did. "Go," he said. "Take Lucky to the vet. We'll be here when you get back."

Arthur went down the steps and across the yard. He passed Reg and the others and Reg reached out and gripped his arm as he went by — one squeeze, hard enough to feel through the exhaustion and the fear and the relief, and then he let go.

Arthur got in the truck. Lucky was on the blanket on the passenger seat, his eyes open, his bandaged leg still. Arthur put his hand on the dog's neck and Lucky's tail moved and Arthur started the engine and drove out of the yard,

past the burned ground and the barricades and the spent brass glinting in the morning light.

The track stretched south. The sun was up and the sky was wide and blue and empty and he drove toward Alice Springs with his dog beside him and the station behind him, battered and holed and still there.

Standing.

Chapter 19 — Exposure

The vet's name was Calloway. He was already waiting when Arthur pulled up — a tall man in his fifties with steady hands and no wasted words, standing in the doorway of the clinic on Hartley Street with the lights on behind him.

"Rennie called," Calloway said, looking past Arthur to the truck. "Let's see him."

They carried Lucky in on the blanket. The dog was awake but still, his breathing shallow, the bandage on his hindquarter dark with dried blood. Calloway examined the wound in the surgery under the overhead lights, his fingers gentle and precise.

"Bullet's still in the muscle. Missed the bone — if it hadn't, the leg would be hanging wrong. I'll need to put him under and get it out." He looked at Arthur. "He's strong. Good weight, good heart rate for what he's been through. I've seen worse."

"How long?"

"Surgery's an hour. He'll need two or three after that to come around. Call it late afternoon."

Arthur looked at Lucky on the table. The dog's eyes were open, watching him. Arthur put his hand on Lucky's head and the ears moved under his palm.

"I'll be back," Arthur said.

He walked out into the morning. Alice Springs was ordinary — cars on the Stuart Highway, tourists outside the Todd Mall shops, a woman pushing a pram along the footpath. None of them knew what had happened three hundred kilometers north. He stood by the truck for a moment and let the ordinariness wash over him, and then he got in and drove to the hospital.

June was sitting up. Her left arm was in a sling and her face was pale and there was an IV line in her right hand, but she was sitting up. Don was in the chair beside the bed. He looked like he hadn't slept or changed his shirt

or done anything except sit in that chair since they'd brought her in. His hand was resting on the mattress near her IV line, not holding her hand, just near it.

"Arthur." June's voice was quieter than he'd expected. She had the same directness in her eyes — the notebook-keeper, the woman who wrote dates in the left margin — but the effort of holding herself upright was visible. "Did they get the one who shot me?"

"Five in custody. One ran."

She nodded. Absorbed that. "How's Lucky?"

"In surgery. The vet says he'll be fine."

"Good." She closed her eyes for a moment, then opened them. "The notebook. Is it safe?"

"The copy's at your place. The original's in Lowe's safe. Both secure."

Something in her face eased — not relief, exactly, but a settling. She needed to know that eight months of work hadn't been undone by a bullet through a wall.

"The story runs tonight," Arthur said. "ABC. National. Your notebook is the spine of it."

June looked at Don. Don looked at her. Whatever passed between them didn't need words — thirty years of marriage carried it.

"Good," June said.

Arthur didn't stay long. June was tiring and Don wasn't leaving and the room had the quiet density of two people who had nearly not made it to thirty-one years together. He shook Don's hand at the door and Don gripped it hard and didn't say anything and Arthur walked out.

Rachel Tan's bureau was on Todd Street, the same small office in the commercial building Arthur had visited weeks ago when every door was closing — Lowe stalled, the Department of Mines stonewalling, Tan herself

cautious and hemmed in by editorial lawyers. The same young man at the front desk, the same cluttered desks behind reception.

Tan was different. The caution was gone. She was moving between her desk and a printer and her phone with the focused energy of a journalist who had cleared every hurdle and was watching her story go live.

“Sit down,” she said, clearing a stack of papers from the spare chair. “You look terrible.”

“Long night.”

“I heard. Lowe called me at seven this morning.” She stopped moving and looked at him. “Six operatives. Armed assault on a cattle station. Arthur, do you understand what this does to the story?”

“Makes it harder to ignore.”

“Makes it impossible to ignore. My editor called me at eight. The segment’s been upgraded — lead national story, not buried in regional. The online piece runs simultaneously. Caruso is doing a phone interview from Melbourne for the evening broadcast.” She picked up a printout from her desk — several pages, stapled. “This is the pre-copy. Embargoed until it airs tonight. Lowe and Miro only.”

Arthur took it. The pages were warm from the printer.

“There’s something else,” Tan said. She sat down behind her desk. “Off the record.”

Arthur nodded.

“Meridian is repositioning. I’ve got sources inside two state mining departments — not official, obviously — and the word is that Meridian is pulling resources from here. From the Territory. The organized resistance, the legal filings, the media attention — it’s costing them more than the lease is worth.” She paused. “But they’re redirecting. The Pilbara families, the Queensland operations — communities that don’t have a Karen Lowe or a June Paterson or a Monash researcher building the file. Less organized. More vulnerable.”

The words landed. He'd known they would. The win was real. The problem was bigger than any single win.

"Can you cover them too?" Arthur asked.

"I'm trying. Caruso's got contacts in both regions. But it takes time to build what you've built here, and not every community has someone who —" She stopped herself. "You know what I mean."

Arthur knew.

She shook his hand at the door. "I'm glad your dog's all right," she said. "Lowe told me about that too."

He sat in the truck on a side street off Bath Street and read the story.

The headline: *The Quiet War: How a Mining Giant Squeezed Fourteen Families Off Their Land.*

It was precise. Tan had taken the threads — June's notebook, Caruso's three years of research, Lowe's corporate chain from Dryden to Eastmark to the offshore entities, Helen's traces, the arrests in Mulga Creek, the surveillance photos of children — and woven them into something that made the pattern undeniable. Three states. Fourteen families. Shell companies layered over shell companies. Government services withdrawn in areas where families resisted. Roads closed. Bores interfered with. And through it all, the same corporate structure, the same law firms, the same deniable operatives showing up wherever a pastoral lease stood between Meridian Resources and the ground beneath it.

His name wasn't in it. Source protection. But everything he'd seen — in Washington three years ago, in the compliance reports that went up the chain and came back diluted, in the bureaucrat's careful disinterest at the Department of Mines — was there on the page, confirmed by people who had never met him and arrived at the same conclusions independently.

He read it twice. Then he folded the pages and put them on the passenger seat and sat for a while with the windows down and the sound of Bath Street coming in — car doors, a radio from the café on the corner, someone laughing. He thought about June's notebook. The dates in the left margin,

the descriptions in the center column, the questions on the right. She had started writing it down because she knew. Eight months of careful observation by a woman with a garden and a drip system and a husband who'd farmed the same country for thirty years. That notebook was the spine of everything that followed.

He started the truck and drove to Lowe's office.

The converted house on Bath Street looked the same — squeezed between the real estate agent and the physiotherapist, the staircase narrow, the landing cluttered with file boxes. But Lowe's office had changed. The desk that had been neat and careful was covered with documents, folders open, sticky notes on the monitor, two phones charging. She looked like she'd been at full speed since dawn and had no plans to slow down.

"Arthur." She stood and shook his hand. "Restraining order was granted this morning. The magistrate moved inside an hour of receiving the supplementary filing — Caruso's documentation, the arrest records, the assault charges. Dryden, Eastmark, and all named agents are barred from contact with any pastoral leaseholder in the district."

"That fast."

"When six armed men assault a cattle station the day before a national news story, magistrates find their calendars suddenly clear." She pulled a folder from the desk. "Police commissioner has opened a formal investigation into Dryden and Eastmark's operations territory-wide. And this morning Helen called me."

Arthur waited.

"The FBI is reopening the US investigation. Diana Marsh — the agent Helen's been in contact with — apparently the Australian exposure gave them jurisdiction they didn't have before. Foreign operatives, cross-border corporate structure, documented coordination between Meridian's US and Australian operations. The bureau couldn't touch it when it was a domestic whistleblower complaint. Now it's international."

Arthur let that settle. Three years. Three years since he'd first flagged Meridian's overseas mining operation. Three years of compliance documents going up the chain and coming back neutered, until he'd gone to the Office of Special Counsel and the world had fallen on him. And now, because a woman in Central Australia started writing dates in the left margin of a blue notebook, the FBI had found a reason to look again.

"It'll take years," Lowe said. She said it the way she said most things — direct, no softening. "Meridian's US counsel will file to delay every step. The agency will resist cooperating. Deep pockets buy time, and time is what makes cases go away."

"I know."

"But the door is open. And it doesn't close once the story airs tonight."

Arthur looked at his watch. Two-thirty. Calloway had said late afternoon.

"Have you eaten?" he said.

Lowe looked at him as if the question had arrived from another continent. Then she glanced at her desk, at the folders and the phones and the sticky notes, and something in her face relaxed half a degree.

"No," she said. "I haven't."

They walked around the corner to a café Arthur hadn't noticed before — small, quiet in the mid-afternoon lull, four tables and a counter. A woman brought them sandwiches and coffee without fuss. They sat by the window and ate and the light came through the glass and it was the most ordinary thing Arthur had done in weeks.

They didn't talk about the case. Lowe asked about the station — what it looked like, how the country changed with the seasons, what the supply runs were like. Arthur told her about the first time Ted had driven him out to Reg's place, the stone house and the single tree and the old man standing in the bare yard waiting for them. Lowe listened with the same care she brought to documents — absorbing the specifics.

"You found something out there," she said.

"I wasn't looking for it."

“Those are the ones you keep.” She finished her coffee. “Thank you for lunch. I have about fourteen hours of work to do before the story airs.”

“Thank you for all of it.”

She waved that away — the same gesture Arthur had seen from Miro and Ted and Rennie when someone acknowledged what they’d done. The outback reflex. You did the work because it was there to do, and praise made you uncomfortable.

He walked her back to the office and drove to Calloway’s.

Lucky was awake. Groggy, his eyes not quite tracking, the bandage on his hindquarter fresh and white. But when Arthur came through the surgery door, the dog’s nose lifted and found him and the tail moved — slow, just the tip, weighted with sedation but deliberate.

“He did well,” Calloway said. “Bullet came out clean. Muscle will heal. He’ll favor the leg for a few weeks, then he’ll forget about it.” He paused. “He’s a tough dog.”

“He is.”

Arthur and Calloway carried him to the truck on the blanket and laid him on the passenger seat. Lucky’s eyes found Arthur’s face and stayed there while Arthur adjusted the blanket around him and put his hand on the dog’s neck. Lucky sighed — a deep, sedated exhalation that seemed to carry the weight of the last twenty-four hours — and closed his eyes.

Arthur got in and started the engine and pulled onto the Stuart Highway heading north. Three hours. The same road he’d driven this morning in the other direction, but everything was different now. The printout was on the dashboard. Lucky was beside him, breathing steadily, his bandaged leg still. The sun was dropping toward the MacDonnells and the light was turning gold on the ranges and the road stretched out ahead, straight and red and empty.

He drove home.

While Arthur was in Alice Springs, Miro flew the route.

He'd fueled the Cessna at first light and taken off from the strip while the barricades were still in place and the burn circle from the drum was still smoking in the morning chill. Reg was in the passenger seat — his bag on his lap, his old rifle between his knees, his face unreadable behind the scratched sunglasses he'd been wearing for thirty years.

They flew south over the station. From the air, Miro could see the homestead the way a stranger would — the bullet-scarred verandah, the black circle where the drum had been, the hay bales still stacked against the flanks, the Land Cruiser across the track entrance. Spent brass glinting in the yard. It looked like what it was.

Reg looked down and said nothing.

Miro banked east and followed the creek bed south — the route the last two operatives had used, the old stock route that hadn't been graded in ten years. From above, the tracks were visible in the sandy bed, fresh tire marks where the fleeing vehicle had torn through. Beyond the creek, the land opened into the red country and the sky was enormous and empty and Miro turned south-southeast toward Reg's place.

He landed on the dirt road a hundred meters from the stone house. The Cessna rolled to a stop and the prop wound down and the silence came in — the deep, complete silence of a place where nobody lived except one old man and the things he remembered.

Reg climbed out slowly. He stood in the red dirt and looked at his house — the stone walls, the single tree, the bare yard. He'd been away four days. It looked like he'd been away a lifetime.

He turned back to Miro, one hand on the wing strut.

"Ted would have enjoyed that," he said. "Not the shooting. The fixing."

Miro nodded. Ted the fixer. Ted who straightened fences and tinkered with bore pumps and sorted other people's problems because that was what he understood about himself — that he was useful, and being useful was enough.

“He would have,” Miro said.

Reg let go of the strut and walked to his front door. He didn’t look back. The screen door banged behind him and Miro sat in the cockpit and watched the house until he saw the kitchen light come on through the window, and then he started the engine and took off and flew northwest toward the Warners.

Matt’s place didn’t have a strip, but the dirt road that ran past the property was flat and straight for a quarter kilometer and Miro had landed there before. He brought the Cessna down neatly, the wheels kicking up a line of red dust, and taxied toward the house.

Sam and Lily were back from Alice Springs. They came running out before the prop stopped — Sam first, legs going, then Lily behind him with her hair flying and Captain the dog barking in circles around both of them. Miro climbed out and Lily grabbed his hand and Sam was already asking about the fight and Matt was coming across the yard with Sarah behind him, and for a few minutes the questions came faster than anyone could answer them.

Matt looked tired but steady. Sarah looked like she’d slept in her clothes and washed her face and decided that was enough. They were intact.

“Anyone want to go up?” Miro said.

Sam’s face split open. Lily’s eyes went wide. Matt hesitated for exactly one second, looked at Sarah, and Sarah said, “Go.”

Miro took them up — Sam in the front, Lily in the back, the Cessna climbing into the afternoon sky. He flew north over the station and the kids pressed their faces to the windows and the country unrolled beneath them — red earth, scrub, the long line of the creek bed, the glint of bore water in the eastern paddock. Miro circled once over the homestead and Sam went quiet. The burn circle. The bullet holes. The barricades. From the air it was both larger and smaller than the stories would make it.

Lily tapped Miro’s shoulder. “Is that where Lucky got hurt?”

“Around the side of the house. Near the back.”

She was quiet for a moment. “Is he going to be okay?”

“Arthur’s bringing him home tonight. He’s going to be fine.”

She sat back. Miro banked south and dropped altitude and flew low over the paddocks and the kids watched their world pass beneath them — the fences, the bores, the stock tracks, the country they’d grown up on — and Lily pressed her hand flat against the window as if she could touch it.

He landed on the dirt road and the kids spilled out talking and Matt was waiting and Miro said, “They’re good flyers,” and taxied back to the road and took off east toward the Patersons.

He didn’t stay long at Don and June’s place. Don was at the hospital. The house was closed up, the garden drip system running on its timer. Miro walked the property — checked the bores, checked the fences, checked the shed. Everything was where it should be. He left a note on the kitchen table: *Checked in. All good. Call if you need. — M.*

He flew home in the late light, the Cessna’s shadow racing him across the red ground, and landed on the strip as the sun hit the ranges.

Arthur arrived an hour after dark. Miro heard the truck on the track and came out with a torch and together they carried Lucky inside on the blanket and laid him on the floor beside Arthur’s bed. The dog was awake now, more alert, his eyes following the torchlight and the movement and the familiar smells of the homestead. Miro brought a bowl of water and set it near Lucky’s head and the dog drank in small, careful laps.

“Calloway got the bullet out clean,” Arthur said. “Full recovery. Few weeks on the leg.”

“Good.”

They went to the verandah. The night was warm and still and the stars were out and the smell of the burned ground had faded to something dry and acrid in the dark. Miro had made tea. They sat in their chairs — Arthur’s and Miro’s, the same ones they’d been sitting in since Ted died — and the quiet settled around them.

“How’s the route?” Arthur asked.

“Standing. Took Reg home. He’s all right. Took the Warner kids up for a fly — they needed it. Checked the Patersons’ place. All quiet.”

“June’s doing well. She asked about Lucky before she asked about herself.”

Miro smiled. “That sounds like June.”

Arthur pulled out the folded printout from his shirt pocket. “Tan gave me the pre-copy. It ran tonight — national lead.”

Miro took it and unfolded it and read it in the light from the kitchen window. Arthur watched him read. Miro’s face didn’t change — it rarely did — but his hands were still on the pages, and he read slowly, and when he finished he folded it and handed it back.

“Fourteen families,” Miro said.

“Fourteen they can document.”

Miro nodded. He looked out at the dark paddocks and the stars. “Call Helen?”

Arthur picked up the sat phone and dialed. Helen answered immediately.

“I’m putting you on speaker. Miro’s here.”

“Good. Hello, Miro.”

“Helen.”

“I watched it,” Helen said. “The online piece went up two hours ago. It’s already being picked up — Sydney Morning Herald, The Age, Guardian Australia. Caruso’s interview was strong. And Tan’s piece — Arthur, it’s good. It’s really good.”

“She’s a good journalist.”

“She had good material.” A pause. “I spoke to Diana Marsh this afternoon. Two hours on the phone. She’s been reassigned to the case — not a new assignment, officially, but her section chief told her to ‘revisit the file in light of international developments.’ That’s FBI for ‘we can’t ignore this anymore.’”

“How long?” Arthur asked.

“Years. You know that. Meridian’s US lawyers will file motions until the sun burns out. But the file is open and it’s not closing. The Australian evidence makes it a different case than the one they buried. Cross-border operations, foreign nationals conducting armed operations on allied soil — that’s not a compliance complaint anymore. That’s something the bureau takes to a grand jury.”

“If they don’t get pressured off it again.”

“They might. But the story is public now. That changes the math. Burying a whistleblower complaint is one thing. Burying an active investigation that’s been reported on nationally in a Five Eyes partner country is another.” Another pause. “I’m not promising justice, Arthur. I’m telling you the ground shifted.”

Miro leaned forward. “Helen.”

“Yes.”

“Thank you. For all of it.”

The silence on the line had weight. Arthur could hear Helen breathing, could picture her in the house in Bethesda, the phone against her ear, the kitchen light on.

“You’re my family,” she said. “Both of you. Don’t thank me.”

“Speaking of family business,” Arthur said. “When are we putting the Dorpers on the eastern paddocks?”

Helen laughed — the first real laugh Arthur had heard from her in weeks. “I was wondering when you’d bring that up. Miro, how soon can you start?”

Miro had been working on this for months, Arthur knew. The quiet conversations on the verandah after dinner, the figures Miro had scratched out on the back of supply lists, the calls to breeders in South Australia. Ten years he’d been thinking about Dorpers on those eastern paddocks. The fencing was already there. The water was good. The grazing was underutilized because Ted had never had the capital or the will to diversify, and Helen’s father before him had been a cattle man who didn’t see the point of sheep.

“I’ve talked to a breeder outside Port Augusta,” Miro said. “He can truck sixty head up in about six weeks. The eastern paddocks need some fencing work — new gates, a couple of water points reconnected. Two weeks to get it ready.” He paused. “I’ve got the numbers. Cost per head, feed projections, water requirements, estimated return in the first year. It’s on paper.”

“Send it to me,” Helen said. “I want to see it this week.”

“You’ll have it tomorrow.”

Arthur looked at Miro. In the light from the kitchen, the man’s face was the same weathered landscape it always was — but something underneath had shifted. Not a smile, exactly. Something quieter and older than a smile. Twenty years of waiting, and now close enough to touch it.

“We’ll make it work,” Arthur said.

“I know we will,” Miro said. He picked up his tea.

Helen said goodnight. The line went quiet. The stars turned overhead and the windmill creaked and Lucky’s breathing came slow and steady from inside the house.

Miro went to bed. Arthur sat on the verandah with the laptop and the light from the screen and the sound of Lucky sleeping through the open door behind him.

Helen —

I’m sitting on the verandah and everyone is accounted for and the dog is snoring and I am trying to figure out how to say what I want to say without making it sound like a speech.

Miro is extraordinary. I know you know that. But watching him today — hearing him talk about the Dorpers like a man who’s been carrying a blueprint in his head for ten years and can finally unfold it — I don’t think I understood until now what you gave him when you made that call. He was loyal and competent and tireless before, but he was working someone else’s land for someone else’s reasons. He’s different now. He’s building something.

I came here to hide. You know that and I know that and there's no point pretending otherwise. I thought I'd stay a few months and the world would sort itself out and I'd go back to whatever was left of a life in Virginia. That's not what happened. What happened is Ted drove me out to Reg's place on the first supply run and I sat in that stone house and drank tea with an old man who'd been alone on his piece of ground for forty years and I thought: this is real. Everything I left behind was an argument about paper. This is real.

I'm not going back. I think you already know that. I think you knew it before I did.

Tell me about your week. Not the case — I know about the case. Tell me about the garden and the neighbor's dog and whatever book you're reading. I want to hear about your ordinary life because it matters to me and because I think we're going to be writing these emails for a long time and I'd rather they were about living than about fighting.

— A

He sent it and closed the laptop and sat in the dark. The Southern Cross was up, tilted over the western ranges, and the Milky Way ran north to south in a band so thick it looked like dust on the sky. He'd learned the constellations from Miro, sitting in this chair, on nights like this. The sky that had been alien was now the one he looked for.

The reply came twenty minutes later.

Arthur —

The garden is overwatered because I keep forgetting to adjust the timer. The neighbor's dog ate my doormat. I'm reading a biography of Eleanor Roosevelt that I bought at a used bookstore on Wisconsin Avenue and it's making me feel like an underachiever.

I knew you weren't coming back. I think I knew it the first time you wrote to me about Miro's cooking.

Send me his Dorpers plan. I want to read it while I'm drinking my coffee tomorrow morning like a woman who owns a sheep operation in Central Australia, which apparently I now do.

Sleep well. Hug Lucky for me. And stop sitting on the verandah in the dark worrying you're not happy. You're allowed.

— H

Arthur read it twice. He closed the laptop and went inside. Lucky was on the blanket beside the bed, his bandaged leg stretched out, his breathing slow and even. Arthur knelt beside him and put his hand on the dog's side and felt the ribs rise and fall.

"Helen says hello," he said.

Lucky's tail moved once against the blanket. Arthur got into bed and turned off the light and the homestead was quiet and dark and outside the stars turned over the country he'd come to by accident and chosen to keep.

Chapter 20 — The Road

Arthur loaded the truck in the early light. Fuel drums in the tray, fencing wire, a box of groceries for Reg, seed catalogs June had ordered through Crowley's, a chess book for Lily that Helen had mailed from a shop in Bethesda. He checked the tie-downs and the water and the spare and walked back to the verandah where Miro was finishing his tea.

"Ready?" Arthur said.

"When you are."

Lucky came off the verandah without being called. He crossed the yard at a trot — not quite even, the right hindquarter still carrying a memory of the bullet, but strong, purposeful, a dog who knew what a loaded truck meant. He jumped into the tray and stood with his front paws on the rail and his nose into the wind that wasn't blowing yet and waited.

Miro climbed into the passenger seat. Arthur got behind the wheel and started the engine and pulled onto the track heading north. The same track Ted had driven the first time, with Arthur beside him and the country stretching out in every direction and none of it making sense. That was months ago. It felt like years. It felt like someone else.

The morning was cool and clear. The ranges sat on the western horizon, dark blue against the paling sky. The track ran straight through the red country — spinifex, mulga scrub, the occasional ghost gum standing white against the red earth. Arthur drove and Miro sat with his arm on the window frame and neither of them talked and the engine was steady and the road unwound ahead of them.

They passed the eastern paddocks twenty minutes out.

"Stop," Miro said.

Arthur pulled over. The new fencing caught the early light — steel posts, tight wire, the gates Miro had hung himself over two weekends. Behind the fence, five Dorpers grazed in a loose cluster on the red ground. White bodies against the red earth, their heads down, working through the scrub grass with the unhurried efficiency of animals that belonged exactly where they were.

Miro got out and leaned on the fence and watched them. Arthur had seen this before — Miro standing at the fence in the early mornings or the late afternoons, counting them, studying the grazing pattern, checking the water points. Ten years of thinking and two weeks of building, and now five sheep on the ground — an advance handful the breeder had sent up with another load heading north — and sixty more coming in a month. The breeder in Port Augusta had confirmed the truck date last week. Helen had approved the numbers the morning after Miro sent them.

Lucky dropped from the tray.

He went through the gate before Arthur could call him — low, fast, the limp visible but not slowing him. He swung wide around the small mob and came in from the east, moving the Dorpers gently toward the water point, his body close to the ground, his instinct for the stock undiminished. The sheep shifted without alarm. They moved where the dog told them to move, and Lucky held them there, his bad leg carrying him, his focus absolute.

Miro watched. Arthur watched Miro.

“He’s got the touch,” Miro said.

“He does.”

Lucky held the mob for a few seconds longer, then broke off and trotted back to the gate, panting, the right leg slightly short. He looked up at Arthur with his tongue out and his ears forward and his whole body saying *that’s my job and I did it*.

Arthur rubbed his head. “Good dog.”

They got back in the truck and drove north.

The Warners’ place looked different. Not the house — the house was the same tin roof and tank stand and chook enclosure — but the feel of it. The yard was tidy. The bore pump hummed steadily. Matt had mended the section of fence the operatives had cut for access and added a gate with a new lock. Small changes, but deliberate. The look of people who intended to stay.

Lily was in the yard when the truck pulled up. She saw Lucky in the tray and ran. Lucky saw her and his tail started going and he jumped down before the truck stopped and Lily was on her knees in the dirt with her arms around his neck, her face buried in his fur, and the dog stood still and let her hold him.

“His leg,” she said, pulling back to look. “Is it better?”

“Getting there,” Arthur said. “He mustered five Dorpers this morning.”

“Dorpers.” She said the word carefully, testing it. “Are they yours?”

“Miro’s. Ours. The station’s.”

Matt came out of the shed wiping his hands. Sarah followed from the house with Sam, who was carrying a plate of something wrapped in foil. They unloaded the groceries and the chess book and drank tea standing in the yard and Matt told Arthur about the new gate and Sarah mentioned that the School of the Air lessons — the remote schooling the kids did by radio — were going well and Sam asked if Miro would take them up again sometime and Miro said anytime and Lily sat in the dirt with Lucky and didn’t say much and didn’t need to.

They stayed half an hour. When they left, Lily waved from the yard with her hand on Lucky’s head, and Lucky watched the truck until Arthur called him and he jumped in the tray and stood at the rail and watched her back until the dust took her.

June was in the garden.

Her left arm was still in a sling — weeks yet before the shoulder was right — but she was kneeling in the dirt beside the drip line, her good hand pulling weeds from between the labeled beds with a focused precision that was not going to let a bullet interfere with her tomatoes.

Don saw the truck first. He came around from the shed and shook Arthur’s hand and shook Miro’s hand and took the seed catalogs and the box of supplies and carried them inside without fuss. June stood up slowly, holding her shoulder, and walked to the verandah.

“Sit,” she said. “I’ll put the kettle on.”

“I’ll do it,” Don said from inside.

June looked at Arthur. “He won’t let me lift anything heavier than a teacup. I told him the doctor said I could resume normal activity in two weeks. He said the doctor hasn’t met me.”

They sat on the Patersons’ verandah — smaller than the homestead’s, neater, June’s garden stretching away in its careful rows — and drank tea and June asked about the Dorpers and Miro told her about the fencing and the water points and the sixty head coming from Port Augusta and June listened and nodded and Arthur could see her filing it all — every number, every detail — in the organized chambers of a mind that had been keeping track of the world long before anyone asked her to.

“I’m glad,” she said when Miro finished. “It’s time the station does something new.”

Don came out with biscuits and sat beside June and the four of them looked out at the garden and the paddocks beyond it and the country running away to the horizon and nobody mentioned the bullet holes or the story or the investigation or any of it. There was nothing to mention. It was behind them, grinding through courts and newsrooms and government offices, and in front of them was a garden with labeled beds and a drip system and June, who was going to have tomatoes by Christmas whether her shoulder agreed or not.

Reg was standing in the yard when they pulled up.

Arthur hadn’t called ahead — he never did for Reg, and Reg never seemed to need warning. The old man was just there, standing by the single tree in the bare yard in front of the stone house, his hat on, his hands at his sides. As if he’d been waiting. As if he’d heard the engine from twenty kilometers out and had come to stand in the exact spot where he always stood when visitors arrived.

Lucky jumped down and went to him. Reg put his hand on the dog's head — a slow, deliberate gesture, his knuckles swollen with age — and Lucky stood beside him and they both watched the truck settle in the yard.

"Kettle's on," Reg said.

They sat inside. The same kitchen, the same table, the same photo on the wall — two young men by a truck, squinting into the sun. Ted and Reg. Arthur had looked at that photo on his first visit and not known who they were. Now he knew everything about them, and the photo was different because he was different, and the two men squinting into the sun were not strangers anymore but the foundation of everything he'd found here.

Reg poured the tea. His hands were steady. He set the cups down and sat in his chair and looked at Miro.

"How are the sheep?"

"Five on the ground. Sixty more in a month."

Reg nodded. He picked up his tea and held it and looked at the cup. "Ted wanted those sheep. Talked about it for years. Said the eastern paddocks were wasted on cattle — wrong grass, wrong water, wrong thinking." He paused. "Couldn't get Jack to listen. And after Jack died, couldn't get the money together. But he wanted them."

Arthur looked at Miro. Miro was looking at Reg. The two men who had known Ted longest, sitting in the kitchen where Ted had sat hundreds of times, the photo on the wall watching them.

"He'd have been out there every morning," Reg said. "Counting them. Checking the fences. Telling you what you were doing wrong."

Miro smiled. "He would have."

"Come see them," Arthur said. "Anytime. We'll drive you out or we can fly you."

Reg looked at him. The old face, weathered stone, the eyes clear and sharp. "I would like that."

They finished their tea and walked outside. The afternoon was warm and the light was turning gold on the stone walls and the single tree threw its shadow across the bare yard. Reg stood at the truck while Miro checked the tie-downs.

“Thank you for the tea,” Arthur said.

Reg nodded. He put his hand on the truck door — not shaking hands, not saying goodbye, just touching the metal for a moment, the way you touch something solid to confirm it’s there.

They drove away. Arthur watched in the mirror as Reg stood in the yard, his hat on, his hands at his sides, the stone house behind him and the single tree beside him and the red country stretching away in every direction. Still there. Still standing.

Rennie’s vehicle and Lowe’s white hatchback were parked in the yard when they got home. Rennie was on the verandah in one of the chairs with a mug of tea that he appeared to have made himself. Lowe was beside him with her briefcase open on her lap, but the briefcase was closed by the time Arthur climbed the steps, and whatever she’d been working on could wait.

“Helped ourselves,” Rennie said. “Hope you don’t mind.”

“We’d mind if you didn’t,” Miro said.

Arthur made a fresh pot and brought it out and the four of them sat on the verandah in the late light. Lucky settled on the boards between Arthur’s chair and Miro’s, his chin on his paws, his eyes half closed.

“Charges filed this week,” Lowe said. She said it like weather — a fact, not a drama. “All five operatives. Assault, trespass, weapons offences, destruction of pastoral infrastructure. The one with the broken wrist is talking.”

“Talking how?” Arthur asked.

“Talking for a reduced sentence. He’s given us the chain of command — who hired them, who briefed them, who funded the operation. It runs through Dryden’s Melbourne office to Eastmark’s board. The commissioner’s investigators are building the corporate case now.”

“Deep pockets,” Rennie said.

“Deep pockets,” Lowe agreed. “They’ll fight every step. Delay, deny, appeal. But the investigation is open and it’s widening and the media won’t let it disappear.” She paused. “It’s satisfying to watch. I’ll say that.”

“Business good?” Arthur asked.

Lowe glanced at him. “I’ve had more inquiries since the story ran than in the previous two years. Three pastoral families in the Pilbara called last week — they’d seen the story. A grazier in Queensland. Two indigenous land councils.” She looked at her briefcase. “I’m going to need a bigger office.”

Rennie grinned. “Don’t forget us when you’re famous.”

“I was never going to be famous, Dave. I was going to be competent in a small office on Bath Street. This is —” She stopped. “This is different.”

They talked until the light started going. Rennie and Lowe left together — Rennie’s vehicle leading, Lowe’s hatchback behind, the dust rising on the track and the headlights coming on as the dusk settled. Arthur watched them go. Two people who had come into the story sideways — a country cop who didn’t walk away and a solicitor who filed the right motions at the right time — and were now part of it permanently. Part of him. Part of all of it.

He turned from the track and looked at the homestead wall.

The bullet holes were still there. Not just the first one — the one from the night probe, at chest height beside the front door, the raw timber darkened now at the edges. But the others too, from the stand. Pocked timber across the verandah posts and the wall boards, a cluster near the shattered window that Don had helped replace, two more near the corner where Lucky had gone around. They hadn’t been filled or sanded or painted. They were part of the house now. Part of what the house meant. Arthur looked at them and thought about the people who had stood behind this wall and in front of it and on the roof above it, and the holes in the timber were not damage. They were the record of what a family could do when the only choices left were to stand or to leave, and nobody left.

Miro came out with two mugs. He handed one to Arthur and sat down.

The stars came up. The windmill creaked in a breeze that had arrived from the south, carrying the smell of the scrub and the faint sweetness of the bore water and the dry red dust that Arthur had stopped noticing months ago because it was the smell of home.

Arthur opened the laptop. One new email.

Arthur and Miro —

I've booked the flight. Arriving Alice Springs December 19. Two weeks. I'm staying through New Year's if you can stand me that long. I want to see the Dorpers. I want to meet Lowe. I want to meet Reg. I want to sit on your verandah and drink tea and do absolutely nothing for as many consecutive hours as the human body can tolerate.

I've never had a Christmas in summer. I haven't been to the station since Dad's funeral, and that was four years ago and I was too broken to see it properly. It's time.

Also I'm bringing Lucky a present but I'm not telling you what it is because Miro will tell me it's impractical and you'll tell me it's too expensive and I don't care about either of those things.

Two weeks.

— H

Arthur turned the laptop so Miro could read it. Miro leaned forward, his face lit by the screen. He read it and sat back and the expression on his face was one Arthur had never seen before — not the weathered composure, not the quiet amusement, but something unguarded and open, the look of twenty years on a piece of ground that had never quite been his, and now the owner was coming to stand on it with him.

"Two weeks," Miro said.

"Two weeks."

"I'll get the spare room sorted. And the eastern fence needs a proper gate before she sees it — the temporary one looks like I built it in the dark."

"You did build it in the dark."

“That’s not the point.” Miro picked up his tea. “She’ll want to see everything. The paddocks, the bores, the route. All of it.”

“She will.”

“Good.” Miro drank his tea. The windmill creaked. The stars turned slowly overhead — the Southern Cross tilted above the western ranges, the Milky Way running north to south, the sky that Arthur had learned to read from this chair, on nights like this, with this man beside him.

Lucky was lying between their chairs. His bandaged leg was stretched out, the limp that would fade in another week or two, the muscle rebuilding itself the way everything out here rebuilt itself — slowly, without complaint, because that was what the country required. His eyes were closed and his breathing was slow and his ears moved when Arthur shifted in his chair, tracking him even in sleep.

“She’s going to love it,” Arthur said.

Miro looked out at the dark. The paddocks, the fences, the country he’d worked for twenty years and was now building into something new. The five Dorpers asleep somewhere on the eastern paddock, sixty more coming, the business plan that had lived in his head for a decade now alive on paper and approved and in motion.

“Yeah,” Miro said. “She will.”

They sat in the quiet. The stars, the windmill, the dog between them. Arthur reached down and scratched behind Lucky’s ear. A moment later, Miro’s hand came down on the other side, fingers finding the other ear, and Lucky sighed and pressed his head up into both hands and his tail moved once against the boards.

The homestead was dark and still. The bullet holes in the timber wall caught no light. The track stretched north toward the town and the families and the country that had taken him in, and south toward the ranges and the road to Alice Springs and the world beyond it that was grinding slowly toward something that might, in time, look like justice.

Arthur didn't need it to be tonight. He had the verandah. He had the dog. He had the man beside him and the woman arriving in two weeks and the land under his feet and the stars over his head.

He was home.